The cortical column as a tuned receiver: a network mechanism for temporal-interference stimulation

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Abstract

Temporal-interference (TI) stimulation can act on neural populations only if three stages work in series: the kilohertz field must reach a nonlinear membrane (access), the membrane must generate the difference frequency absent from the field (detection), and the circuit must amplify that weak component (amplification). We build a mesoscale model of all three stages. Following single-neuron TI models that locate rectification in nodes and the axon initial segment, we represent access by a short effective membrane time. We analyze detection and amplification in a Jansen–Rit column, an exact mean field of quadratic integrate-and-fire neurons, and its spiking network. For weak fields the detector is quadratic: the beat is proportional to the product of the local carrier amplitudes, and a steady operating-point shift to their summed squares. A static rate curve and the exact mean field give the same product law; the mean field adds frequency dependence when the membrane is slow relative to the input. Near a Hopf bifurcation the circuit amplifies the beat as the inverse of the modal damping; with the Jansen–Rit operating point held fixed, synaptic coupling sets this gain independently of detection. The amplified response appears mainly in envelope-locked timing, with little change in mean rate. At stronger fields the steady shift alone can drive a gamma circuit across its oscillation threshold, and an unmodulated carrier of equal power does the same. The model expresses TI efficacy as the product of three separately measurable factors. For weak fields, dose follows the product of carrier amplitudes rather than the envelope minimum. Under uniform conductivity, access, and detection, the steady drive has its largest magnitude at compartment boundaries. TI shares its circuit amplifier with direct low-frequency stimulation. Carrier sweeps, independent-amplitude tests, beat sweeps across states, and equal-power controls each test one stage.

Keywords: temporal interference; non-invasive neuromodulation; transcranial stimulation; neural mass model; amplitude demodulation; Hopf bifurcation; cross-frequency coupling; criticality.

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1 Introduction

Temporal-interference (TI) stimulation was proposed to reach deep brain targets while reducing stimulation of surrounding tissue [1]. It applies two sinusoids at f_1 and $f_2 = f_1 + \Delta f$ through separate electrode pairs, typically with $f_1 \sim 1$–2 kHz and $\Delta f \sim 1$–100 Hz. Where the fields overlap, their superposition is an amplitude-modulated (AM) signal with an envelope at Δf. Electrode currents can steer the region of largest envelope modulation. Whether this also localizes the neural response depends on how neurons transduce the waveform.

The difference frequency is absent from the input itself:

$$s(t) = \varepsilon_1 \cos(\omega_1 t) + \varepsilon_2 \cos(\omega_2 t), \qquad \omega_{1,2} = 2\pi f_{1,2}, \quad \Omega = \omega_2 - \omega_1 = 2\pi\,\Delta f. \tag{1}$$

Here $s(t)$ is the local membrane polarization, t is time, and $\varepsilon_{1,2}$ are its tone amplitudes in mV (related to the applied field in §2.2), Ω is the beat angular frequency, and $f_c = (f_1 + f_2)/2$ is the carrier frequency. The spectrum contains only the two applied lines (Fig. 4). A linear, time-invariant system can attenuate or phase-shift them but cannot create a new one. Passive membrane filtering therefore cannot demodulate TI [2]; a nonlinear element must mix the carriers into the low-frequency band, as in AM reception [3].

The mechanism therefore has distinct physical requirements (Fig. 1). *Access* is the conversion of the extracellular field into local membrane polarization. *Detection*, or demodulation, is the nonlinear generation of the difference-frequency component from those polarizations. *Amplification* is the response of the neuron and its recurrent circuit to the generated component. The same cellular structures can contribute to more than one stage, but strong coupling, effective mixing, and large resonant gain are different properties.

Somatic charging attenuates kHz fields, with the response also depending on cable geometry and field coupling [4, 5]. Esmaeilpour et al. [6] already modeled TI sensitivity using a short, axon-like membrane time. Cohen et al.'s conducting periaxonal space separates nodal and internodal voltage dynamics and supports saltatory conduction [7]; nodes and the sodium-channel-rich axon initial segment (AIS) are candidate access sites [8]. We represent this route by a short effective membrane time, whose field-to-polarization transfer requires calibration. Table 3 distinguishes measured and assumed time scales.

Detection requires that this polarization encounter a nonlinearity. Mirzakhalili et al. [2] demonstrated subthreshold nodal mixing in a modified McIntyre–Richardson–Grill (MRG) myelinated-axon model with Hodgkin–Huxley ion-channel dynamics. Cortical-neuron models also show axonal excitation and conduction block under stronger fields [9]. Luff et al. [10] directly observed subthreshold difference-frequency oscillations in individual neurons, including carriers near 5 kHz. Mixing persisted during synaptic blockade but was suppressed by blocking tetrodotoxin-sensitive sodium channels. These measurements establish a cellular detector without locating it within a specific compartment. In a population description, smooth cellular contributions can be combined into an effective second-order response; a static rate curve realizes that response through its curvature.

Amplification determines whether the generated beat appreciably changes activity. Intrinsic currents, including the hyperpolarization-activated current I_h and M-type potassium current I_M, can tune a single neuron [11], as in the cell- and state-dependent hippocampal TI responses of de Palma Aristides et al. [12]. Recurrent excitatory–inhibitory circuits supply another resonance [13, 14, 15]. In slices, pyramidal and parvalbumin (PV) neurons respond differently, and most pyramidal TI responses vanish under synaptic blockade [16]; simulations also find network mediation [17, 6]. Reviews summarize these mechanisms [18, 19]. At human-comparable fields, primate recordings show weaker effects than direct low-frequency stimulation, expressed mainly in spike timing rather than mean rate [20]. These findings motivate a model that separates the cellular beat source from its recurrent amplification.

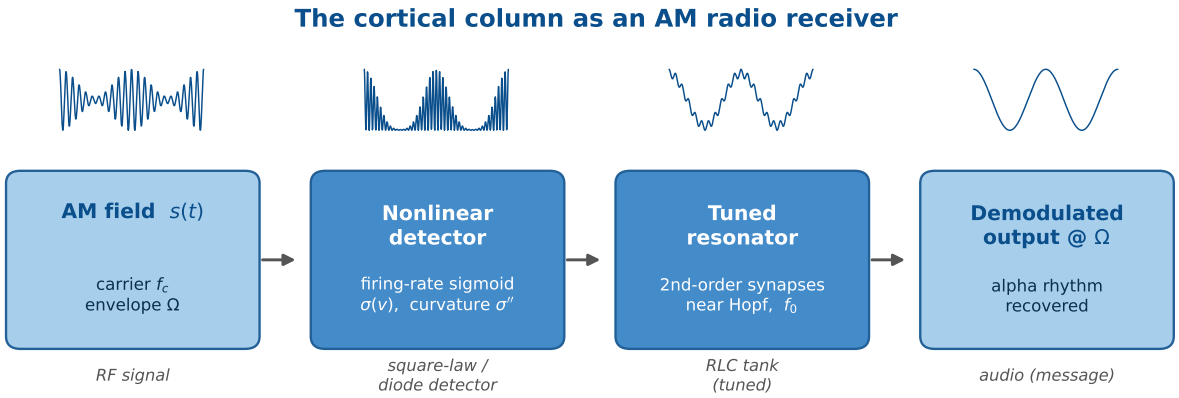


Figure 1: The cortical column as a tuned receiver. Access converts the applied field into the local polarization entering the detector. The nonlinear detector generates the beat at angular frequency Ω from a carrier near f_c; a recurrent network amplifies it near its natural frequency f_0. The diagram shows the static-sigmoid realization. In a conventional AM receiver, the tuned circuit selects the carrier before detection [3]; here the resonator selects the low-frequency output. The laminar extension also has a carrier-selective stage (§E.2).

We focus on weak stimulation-induced changes around ongoing activity, which may already include spiking. Direct carrier-evoked spiking and conduction block [21, 22, 23] lie outside this expansion; the finite-amplitude network examples are identified separately.

We build a mesoscale model separating access, detection, and amplification in series. A Jansen–Rit column, an exact quadratic integrate-and-fire (QIF) mean field, and its spiking network connect the weak-input product law to resonant gain, timing modulation, and the equal-power carrier control; a laminar extension adds two resonant bands at low carriers. Fast relaxation recovers a static population transfer with dynamic synapses, while slower membranes require a frequency-dependent mixing coefficient. Related neural-mass models describe endogenous cross-frequency coupling and nested amplitude modulation [24, 25]; an external field additionally requires field-to-cell access. Each stage has a separate test: carrier sweeps of local polarization test access, independent variation of the carrier amplitudes tests detection, and beat sweeps across states test amplification. Equal-power unmodulated-carrier controls distinguish the steady shift from the beat response.

2 Theory

2.1 Population transfer and the slow-synapse limit

A neural mass model describes a population through averaged variables [26, 27]. In the Jansen–Rit (JR) family, a linear synaptic filter converts presynaptic firing rate $r(t)$ into postsynaptic potential $u_{\mathrm{PSP}}(t)$:

$$\ddot{u}_{\mathrm{PSP}} + 2a\dot{u}_{\mathrm{PSP}} + a^2 u_{\mathrm{PSP}} = Aa\, r(t),$$

with inverse synaptic time a (s^{-1}) and PSP gain A (mV); inhibitory synapses use b and B in the same respective units. Summed postsynaptic potentials give the mean input v, which a static transfer curve converts to firing rate [28],

$$\sigma(v) = \frac{2e_0}{1 + e^{\rho(v_0 - v)}}. \tag{2}$$

Here $2e_0$ is the maximum rate, v_0 the inflection voltage, and ρ the inverse voltage scale (s^{-1}, mV, and mV^{-1}, respectively). Primes denote derivatives with respect to voltage. Nonzero curvature

makes this curve a mixer, while its slope sets the local gain of the recurrent circuit.

For a synapse from population Y to X, the resulting first-generation neural mass model (NMM1) equations are [26]

$$\hat{L}_{X\leftarrow Y}[u_{X\leftarrow Y}] = C_{X\leftarrow Y}\, r_Y, \qquad v_X = \Lambda[E] + \sum_{Y:\, C_{X\leftarrow Y}\neq 0} u_{X\leftarrow Y}, \qquad r_X = \sigma(v_X). \tag{3}$$

The operator $\hat{L}$ is the inverse synaptic filter, $u_{X\leftarrow Y}$ its postsynaptic potential, $C_{X\leftarrow Y}$ the connectivity, and $\Lambda[E]$ the direct polarization caused by the applied field E (V/m). The rates r_X, r_Y are in s^{-1}, the potentials $v_X, u_{X\leftarrow Y}$ in mV, and the pathway weights $C_{X\leftarrow Y}$ dimensionless. This field contribution enters alongside the synaptic potentials, without first passing through a synapse.

The corresponding population nonlinearity can be derived for all-to-all coupled QIF neurons with Lorentzian-distributed excitabilities. Their exact Montbrió–Pazó–Roxin (MPR) mean field evolves the firing rate r and mean voltage v [29]; adding dynamic synapses gives NMM2 [30, 31]. With normalized time $\tilde{t} = t/\tau_m$ and rate $\tilde{r} = \tau_m r$, where τ_m is the membrane time,

$$\frac{\mathrm{d}\tilde{r}}{\mathrm{d}\tilde{t}} = \frac{\Delta}{\pi} + 2\tilde{r}\, v, \qquad \frac{\mathrm{d}v}{\mathrm{d}\tilde{t}} = v^2 + \bar{\eta} - \pi^2\tilde{r}^2 + I(\tilde{t}), \tag{4}$$

where $\bar{\eta}$ is the mean excitability, $\Delta > 0$ its half-width, and $I(\tilde{t})$ the normalized input, including recurrent drive when present. The reduced variables are dimensionless; r without a tilde denotes physical firing rate. For a constant total drive $Q = \bar{\eta} + I$, setting both derivatives to zero gives $v = -\Delta/(2\pi\tilde{r})$ and

$$\tilde{r} = F(Q) = \frac{1}{\pi}\sqrt{\frac{Q + \sqrt{Q^2 + \Delta^2}}{2}}. \tag{5}$$

Primes on F denote derivatives with respect to the total drive Q. Its curvature combines threshold recruitment and the concave rate increase of active cells (App. B.2). This nonlinear curve exists without recurrent coupling. It has an inflection at $Q = \Delta/\sqrt{3}$ and an unbounded concave rise, unlike the saturating JR sigmoid.

If the population relaxes to this equilibrium faster than synaptic inputs change, NMM2 reduces to a static rate map with dynamic synapses [30, 31]. Restoring the membrane time τ_m and physical firing rate, a second-order synapse with time constant τ_s obeys

$$r(t) \simeq \frac{F(Q(t))}{\tau_m}, \qquad \tau_s^2\ddot{r}_{\mathrm{syn}} + 2\tau_s\dot{r}_{\mathrm{syn}} + r_{\mathrm{syn}} = r(t), \tag{6}$$

where r_{syn} is the filtered rate entering the recurrent drive in Q, with the original coupling normalization retained. This is the slow-synapse limit: shortening the effective membrane time makes the transfer appear static while the network retains its synaptic dynamics. The relevant separation is between the population relaxation time τ_{rel} and τ_s. Applying the same static map directly to a carrier of angular frequency ω_c requires the stronger condition $\omega_c\tau_{\mathrm{rel}} \ll 1$. A population can therefore be quasistatic for its synaptic inputs yet dynamic for a kHz carrier.

The transfer curve summarizes cellular nonlinearities within this regime. Its curvature combines their leading contributions to mixing; its slope converts a slow input into a rate change and enters recurrent gain. QIF supplies a derived realization through its spike-generating quadratic and excitability distribution. The generic weak-input mixing law does not require identifying each channel's contribution, although the coefficient and its frequency dependence are model-specific. Outside the static limit these contributions belong to a dynamic input–output functional. Section 2.3 calculates this response for QIF and recovers Eq. (5) in the adiabatic limit.

The JR column couples pyramidal, excitatory-interneuron, and inhibitory-interneuron populations, with field input to the pyramidal sigmoid and local field potential (LFP) proxy $v = y_1 - y_2$, where

y_1 and y_2 are the excitatory and inhibitory postsynaptic potentials onto the pyramidal population. Its external input rate is p (s^{-1}), and C is the dimensionless connectivity scale (App. B). The laminar extension (LaNMM) [24, 32] adds coupled alpha and gamma circuits: deep pyramidal P_1, spiny-stellate (SS), and somatostatin (SST) populations, and a superficial pyramidal P_2/PV circuit. These models retain dynamic synapses and static rate curves; NMM2 and its spiking realization retain membrane dynamics as well. The recurrent circuit can resonate without intrinsic cellular resonance [13, 14]; in the fast-membrane limit only its synaptic modes remain, and resonances requiring finite membrane dynamics need not persist.

Figure 2 locates the field input, nonlinear detector, and recurrent amplifier in the JR and NMM2 circuits.

2.2 From applied field to a squared-envelope beat component

We use the quasistatic electromagnetic approximation for the applied field $E(t)$ (V/m), neglecting propagation and induction. This does not make membrane charging instantaneous. Let $s(t)$ be the polarization (mV) after the cellular access response; the static population model reads

$$r(t) = \sigma(v(t) + s(t)), \qquad E(t) = E_1 \cos \omega_1 t + E_2 \cos \omega_2 t. \tag{7}$$

The field acts directly on soma, dendrites, AIS, nodes, and terminals, each with its own coupling and frequency response. In a reduced description, their contributions to the effective input are represented by parallel entry points. For nearby carriers centered at $\omega_c = 2\pi f_c$,

$$s(t) \simeq \sum_k \boldsymbol{\lambda}_f^k(\omega_c) \cdot \mathbf{E}(t), \qquad \boldsymbol{\lambda}_f^k(\omega) = \boldsymbol{\lambda}_0^k \, |H_k(\omega)|, \tag{8}$$

where $\boldsymbol{\lambda}_0^k$ is the static polarization vector of compartment k (a length), and H_k its access filter [26, 33]. Equation (8) uses amplitude gains and assumes aligned compartment phases; a general sum requires the complex transfers, including their relative phases. The passive compartment equations in App. B.1 give both factors from the same voltage response. The static gain and its frequency dependence belong to this one response. A model driven by post-coupling polarization and a model driven by current through its own membrane equation must therefore count that filtering once.

For a dominant entry point, define $\lambda_f(\omega) = \lambda_0 |H(\omega)|$. Then $\varepsilon_j = \lambda_f(\omega_j) E_j$ denotes the polarization reaching the nonlinearity. The direct-coupling calculation takes $\lambda_f \approx \lambda_0$ to isolate mixing and recurrent amplification; §2.8 restores frequency-dependent access. Fast axonal access motivates this limit; compartment anatomy enters the reduced model through the coupling and response time, which must be calibrated for the preparation.

Expanding σ about a field-free operating voltage v^* (mV) (a Volterra/Taylor expansion, as in [25]) gives $\sigma(v^* + s) \approx \sigma(v^*) + \sigma'(v^*)\, s + \frac{1}{2}\sigma''(v^*)\, s^2 + \dots$ The truncation requires $|s| \ll 1/\rho \approx 1.8$ mV and a nonzero second derivative for quadratic mixing to be leading. Larger excursions require the full transfer curve. The linear term preserves the two input frequencies. The quadratic cross term generates their difference through the identity $2 \cos \omega_1 t \cos \omega_2 t = \cos \Omega t + \cos(\omega_1 + \omega_2) t$. Low-pass synaptic filtering suppresses the fast terms after mixing; membrane filtering, when retained, already shapes the carrier polarization. We isolate the slow source by a carrier average, before applying its frequency-dependent network gain (§2.7). The fast $\cos^2 \omega_j t$ terms average to $\frac{1}{2}$ and the sum-frequency term to zero:

$$\langle \sigma(v^* + s) \rangle_c = \sigma(v^*) + \tfrac{1}{4}\sigma''(v^*)\,(\varepsilon_1^2 + \varepsilon_2^2) + \tfrac{1}{2}\sigma''(v^*)\,\varepsilon_1 \varepsilon_2 \cos \Omega t + O(\varepsilon^4), \tag{9}$$

so a line appears at exactly the envelope frequency Ω, with amplitude

$$Y_\Omega \simeq \tfrac{1}{2}\, \sigma''(v^*)\, \varepsilon_1 \varepsilon_2, \tag{10}$$

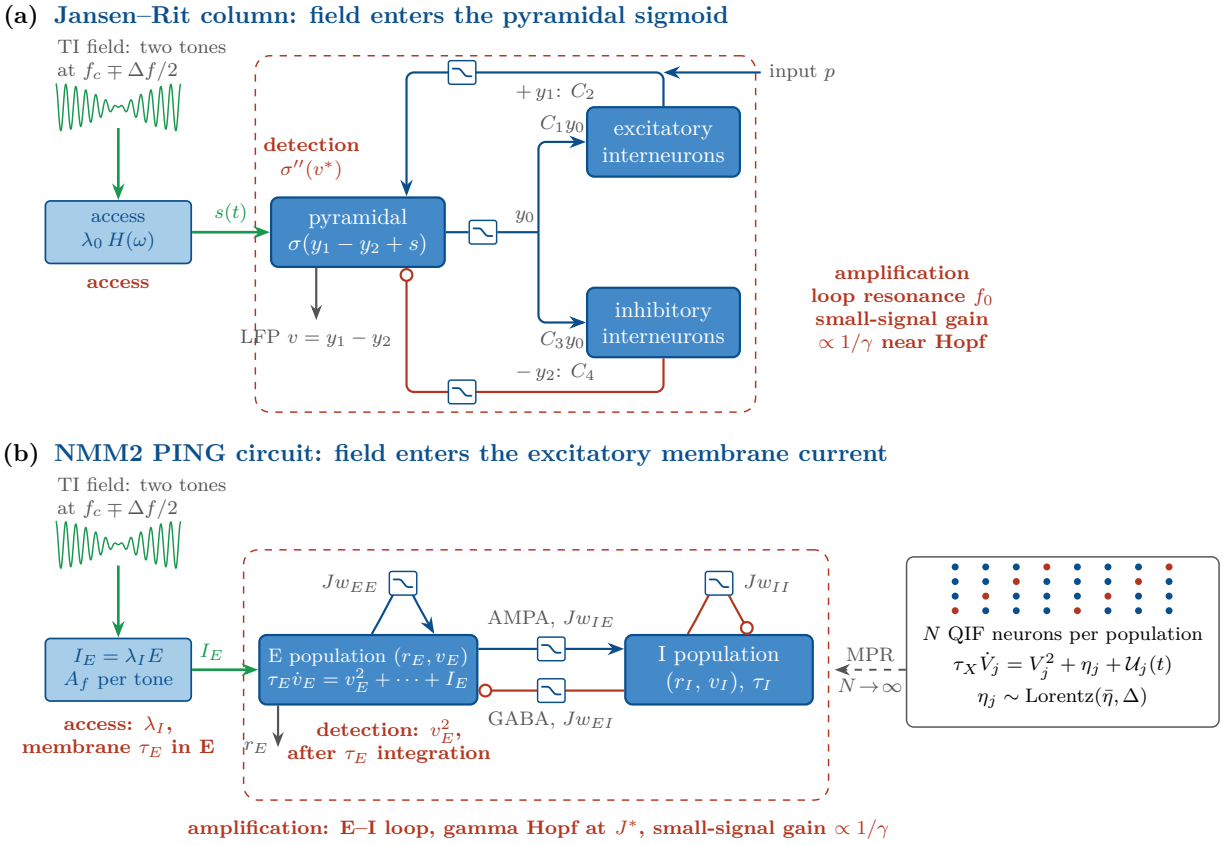


Figure 2: Where the TI field enters each model. Both panels show the same three stages, with each filter counted once. Access converts the two-tone field into the input that reaches the nonlinearity; detection generates the beat; the recurrent circuit amplifies it. Dashed outlines mark the recurrent amplifier, whose small-signal gain grows as the inverse modal damping $1/\gamma$ near a Hopf bifurcation; f_0 is the mode's frequency. The low-pass symbol on each synaptic arrow marks a second-order low-pass filter (excitatory h_e and inhibitory h_i in a; AMPA, τ_a, and GABA, τ_g, in b) acting after the nonlinearity. These filters attenuate the carrier more strongly than the generated beat and transmit the steady shift into the recurrent loop. *(a)* Jansen–Rit column. Access multiplies the field by the static coupling λ_0 and the access filter $H(\omega)$; the resulting polarization $s(t)$ enters the pyramidal sigmoid, whose curvature $\sigma''(v^*)$ mixes the tones. The pyramidal firing is filtered by the excitatory synaptic kernel h_e (inverse time a, gain A) to give y_0. The interneurons receive $C_1 y_0$ and $C_3 y_0$, respectively, and return the potentials y_1 (through h_e, connectivity C_2) and y_2 (through the inhibitory kernel h_i, inverse time b, gain B, connectivity C_4). The external input is p, and $v = y_1 - y_2$ is the LFP proxy. *(b)* NMM2 PING circuit. The field enters the excitatory voltage equation as the current $I_E = \lambda_I E$, of amplitude A_f per tone; the excitatory membrane, with time constant τ_E, integrates it before the quadratic term v_E^2 mixes the tones. Excitatory (AMPA, τ_a) and inhibitory (GABA, τ_g) synapses with global coupling J and pathway weights w_{XY} (target X, source Y) close a gamma loop with a Hopf bifurcation at J^*. The population equations are the exact Montbrió–Pazó–Roxin (MPR) mean field, in the limit $N \to \infty$, of the network of N quadratic integrate-and-fire neurons at right, with membrane time τ_X for $X \in \{E, I\}$ and $\mathcal{U}_j(t)$ the total synaptic and field input to neuron j; the finite network is simulated directly in §4.10. Blue arrows are excitatory, red circle-ended connections inhibitory, and green arrows carry the applied field input.

Here Y_Ω is the signed rate amplitude before recurrent feedback, in s^{-1}; ε denotes a common small amplitude scale, and $\simeq$ means to leading order in the polarizations, here and in what follows. The same expansion leaves a constant (DC) term, $\frac{1}{4}\sigma''(\varepsilon_1^2 + \varepsilon_2^2)$, which any read-out of the mean rate must include.

For a dynamic cellular response with synaptic input held fixed, define the effective second-order coefficient $\chi^{(2)}$ by the complex beat amplitude Y_Ω,

$$Y_\Omega \simeq \chi^{(2)}(\omega_2, -\omega_1)\, \varepsilon_2 \varepsilon_1, \qquad r_\Omega(t) = \mathrm{Re}\left[Y_\Omega e^{i\Omega t}\right].$$

Here $i^2 = -1$, and $r_\Omega(t)$ is the generated rate component before recurrent feedback. Thus $\chi^{(2)}$ has units $\mathrm{s^{-1}mV^{-2}}$ when its input is polarization and its output is physical rate. With this cosine-amplitude convention, the memoryless limit is $\chi^{(2)} = \sigma''(v^*)/2$. Cellular processes can contribute to the same coefficient, with model-specific frequency and state dependence: weak amplitude permits the expansion but does not remove memory, and symmetry or cancellation can make the quadratic term vanish.

Write $\mathcal{A}(t)$ for the nonnegative envelope of the local two-tone polarization, in mV. The quadratic source follows $\mathcal{A}^2$, whose temporal and spatial maps are derived in §2.5.

Dense perturbative sweeps use an amplitude-modulated (AM) surrogate that matches the leading beat source; its waveform and the two-tone controls are specified in §3.1.

The same quadratic intermodulation generates endogenous AM sidebands from slow and fast inputs [25], or $\omega_0 \pm \Omega$ sidebands when the recovered beat mixes with an intrinsic rhythm ω_0 (Fig. S12b).

Equation (10) carries three predictions, all verified below: the generated beat is quadratic in the drive ($Y_\Omega \propto \varepsilon^2$, square-law detection); it follows the sigmoid curvature ($Y_\Omega \propto \sigma''(v^*)$, hence zero at the inflection $v^* = v_0$); and, *at fixed post-coupling polarization* ε, it is independent of the carrier ω_c. This last prediction needs care: as a function of the *applied* field the response inherits the coupling $\varepsilon = \lambda_f E_0$, with applied amplitude E_0, so the field required for a given effect rises with f_c (§2.8), consistent with the carrier dependence of TI thresholds in [21, 22]. Carrier independence is thus a statement about the recovered beat component at fixed polarization, not about the applied field.

2.3 The exact mean field connects static and dynamic mixing

The adiabatic condition in §2.1 determines whether the static curve describes carrier mixing. Consider an uncoupled MPR population (Eq. (4), membrane time units), with constant drive Q and a weak added current $I_{\mathrm{ac}}\cos(\tilde{\omega}\tilde{t})$. Here $\tilde{\omega} = \omega\tau_m$ is the normalized carrier angular frequency. To second order in I_{ac}, the carrier-averaged shift of $\tilde{r}$ is $I_{\mathrm{ac}}^2\kappa_{\mathrm{DC}}(Q,\tilde{\omega})$, where

$$\kappa_{\mathrm{DC}}(Q,\tilde{\omega}) = \frac{\tilde{r}^*\,[\tilde{\omega}^2 + 3d^2 - \nu^2]}{(d^2+\nu^2)\{[d^2+\nu^2-\tilde{\omega}^2]^2 + 4d^2\tilde{\omega}^2\}}, \qquad \tilde{r}^* = F(Q), \quad d = \frac{\Delta}{\pi\tilde{r}^*}, \quad \nu = 2\pi\tilde{r}^*. \tag{11}$$

The physical rate shift is $I_{\mathrm{ac}}^2\kappa_{\mathrm{DC}}/\tau_m$. The fixed-point eigenvalues in normalized time are $-d \pm i\nu$: d is the relaxation rate and ν the ringing angular frequency, both in membrane-time units; their physical values are d/τ_m and ν/τ_m. The expansion about the fixed point is given in App. B.2. Its limits are

$$\kappa_{\mathrm{DC}}(Q,\tilde{\omega}) \xrightarrow[\tilde{\omega}\to 0]{} \tfrac{1}{4}F''(Q), \qquad \kappa_{\mathrm{DC}}(Q,\tilde{\omega}) \xrightarrow[\tilde{\omega}\gg d,\nu]{} \frac{F'(Q)}{2\tilde{\omega}^2}. \tag{12}$$

In the first limit the population tracks its static curve, whose curvature rectifies the input. In the second, the voltage excursion is approximately $I_{\mathrm{ac}}/\tilde{\omega}$; its square supplies a slow drive that the population reads through F'. Above the inflection of F, these limits have opposite signs and the coefficient vanishes at $\tilde{\omega}_z = \sqrt{\nu^2 - 3d^2}$ (Fig. 10a). The 300 Hz and kHz carriers are on the fast side for the parameters of the pyramidal–interneuron network gamma (PING) circuit used below. That classification is parameter-dependent: a shorter effective membrane time can bring the same physical carrier into the adiabatic regime.

Membrane access is already included in this calculation. The linear voltage response is $H_v(\tilde{\omega}) = (i\tilde{\omega} + d)/[(i\tilde{\omega} + d)^2 + \nu^2]$. Dividing by its squared magnitude gives the mixing coefficient at fixed voltage excursion,

$$\kappa_V(Q,\tilde{\omega}) = \frac{\kappa_{\mathrm{DC}}(Q,\tilde{\omega})}{|H_v(\tilde{\omega})|^2} = \frac{F'(Q)}{2}\,\frac{\tilde{\omega}^2 + 3d^2 - \nu^2}{\tilde{\omega}^2 + d^2}. \tag{13}$$

This coefficient tends to $F'/2$ at high frequency. The $1/\tilde{\omega}^2$ suppression at fixed current comes from $|H_v|^2$, the membrane filtering already represented by Eq. (8); it is not an additional detector filter.

A static curve placed after the same membrane has the same leading carrier roll-off, although its mixing coefficient and sign can differ. The steady-state curvature is $F'' = 4\tilde{r}^*(3d^2 - \nu^2)/(d^2 + \nu^2)^3$, so the inflection occurs at $\nu^2 = 3d^2$.

For nearby fast tones, the quadratic terms in Eq. (4) contribute at different orders: v^2 at ω^{-2}, $\tilde{r}v$ at ω^{-3}, and $\tilde{r}^2$ at ω^{-4}. Table 1 compares the carrier and beat routes to the firing rate for a static curve and a dynamic population with the same membrane access.

stage	static curve, same membrane	dynamic population
point-membrane current → voltage	ω^{-1}	ω^{-1}
voltage → rate, carrier	1	ω^{-1}
current → rate, carrier	ω^{-1}	ω^{-2}
two tones → beat in the rate	$(\omega_1\omega_2)^{-1}$	$(\omega_1\omega_2)^{-1}\times$ const.

Table 1: Fast-carrier scaling with matched point-membrane access, at fixed beat frequency and a nonzero leading mixing coefficient. The dynamic population integrates the carrier once more between voltage and rate; the beat is formed before that step. Prefactors depend on the operating point and beat-frequency susceptibility.

The first row gives the shared membrane factor $1/\omega$. The second converts voltage to rate: a static curve adds its slope, whereas the dynamic rate equation integrates the carrier once more. Combining these stages gives the third-row carrier responses, ω^{-1} and ω^{-2}, respectively.

The beat in the last row is formed before that additional rate integration: static curvature and dynamic v^2 each mix the attenuated voltage, retaining $(\omega_1\omega_2)^{-1}$. Equal exponents do not imply equal amplitudes; mixing and the susceptibility at fixed Ω determine the prefactors. For the uncoupled carrier-averaged response, κ_V in Eq. (13) tends to $F'/2$, but is not the full finite-Ω network prefactor. Thus the dynamic rate attenuates the carrier twice while forming the beat between those stages.

2.4 Detector laws and harmonic signatures

A neural response proportional to the squared envelope is not equivalent to one proportional to the envelope. A detector implements some transduction $T(\mathcal{A})$ of the local envelope $\mathcal{A}(t)$, and the two laws predict different amplitude scaling, harmonic content and spatial weighting.

For a narrowband field $s(t) = \mathcal{A}(t)\cos\omega_c t$ passing through a memoryless nonlinearity g, the low-frequency (baseband) output Y_{LF} is the average of g over one carrier cycle, with carrier phase θ:

$$Y_{\mathrm{LF}}(\mathcal{A}) = (2\pi)^{-1}\int_0^{2\pi} g(v^* + \mathcal{A}\cos\theta)\,\mathrm{d}\theta.$$

Odd powers of $\mathcal{A}$ average away, leaving only even ones:

$$Y_{\mathrm{LF}}(\mathcal{A}) = g(v^*) + \tfrac{1}{4}g''(v^*)\mathcal{A}^2 + \tfrac{1}{64}g^{(4)}(v^*)\mathcal{A}^4 + \cdots \tag{14}$$

A smooth memoryless response with $g''(v^*) \neq 0$ therefore transduces $\mathcal{A}^2$ at leading weak-input order, whatever its detailed shape. For the JR column, $g = \sigma$, giving the mechanism of §2.2. Recovering $\mathcal{A}$ itself requires a qualitatively different detector: strong rectification. A full-wave rectifier has low-pass-filtered (LPF) output $\mathrm{LPF}[\,|\mathcal{A}\cos\omega_c t|\,] = (2/\pi)\mathcal{A}$ and a half-wave rectifier $(1/\pi)\mathcal{A}$, both linear in the envelope, as does a diode-and-capacitor peak detector. A hard threshold is not one of them: a step detector with offset $\delta > 0$ transduces $\pi^{-1}\arccos(\delta/\mathcal{A})$ for $\mathcal{A} > \delta$ and nothing below it, which is neither linear nor quadratic in $\mathcal{A}$ (App. D). Asymmetric channel rectification, threshold crossing and release events are candidate biological realizations of rectifiers of one kind or another.

Envelope following and square-law detection are distinguishable at a single site. At a matched target, $\mathcal{A}(t) = 2\varepsilon|\cos(\Omega t/2)|$, whose Fourier series $|\cos\theta| = \frac{2}{\pi} + \frac{4}{\pi}\sum_{n\geq 1}\frac{(-1)^{n+1}}{4n^2-1}\cos(2n\theta)$ gives a

harmonic ladder whose nonnegative Fourier amplitudes $A_{n\Omega}$ obey $A_{2\Omega}/A_\Omega = 1/5$, $A_{3\Omega}/A_\Omega = 3/35$ and $A_{4\Omega}/A_\Omega = 1/21$. The square-law output $\frac{1}{2}\mathcal{A}^2 = \varepsilon^2(1+\cos\Omega t)$ contains only DC and Ω. For the mixed family $T(\mathcal{A}) = c_1\mathcal{A} + c_2\mathcal{A}^2$, with $c_1 \neq 0$ and a nonzero fundamental, the pre-network ratio is

$$\mathcal{H}_{\text{det}} \equiv \left|\frac{Y_{2\Omega}}{Y_\Omega}\right| = \frac{1/5}{\left|1 + \frac{3\pi}{4}\, c_2\varepsilon/c_1\right|}, \tag{15}$$

so measuring $\mathcal{H}_{\text{det}}$ constrains $c_2\varepsilon/c_1$ within this family.[1]

A smooth detector generates a second harmonic beyond quadratic order, $Y_{2\Omega}/Y_\Omega \sim (c_4/c_2)\varepsilon^2$, where $c_2 = g''(v^*)/4$ and $c_4 = g^{(4)}(v^*)/64$ are the coefficients in Eq. (14). The square-law signature is a *vanishing* ratio in the weak-field limit, not an exact zero. The recurrent network also multiplies each harmonic by its frequency-dependent gain G, $\mathcal{H}_{\text{meas}} = \mathcal{H}_{\text{det}}\,|G(2\Omega)/G(\Omega)|$. Near resonance, harmonic suppression can make an envelope follower appear square-law.

An amplitude sweep tests the scaling rather than one ratio. An envelope-following detector gives $Y_\Omega \propto \varepsilon$ with the harmonic ratio pinned at 1/5; a weak square-law detector gives $Y_\Omega \propto \varepsilon^2$ with a ratio growing as ε^2. A threshold detector is a third class: its response vanishes for $2\varepsilon \leq \delta$, and its harmonic ratio varies with amplitude after onset. A single harmonic ratio cannot distinguish all three; amplitude dependence is the primary test.

2.5 Envelope oscillations and spatial weighting

The same two-tone field gives different spatial dose maps under envelope following and quadratic detection. The distinction is the detector's response to the oscillating envelope, not a change in the applied field. Write $\mathbf{x}$ for position and $\varepsilon_j(\mathbf{x})$ for the signed local polarization of tone j, projected along a fixed direction. These amplitudes vary in space and are held fixed only during the temporal averages at one location. The nonnegative envelope is

$$\mathcal{A}(\mathbf{x},t) = \sqrt{\varepsilon_1(\mathbf{x})^2 + \varepsilon_2(\mathbf{x})^2 + 2\varepsilon_1(\mathbf{x})\varepsilon_2(\mathbf{x})\cos\Omega t}.$$

Carrier averaging of the squared signal gives

$$\text{LPF}[s^2(t)] = \tfrac{1}{2}\mathcal{A}^2(t) = \frac{\varepsilon_1^2 + \varepsilon_2^2}{2} + \varepsilon_1\varepsilon_2\cos\Omega t, \tag{16}$$

with spatial arguments suppressed at a fixed location. Thus square-law detection recovers $\mathcal{A}^2$, which is sinusoidal at Ω, whereas the envelope itself is not: at a matched site, $\mathcal{A}(t) = 2\varepsilon|\cos(\Omega t/2)|$, a rectified cosine. The conventional TI map describes its excursion, $\mathcal{M}[y] \equiv \max_t y - \min_t y$, along the chosen direction [1]. Table 2 compares this envelope with the squared-envelope signal; the overbar denotes a beat-period mean. The columns are geometric maps before detector gains: an ideal envelope follower multiplies $\mathcal{A}$ by a constant, whereas the weak quadratic response change is $g''(v^*)\mathcal{A}^2/4$ (Eq. (14)). Envelope following is an additional response assumption; the conventional envelope-excursion map alone does not specify a neuron's mean output.

The excursion maps in Table 2 are related pointwise by

$$\mathcal{M}[\tfrac{1}{2}\mathcal{A}^2] = \max(|\varepsilon_1|, |\varepsilon_2|)\;\mathcal{M}[\mathcal{A}]. \tag{17}$$

The square-law map is the conventional envelope-excursion map multiplied, at each point, by the dominant local polarization magnitude. It need not preserve the spatial contrast of the conventional TI map. Both maps can nevertheless have a central modulation maximum, as the illustrative line profile in Fig. S13a shows; the quadratic profile is broader in that example. Where the dominant carrier is larger superficially than at depth, this reweighting degrades deep-to-superficial contrast.

[1] The inverse has two branches unless the sign of the fundamental relative to the linear term is known; for $c_2/c_1 \geq 0$ it is unique.

	Envelope following	Quadratic detection
Slow signal	$\mathcal{A}(\mathbf{x}, t)$	$\frac{1}{2}\mathcal{A}(\mathbf{x}, t)^2$
Mean (DC)	$\overline{\mathcal{A}}(\mathbf{x})$	$\mathcal{I}(\mathbf{x}) = \dfrac{\varepsilon_1^2 + \varepsilon_2^2}{2}$
Modulation excursion	$2\min(\lvert\varepsilon_1\rvert, \lvert\varepsilon_2\rvert)$	$2\lvert\varepsilon_1\varepsilon_2\rvert$
Units before detector gain	mV	mV^2

Table 2: Envelope and quadratic maps at the same position $\mathbf{x}$. Carrier averaging of the detector response gives the slow signal, up to its gain; averaging over a beat period then gives the mean. Excursion means maximum minus minimum, not Fourier amplitude.

As an illustrative example, at $(\varepsilon_1, \varepsilon_2) = (10, 1)$ superficially against $(0.5, 0.5)$ at a matched deep target, $\mathcal{M}[\mathcal{A}]$ favors the superficial point by $2\times$ and $\mathcal{M}[\frac{1}{2}\mathcal{A}^2]$ by $40\times$. Focality must therefore be computed from the product map, whose spatial ranking can differ from the envelope map's. Its contrast depends on the actual vector field distribution: a sufficiently weak second carrier can suppress the superficial product. A finite-element comparison on a real TI montage can quantify this reweighting from the same local polarizations; the illustrative line profile is not a head-model calculation.

With one fixed electrode pair per carrier and fixed neural state, changing the current ratio rescales the leading quadratic beat map without moving its maxima. For fixed frequencies, linear access, and fixed projection directions, write $\varepsilon_j(\mathbf{x}) = I_j^{\mathrm{pair}}\mathcal{P}_j(\mathbf{x})$, where $I_j^{\mathrm{pair}} > 0$ is the peak pair current (mA) and $\mathcal{P}_j$ is the signed local polarization per unit current (mV/mA). Then

$$\mathcal{M}[\tfrac{1}{2}\mathcal{A}^2] = 2I_1^{\mathrm{pair}} I_2^{\mathrm{pair}} |\mathcal{P}_1\mathcal{P}_2|.$$

The normalized map and its target-to-cortex ratios are unchanged, as Cassarà et al. noted for second-order mixing [34]. Fixed detector coefficients and linear network propagation preserve this common current factor, including for dynamic mixing and spatially heterogeneous gains. Steering within this regime requires changing at least one carrier's field shape, for example by redistributing current among several electrodes at that frequency. The DC map, however, weights $\mathcal{P}_1^2$ and $\mathcal{P}_2^2$ separately by the squared currents. It changes with the ratio and can indirectly reshape the beat response by shifting local operating points. Threshold effects can also break the quadratic prediction; the conventional 2 min steering law applies when the detector follows the envelope. An interior beat maximum remains compatible with the fixed-state product law.

The network supplies dynamical selectivity in addition to this spatial weighting. Writing $R_\Omega(\mathbf{x})$ for the complex demodulated response at the envelope frequency Ω produced at location $\mathbf{x}$, and $G_{\mathbf{x}}(\Omega)$ for the local network susceptibility there,

$$R_\Omega(\mathbf{x}) \;\propto\; \sigma''(v_{\mathbf{x}}^*)\, G_{\mathbf{x}}(\Omega)\, \varepsilon_1(\mathbf{x})\, \varepsilon_2(\mathbf{x}), \tag{18}$$

a product of three factors. Field overlap sets where a difference-frequency drive is generated at all; the operating point and the network susceptibility set which of the driven populations amplifies it. Resonance does not override an unfavorable field product, but it can compensate for one.

Equation (18) is written for scalar projected fields. In general the coupling is vectorial and compartment-specific, $\varepsilon_i(\mathbf{x}) = \boldsymbol{\lambda}\cdot\mathbf{E}_i(\mathbf{x})$, so the mixing product $(\boldsymbol{\lambda}\cdot\mathbf{E}_1)(\boldsymbol{\lambda}\cdot\mathbf{E}_2)$ is signed: its magnitude follows the product of the projected amplitudes, while its phase inverts with either the sign of σ'' or the relative sign of the two projections. The derivations below take the collinear, scalar case.

2.6 The mean shift has a different spatial map

The quadratic detector's steady source adds the two carrier intensities, without cross-frequency interference. Under uniform conductivity, access, and detection, its largest magnitude lies on compartment boundaries; the envelope-following mean obeys the same restriction, as shown below. The envelope mean is

$$\overline{\mathcal{A}}(\mathbf{x}) = \frac{1}{2\pi}\int_0^{2\pi} \sqrt{\varepsilon_1(\mathbf{x})^2 + \varepsilon_2(\mathbf{x})^2 + 2\varepsilon_1(\mathbf{x})\varepsilon_2(\mathbf{x})\cos\vartheta}\,\mathrm{d}\vartheta,$$

where ϑ is beat phase. At a matched site with $\varepsilon_1 = \varepsilon_2 = \varepsilon > 0$, the envelope and quadratic means are $4\varepsilon/\pi$ and ε^2, respectively. The applied field has no DC component: these means describe the ideal detector outputs after multiplication by their gains, and the quadratic response change takes the sign of g''. Even one carrier gives either ideal detector a mean output, but no beat modulation; adaptation can alter the physiological mean response.

For the JR quadratic detector, writing $Y_{\mathrm{DC}} = \sigma''(\varepsilon_1^2 + \varepsilon_2^2)/4$ for the local DC source in Eq. (9), its sign follows the curvature and is independent of carrier polarity. Carrier averaging retains the cross term as the beat; averaging over many beat cycles removes it, leaving a sum of intensities without cross-frequency cancellation. At the detector output, where $Y_{\mathrm{DC}} \neq 0$, $|Y_\Omega/Y_{\mathrm{DC}}| = 2|\varepsilon_1\varepsilon_2|/(\varepsilon_1^2 + \varepsilon_2^2) \leq 1$, with equality at matched tone magnitudes. A common access factor cancels from this local ratio. In the polarization mean-square map $\mathcal{I} = (\varepsilon_1^2 + \varepsilon_2^2)/2$, the example above gives 50.5 superficially and 0.25 at depth, a 202-fold contrast; the beat/DC ratios are 0.20 and 1, respectively.

The geometric restriction follows in a homogeneous, isotropic, source-free conductor. Writing ϕ_j for the potential of tone j, the potentials ϕ_j, each component of $\mathbf{E}_j = -\nabla\phi_j$, and the signed polarizations $\varepsilon_j = \boldsymbol{\lambda}\cdot\mathbf{E}_j$ for spatially fixed coupling $\boldsymbol{\lambda}$ are harmonic. Thus $\nabla^2\mathcal{I} = \sum_j |\nabla\varepsilon_j|^2 \geq 0$: the intensity map is subharmonic and has no strict interior maximum. A montage can shape each carrier field, but the maximum of this map lies on the region's boundary; conductivity interfaces are such boundaries.

The envelope mean has the same restriction. At each beat phase ϑ, $\mathcal{A}$ is the Euclidean norm of $(\varepsilon_1 + \varepsilon_2\cos\vartheta, \varepsilon_2\sin\vartheta)$, a vector of harmonic functions. A norm is convex, so this envelope is subharmonic; averaging over ϑ preserves that property. Thus both idealized mean maps lack a strict interior maximum under these conditions (Fig. S13b). This does not prohibit a beat maximum: the product instead obeys $\nabla^2(\varepsilon_1\varepsilon_2) = 2\nabla\varepsilon_1\cdot\nabla\varepsilon_2$, whose sign is unrestricted. Within the homogeneous model, interior selectivity must therefore come from the oscillatory response rather than from either mean map.

Spatially varying access, orientation, or curvature can change the physiological DC map, so the intensity result does not extend to those weights. For isotropically distributed unit orientations $\mathbf{n}$ with orientation-independent access and curvature, $\langle(\mathbf{n}\cdot\mathbf{E}_j)^2\rangle = |\mathbf{E}_j|^2/3$ and $\langle(\mathbf{n}\cdot\mathbf{E}_1)(\mathbf{n}\cdot\mathbf{E}_2)\rangle = \mathbf{E}_1\cdot\mathbf{E}_2/3$: orthogonal fields cancel the averaged beat, but retain the DC intensity. At equal local RMS polarization, an unmodulated carrier gives the same mean shift at second order when its DC mixing coefficient equals those of both TI carriers. For a dynamic detector, this requires the frequency-dependent coefficient to vary negligibly across the carrier interval.

2.7 Amplification: the synaptic low-pass and the network resonance

Synaptic filtering suppresses the carrier after the nonlinearity has generated the beat. Each JR excitatory synapse has transfer function $H_s(\omega) = Aa/(i\omega + a)^2$, a second-order low-pass with characteristic frequency $a/(2\pi) \approx 16$ Hz. It passes a 10 Hz component with relative amplitude about 0.7, while reducing a 100 Hz component to about 2.5% (Fig. 6). Provided the carrier does not itself excite a responsive mode, the loop therefore reads predominantly the generated low-frequency drive.

What turns this recovered beat component into a large, frequency-selective response is the network. Linearizing the JR column (node) about its fixed point gives a leading eigenvalue pair $\mu_\pm = -\gamma \pm i\omega_0$; near the Hopf the response is dominated by this critical mode, with damping γ and modal frequency ω_0. Below a supercritical Hopf, $\gamma \to 0^+$ and the column is a sharply tuned (high quality-factor $\mathcal{Q} = \omega_0/2\gamma$) resonator; driving it with the demodulated beat component (10) at Ω gives a resonant response. Writing G for the complex susceptibility, a constant-numerator two-pole approximation gives its magnitude as

$$|G(\Omega)| \propto \left[(\omega_0^2 + \gamma^2 - \Omega^2)^2 + (2\gamma\Omega)^2\right]^{-1/2}, \qquad |G(\omega_0)| \propto \frac{1}{2\gamma\omega_0} \quad (\gamma \ll \omega_0), \tag{19}$$

so the response peaks near ω_0 with an approximately Lorentzian power profile and $1/\gamma$ growth near a simple Hopf with nonzero input–output projections.[2] This weak-drive law requires the rectified mean shift to leave the state stable; entrainment above the Hopf instead requires a phase-capture test (§3.8).

Write D for the detector's beat-source coefficient: for the JR rate source, $D = \frac{1}{2}\sigma''(v^*)$, half the local sigmoid curvature. Combining access, detection, and amplification gives

$$R_\Omega \simeq G(\Omega;\gamma)\; D\; \lambda_f(\omega_1)E_1\, \lambda_f(\omega_2)E_2, \tag{20}$$

where λ_f maps field to local carrier polarization, D converts the product of those polarizations into a beat drive, and G maps that drive to the complex observed response, whose measured amplitude is $A_\Omega = |R_\Omega|$. For JR, G is the response to a generated rate drive. For fast-carrier QIF in the normalized units of Eq. (4), $D = 1$ for the v^2 source and G includes its conversion through the voltage and rate dynamics. Thus the population readout is included once. In these limits D is independent of carrier frequency at fixed polarization; across the dynamic crossover it acquires frequency dependence. A carrier sweep and a beat sweep therefore constrain different stages rather than a single effective gain.

The resonance does not supply the quadratic mixer. The cubic Hopf normal form responds to an in-band drive but has no second-order difference-frequency source (App. C). A large resonant susceptibility alone therefore does not establish beat generation.

2.8 Carrier access depends on the effective membrane response

Carrier independence at fixed polarization does not imply independence at fixed applied field. As an isopotential access model, consider $H_m(\omega) = 1/(1 + i\omega\tau_m)$, with effective time constant τ_m. This is the response of a point membrane to injected current; a field coupled through a cable need not have the same transfer. For nearby carriers, the two polarizations acquire nearly the same attenuation. The quadratic beat then satisfies

$$\frac{|Y_\Omega(f_c)|}{|Y_\Omega^{\text{direct}}|} \simeq |H_m(\omega_c)|^2 = \frac{1}{1 + (\omega_c\tau_m)^2} \sim \frac{1}{(\omega_c\tau_m)^2} \quad (\omega_c\tau_m \gg 1), \tag{21}$$

where Y_Ω^{direct} is the beat generated with the same static coupling and no access attenuation. This filter belongs either in the field-to-polarization map or in the membrane equation that computes that polarization.

Somatic passive time constants are commonly 10–30 ms; reported human pyramidal values include approximately 12 ms [4] and 16.5 ± 3.7 ms [5]. For the illustrative $\tau_m = 16$ ms used here, the power factor $|H_m|^2$ is about 10^{-4} at 1 kHz, 2.5×10^{-5} at 2 kHz, and 10^{-6} at 10 kHz. A static nonlinearity placed after this point-membrane response therefore receives strongly attenuated carriers.

[2] Here ω_0 is the eigenvalue's imaginary part. The canonical oscillator has undamped frequency $\sqrt{\omega_0^2 + \gamma^2}$ and peak $\sqrt{\omega_0^2 - \gamma^2}$ for $\omega_0 > \gamma$; frequency-dependent network projections can shift the peak.

Cohen et al.'s periaxonal circuit provides a reason to distinguish axonal from somatic access [7]. A conducting submyelin space, about 12 nm wide and partly sealed at the paranodes, separates the voltage across myelin from that across the axonal membrane. Their minimum fitted axonal decay was approximately 1 ms. This is a response to injected current in a distributed cable, rather than a measured transfer from a TI field. The AIS is another candidate site, with a high sodium-channel density [8]; this property supports nonlinear sensitivity but does not fix its charging time.

A shorter effective time changes carrier transmission quantitatively. The sensitivity case $\tau_m = 0.2$ ms gives $|H_m|^2 \approx 0.39$ at 1 kHz and 0.14 at 2 kHz (Fig. S5). This assumed time represents the fast-compartment hypothesis in Eq. (8), or motivates a shorter membrane time in a QIF reduction; it has not been measured under TI at the AIS or a node. In the latter description, the approach to a static transfer is governed by Eq. (6); the membrane filter must not be applied again outside the QIF equations. A short access time improves carrier transmission without, by itself, specifying the mixing coefficient or the remaining circuit resonance. Table 3 separates measured decays, assumed access times, strong-pulse charging, cellular detection, and downstream synaptic filtering. A characteristic frequency requires a specified filter; a measured decay alone is not a TI cutoff.

Response	Time scale	Evidence and role
Somatic point-membrane model	$\tau_m = 16$ ms; $f_{\text{char}} \approx 10$ Hz	Illustrative current-driven filter, informed by somatic measurements near 12 and 16.5 ms [4, 5].
Myelinated axon	minimum fitted decay ≈ 1 ms	Injected-current responses in Cohen et al.'s periaxonal circuit [7]; evidence for distinct axonal voltage dynamics.
Fast axonal access	assumed $\tau_m = 0.2$ ms; $f_{\text{char}} \approx 800$ Hz	Reduced-model sensitivity case for a fast compartment, such as an AIS or node; TI coupling and charging time require calibration.
Prior TI network model	$\tau_m = 1$ and 0.4 ms	Short effective membrane times governing kHz sensitivity in a gamma network [6]; model parameters, not measured axonal TI decays.
Field-induced charging	≈ 0.7 μs	Measured with strong microsecond field pulses in isolated neurons [23]; a different stimulation regime.
Cellular detector	channel- and state-dependent	Luff et al.'s TTX-sensitive mixing persists near 5 kHz [10]; this measures detection, not a passive time constant.
JR excitatory synapse	$\tau_s = 10$ ms; $f_{\text{char}} \approx 16$ Hz	Model filter acting on the generated rate, downstream of detection.

Table 3: Access, detection, and downstream filtering involve different response times. Measured decays, pulse-charging times, and assumed model parameters are identified separately. The characteristic frequency $f_{\text{char}} = 1/(2\pi\tau)$ is given only for the specified filters; an axonal decay is not automatically a TI cutoff. AIS, axon initial segment; TTX, tetrodotoxin.

Cable geometry changes this attenuation: a long passive cable with a sealed end has a quadratic-beat factor of about 10^{-2} at 1 kHz and 10^{-3} at 10 kHz for $\tau_m = 16$ ms, rather than the point-membrane values (App. B.1, Eq. (29)).

Channel kinetics contribute to the effective dynamic mixing response. A gate filter added outside the detector must not duplicate dynamics the detector already contains, and where the detector lacks them, as QIF lacks sodium-channel kinetics, the filter needs its own model or measurement; neither a static sigmoid nor QIF specifies a universal 1 kHz gate cutoff. Equation (11) gives the QIF realization of this response. Carrier sweeps can constrain the combined access and mixing response, while beat-frequency sweeps probe the downstream amplifier.

2.9 Operating-point dependence

Because $Y_\Omega \propto \sigma''(v^*)$, demodulation is governed by the curvature at the operating point, and in particular by how far v^* sits from the sigmoid inflection (Fig. 7). The Population Excitation–Inhibition Index (PEIX) of [24] measures signed departure from maximal sigmoid slope:

$$\mathrm{PEIX}(v^*) = \mathrm{sign}(v^* - v_0)\left\{1 - \mathrm{sech}^2\left[\tfrac{\rho}{2}\,(v^* - v_0)\right]\right\}. \tag{22}$$

It is zero at v_0, positive above it, negative below it, and tends to ± 1 in the saturated tails. The normalized slope is instead $\sigma'(v^*)/\sigma'(v_0) = 1 - |\mathrm{PEIX}(v^*)|$, with $\sigma'(v_0) = e_0\rho/2$. Demodulation follows the curvature, which vanishes at the inflection and in the tails and peaks in magnitude on the flanks. For the logistic curve, $\sigma'' = -\rho\sigma'\,\mathrm{sign}(\mathrm{PEIX})\sqrt{|\mathrm{PEIX}|}$; the index specifies the side and saturation, but is not itself the mixing gain.

This relation is specific to the memoryless logistic detector. In the exact mean field at a fast carrier the rectified DC term follows the slope F' and is largest at the inflection (§2.3), so the relation between PEIX and TI efficacy is model-dependent; PEIX remains a measurable read-out of the operating point. In the Jansen–Rit detector, anything shifting v^* (for example, neuromodulation, attention, arousal, psychedelic exposure, or PV-interneuron dysfunction in Alzheimer's disease) scales, and can flip the sign of, the TI response; in the dynamic detector the same shifts act through F' and the susceptibility, without a sign rule. The state dependence is the falsifiable handle; the sign reversal is specific to the memoryless model.

3 Methods

3.1 Stimulation waveforms and matched-source controls

Dense perturbative sweeps use the three-line waveform

$$s(t) = \varepsilon\,[\,1 + m\cos\Omega t\,]\cos\omega_c t, \qquad \omega_c = 2\pi f_c, \tag{23}$$

with dimensionless modulation depth m, because it parameterizes a sweep by one amplitude. It is not the physical signal: it carries a line at ω_c that the two-tone sum lacks. The two agree at Ω to leading order (the surrogate gives $Y_\Omega = \frac{1}{2}\sigma''\varepsilon^2 m$) and are *not* equivalent beyond it. For matched genuine tones $\mathrm{LPF}[s^2] = \varepsilon^2(1 + \cos\Omega t)$, whereas for the $m = 1$ AM surrogate $\mathrm{LPF}[s^2] = \varepsilon^2(\frac{3}{4} + \cos\Omega t + \frac{1}{4}\cos 2\Omega t)$: the same Ω amplitude, but a different DC term and a spurious second harmonic at 25% of the fundamental. Genuine two tones are used for the demodulation demonstration (Fig. 4), the curvature and square-law controls (Fig. 7), the laminar maps (Figs. S1, S7) and the kHz demonstration. The AM surrogate is retained for dense resonance and coupling sweeps; Fig. 7d verifies open-loop agreement at Ω at one operating point. That agreement does not extend to the mean shift or second harmonic, the latter being a diagnostic of transduction class (§2.4). We therefore repeat the mean-shift-dependent comparisons with two tones: the timing-versus-rate figure uses them, as do controls of the TI/tACS ratios and NMM2 endpoint. The corresponding Results report both waveforms, whose different DC terms can shift the recurrent operating state.

3.2 Amplitude scaling and harmonic measurements

These measurements distinguish quadratic detection from envelope following, which predict different dose maps and cannot be identified from a beat response at one amplitude. With fixed coupling and a linear downstream response, an amplitude sweep tests whether the generated beat scales as ε^2 or ε. The harmonic test compares the response at the second harmonic, 2Ω, with the fundamental at Ω. After correcting for network gain, their ratio tends to zero for weak quadratic detection but to 1/5 for ideal envelope following. Together these measurements test the smooth-transfer assumption of §2.2 using the signatures derived in §2.4.

The response at the envelope frequency is read out with a software lock-in amplifier: multiplying $v(t)$ by sine and cosine at Ω and averaging estimates the component at that frequency. A finite window suppresses neighboring frequencies without eliminating them. With a Hann window, the in-phase ($L_{\cos}$) and quadrature ($L_{\sin}$) components are

$$L_{\cos} = \frac{2}{\sum_k w_k} \sum_k w_k \, (v_k - \bar{v}) \cos \Omega t_k, \quad L_{\sin} = \frac{2}{\sum_k w_k} \sum_k w_k \, (v_k - \bar{v}) \sin \Omega t_k,$$
$$A_\Omega = \sqrt{L_{\cos}^2 + L_{\sin}^2}, \tag{24}$$

with sample index k, sample times t_k, voltages $v_k = v(t_k)$, and Hann weights w_k. The windowed mean is $\bar{v} = \sum_k w_k v_k / \sum_k w_k$. For a test tone $v = A_{\text{test}} \cos(\Omega t + \theta_0)$, with amplitude A_{test} and phase θ_0, the long-window limits $(L_{\cos}, L_{\sin}) \to A_{\text{test}}(\cos\theta_0, -\sin\theta_0)$ give $A_\Omega \to A_{\text{test}}$: the normalization returns the physical amplitude, twice the magnitude of the windowed Fourier coefficient. Out-of-band components can leak into the estimate, particularly the DC level of the JR voltage readout ($\bar{v} \sim 8$ mV, far larger than the demodulated signal). The finite-window projection of a constant onto the quadrature references need not vanish, so we subtract $\bar{v}$ explicitly; this makes the metric accurate down to the 10^{-8} level needed for the JR kHz analysis (§2.8).

The log–log slope of the envelope-locked response against field amplitude separates the linear and quadratic laws of §2.4 without requiring absolute calibration; the ε^2 control of §4.4 is that measurement, performed in the model.

To measure that harmonic ratio, apply Eq. (24) at Ω and 2Ω over the same settled window. Their amplitude ratio estimates $\mathcal{H}_{\text{meas}}$; correcting for $|G(2\Omega)/G(\Omega)|$ gives $\mathcal{H}_{\text{det}}$. Inferring a mixture coefficient through Eq. (15) additionally requires the mixed family $T(\mathcal{A}) = c_1\mathcal{A} + c_2\mathcal{A}^2$ and a known sign branch. A threshold response can give a similar ratio at one amplitude, so the amplitude sweep must also be checked. At resonance ($\Omega = \omega_0$) with $\mathcal{Q} = 10$, a detector ratio of 20% reads as 0.7%, making an envelope follower appear square-law. The test therefore requires an *off-resonance* drive: at $\Delta f \simeq f_0/4$ both lines sit on the flat part of G, where $|G(2\Omega)/G(\Omega)| \approx 1.22$–$1.25$ across $\mathcal{Q} = 3$–30, or with G measured independently by a weak sweep of direct low-frequency stimulation (transcranial alternating-current stimulation, tACS) and deconvolved.

3.3 Head model and field computation (R. Salvador; text to come)

[PLACEHOLDER: R. Salvador will specify the Ernie head model, tissue conductivities, electrode geometry and currents for the Violante montage, finite-element (FEM) solver and boundary conditions, and field-to-polarization conversion. The methods will define the target and cortical regions, spatial summary statistics, and focus-displacement measure. The projection direction at each location will remain fixed across the 1:1 and 1:3 conditions and the current-ratio sweep. A separate isotropic comparison will average the signed quadratic mixing term over uniformly distributed orientations before taking its magnitude. Head-model details and results are pending.]

3.4 Single-column Jansen–Rit: integration, lock-in, and controls

All symbols and units are collected in Table 5 (App. A). We integrate the single-column JR model of §2.1 (App. B, Eqs. (26) and Table 6) as six first-order ODEs. The TI field enters only the pyramidal output sigmoid, Eq. (26), as $s(t)$; the read-out $v = y_1 - y_2$ is *not* fed the field directly, so any power at Ω in v is produced by the nonlinearity and the recurrent loop, not by trivial pass-through. Unless stated otherwise $f_c = 100$ Hz and $m = 1$.

We integrate with a fixed-step fourth-order Runge–Kutta (RK4) scheme, $\Delta t = 2 \times 10^{-4}$ s (50 samples per carrier cycle at 100 Hz; reduced to 10^{-4} s for carrier sweeps up to 300 Hz). The kHz-carrier runs of Fig. S9 use $\Delta t = 2 \times 10^{-5}$ s for the carrier sweep to 4 kHz (25 samples per carrier cycle at 2 kHz, 12.5 at 4 kHz) and 1.5×10^{-5} s for the 2 kHz output spectrum. Halving

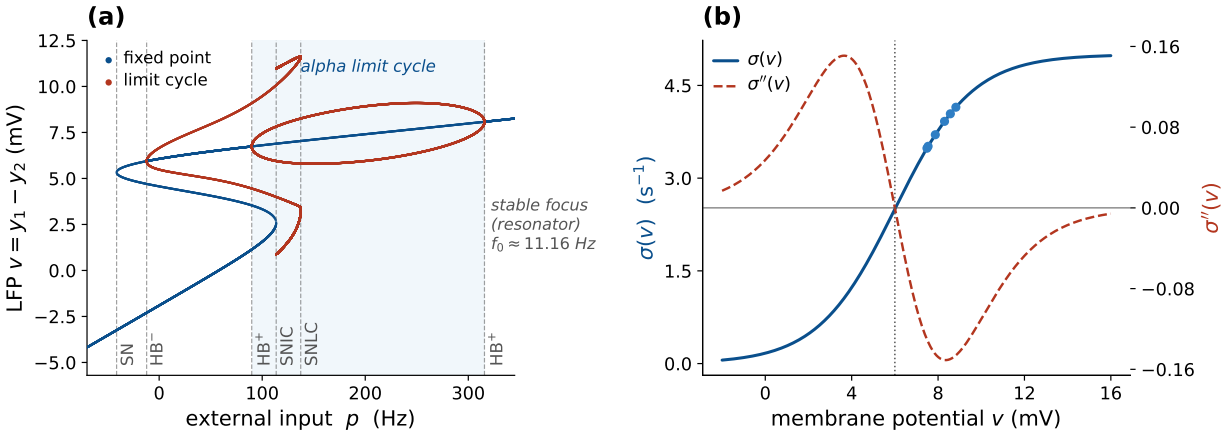


Figure 3: The Jansen–Rit operating regime: bifurcation and sigmoid curvature. *(a)* JR bifurcation diagram from numerical continuation—the LFP $v = y_1 - y_2$ along the fixed-point branch (blue) and the min/max of the limit-cycle branches (red) vs. external input p, with *solid* stable and *faded* unstable. The alpha limit cycle (shaded) lies between the Hopf points at $p \approx 90$ and 316 s^{-1}. The alpha cycle coexists with a lower stable fixed point up to the saddle-node on an invariant circle (SNIC, $p \approx 114$), then with a large-amplitude cycle up to its saddle-node near $p = 137$. The SNIC terminates the large-amplitude branch, not the alpha cycle. At the upper Hopf, $f_0 \approx 11.16$ Hz; beyond it the fixed point is a stable focus, the near-Hopf resonator used here. Further codim-1 points are marked (saddle-node SN, Hopf HB$^{\pm}$, saddle-node of limit cycles SNLC). *(b)* The sigmoid $\sigma(v)$ and its curvature $\sigma''(v)$, which sets the demodulation gain and vanishes at the inflection v_0. Dots mark the operating points reached by the closed-loop model for the p values used here.

each step changes the reported lock-in amplitudes by less than 1%. The 10 kHz figures quoted in §2.8 are analytic evaluations of Eq. (21), not simulations.

The resonance sweep in Fig. 5 uses 10 s of settling and a 20 s measurement window. Long windows reduce transients from weakly damped modes and average beating when autonomous activity persists. Other runs use the windows specified in their scripts. The two-tone 2 kHz example (Fig. S6) uses $p = 400$ s^{-1}, $C = 135$, and 0.5 mV per tone with $\tau = 0.2$ ms. From a zero initial state, it settles for 4 s and records 4 s at $\Delta t = 1.5 \times 10^{-5}$ s, sampling before each RK4 step. Its amplitude spectra use plain-mean subtraction and a Hann window. Parameter sweeps are vectorized: the state is an $(N_{\text{grid}}, 6)$ array, where N_{grid} counts the parameter combinations advanced simultaneously, so a full resonance map runs in seconds.

The full bifurcation diagram (Fig. 3) is computed by numerical continuation of the fixed-point and limit-cycle branches. We independently locate the operating supercritical Hopf by solving, for each p, the self-consistent scalar equation for the resting fixed point $v = y_1 - y_2$, forming the 6×6 Jacobian numerically and diagonalizing it: the Hopf is the p at which the leading eigenvalue pair crosses the imaginary axis with $\operatorname{Im} \mu_+$ in the alpha band. This gives $p_H \approx 315.70$ s^{-1} and $f_0 = \operatorname{Im} \mu_+ / 2\pi \approx 11.16$ Hz, consistent with the continuation and the JR analysis of [35]. The 11.1 Hz demonstration beat is near this resonance. For $p > p_H$ the fixed point is a stable focus.

We compare the *open-loop detector*, the firing-rate sigmoid at a fixed operating point v^* without recurrence, with the *closed-loop* column, the full recurrent Jansen–Rit with its feedback. The open-loop detector passes the two-tone field through σ at v^* and applies Eq. (24), isolating the pure demodulation law (Figs. 6, 7, S5); its signed in-phase component $L_{\cos}$ verifies the curvature law, including its sign. The *bifurcation diagram* records the field-free min/max of v vs. p, each run initialized at its fixed point plus a small kick. The *two-dimensional map* evaluates A_Ω over an (Ω, p) grid. We verify the mechanism three ways: the square law (A_Ω vs. ε on a well-damped focus, expecting a log–log slope of 2); a linearization control (replacing σ in the pyramidal sigmoid of App. B, Eq. (26), by its tangent at v^*, which must abolish the Ω response); and a check of σ', σ''

against finite differences. Code and reproduction limits are listed under *Code and data availability.*

3.5 Exact next-generation mean field (NMM2 PING)

The NMM2 PING circuit couples excitatory and inhibitory MPR populations through second-order synapses [29, 30, 31]. We use the Rosetta Stone formulation [26], which places this derived mean field on the same footing as JR and LaNMM (§2.1). For population $X \in \{E, I\}$ (excitatory or inhibitory), r_X is the physical firing rate (ms^{-1} in the integration), v_X the dimensionless mean QIF voltage, and τ_X the membrane time (ms). Dots denote physical-time derivatives:

$$\begin{aligned} \tau_E \dot{r}_E &= \Delta/(\pi\tau_E) + 2 r_E v_E, \qquad & \tau_E \dot{v}_E &= v_E^2 + \bar{\eta} - (\pi\tau_E r_E)^2 + \tau_E J\,(r_E^{\mathrm{syn}} - r_I^{\mathrm{syn}}) + I_E(t), \\ \tau_I \dot{r}_I &= \Delta/(\pi\tau_I) + 2 r_I v_I, & \tau_I \dot{v}_I &= v_I^2 + \bar{\eta} - (\pi\tau_I r_I)^2 + \tau_I J\,(r_E^{\mathrm{syn}} - 2 r_I^{\mathrm{syn}}), \end{aligned} \tag{25}$$

with second-order synaptic activations $r_E^{\mathrm{syn}} = \hat{K}_a[r_E]$ (excitatory, time constant τ_a) and $r_I^{\mathrm{syn}} = \hat{K}_g[r_I]$ (inhibitory, τ_g), each obeying the same critically damped operator as the JR synapse, $\tau_s^2 \ddot{r}_{\mathrm{syn}} + 2\tau_s \dot{r}_{\mathrm{syn}} + r_{\mathrm{syn}} = r$; here J is the dimensionless global synaptic gain and the relative weights $(w_{EE}, w_{EI}, w_{IE}, w_{II}) = (1, 1, 1, 2)$ use target X and source Y in w_{XY} and set the E and I rows: the E membrane sees $J\,(r_E^{\mathrm{syn}} - r_I^{\mathrm{syn}})$ and the I membrane $J\,(r_E^{\mathrm{syn}} - 2 r_I^{\mathrm{syn}})$, the only asymmetry being the doubled $I \to I$ weight $w_{II} = 2$.

The common background drive $\bar{\eta}$ is the bifurcation parameter: raising it past a supercritical Hopf at $\bar{\eta}_H = 1.110$ opens a gamma limit cycle (the gamma counterpart of the JR alpha Hopf). The applied field enters the excitatory voltage equation as a current-like forcing, $I_E(t) = \lambda_I E(t)$ in the convention of the exact mean field [30], with instantaneous field-to-current coupling λ_I, as two genuine tones at $f_c \mp \Delta f/2$ (carrier $f_c = 300$ Hz, envelope Δf swept through the gamma band) of current amplitude A_f in the dimensionless MPR drive units, the same normalization as $\bar{\eta}$. Thus λ_I is measured in normalized drive per V/m. The E membrane $\tau_E \dot{v}_E$ integrates this forcing into the carrier-frequency excursion $A_f/(\omega\tau_E)$ that the exact quadratic v_E^2 term rectifies, with no postulated sigmoid; the PING as run therefore computes membrane access with $\tau_m = \tau_E$.

We integrate with fixed-step RK4 ($\Delta t = 0.05$ ms) and read out the lock-in (Eq. (24)) of r_E at Δf over the $(\Delta f, \bar{\eta})$ plane. Parameters (Rosetta Stone PING [26]): $\Delta = 1$, global coupling $J = 15$, $\tau_E = 15$, $\tau_I = 7.5$, $\tau_a = 10$, $\tau_g = 2.5$ ms, with $\bar{\eta}$ swept through the supercritical Hopf at $\bar{\eta}_H = 1.110$ ($f_0 = 54.0$ Hz), located by bisection on the leading eigenvalue of the mean-field Jacobian. The simulations retain these finite membrane times; Eq. (6) characterizes the fast-membrane limit.

As in JR, either background drive or coupling can bring the circuit to its Hopf. The resonance map sweeps $\bar{\eta}$ (Fig. S8); the coupling sweep, called the J-curve, varies J at fixed $\bar{\eta}$ toward J^*, located by bisection on the leading Jacobian eigenvalue, and reads the lock-in peak of r_E over Δf (Fig. S10). Unlike the JR J-curve, this sweep does not pin the operating point. At $\bar{\eta} = 0$, we track the eigenpair that reaches the Hopf by continuation and define γ from that critical pair, even where another mode dominates the response. The linear reference includes the operating-state dependence of the carrier response and the recurrent transfer. We compute its second-order source from the PING quadratic terms at the central carrier, 300 Hz, and apply the full linearized network response over 15–90 Hz in 0.025 Hz steps. Using the distinct AM sidebands changes the peak gain by less than 0.1% across this sweep.

The simulated coupling sweep uses the AM surrogate, $A_f = 8$, with 5 s settling and a 4 s window. We search around each linear resonance, extending the frequency grid until each sampled maximum is bracketed, and compare amplitudes $A_f = 2, 4, 8$ at nine couplings. Local parabolic interpolation changes the sampled peaks by less than 1.3%. The figure scales the linear reference to the median measured gain over $14.5 < J < 16$; the amplitude check instead normalizes peak response divided by A_f^2 and linear gain to its value at $A_f = 2$, $J = 15.53$. These normalizations compare gain variation with the detector coefficient allowed to vary along this unpinned sweep.

We check the stability of the driven J-curve endpoint by integrating the full variational matrix along its trajectory. At carrier 300 Hz and beat 50.5 Hz, the AM input repeats every 2 s. After 8 s of settling, we compute the perturbation multipliers over that period and repeat over the next period. Moduli below one indicate decay of perturbations to the periodic response. Two-tone controls at $J = 16.5663$ and 16.5901, both with a 50.5 Hz beat, use 5 s settling, direct perturbation decay, and an 8 s finite-time Lyapunov estimate.

Although a DC-only averaged calculation predicts an unstable endpoint, the full periodically forced solution remains attracting: its largest perturbation multiplier is 0.034 over the 2 s forcing period. Increasing settling from 0.6 to 3 s changes the endpoint lock-in by 0.8%. With genuine two tones, the 50.5 Hz endpoint control also attracts nearby trajectories: perturbations decay at -0.0014 ms^{-1}, and the 8 s Lyapunov estimate is -0.00079 ms^{-1}. These controls test a nonlinear driven response, not linear gain about the DC-shifted equilibrium.

3.6 QIF spiking network (microscale of NMM2)

NMM2 is the exact infinite-population mean field of all-to-all QIF neurons [29, 26, 31]. We integrate that network directly to compare beat-locked and ongoing activity at the spike level (§4.10): $N = 8000$ QIF neurons per population, parameters identical to the PING mean field (Eq. (25)), with single-neuron voltages V_j, finite spike threshold $V_{\text{peak}} = 100$ and reset $-V_{\text{peak}}$ in model voltage units, excitabilities $\eta_j \sim \text{Lorentzian}(\bar{\eta}, \Delta)$ sampled by deterministic quantiles, second-order synapses driven by the empirical population rates, and a genuine two-tone field entering the excitatory membranes. Spiking and threshold dynamics are where the AM surrogate and the physical waveform cannot be assumed equivalent beyond perturbation theory, so this run uses two tones throughout.

The common background drive $\bar{\eta}$ places the field-free mean field below or above a gamma Hopf at $\bar{\eta}_H = 1.110$ ($f_0 = 54.0$ Hz). We use $\bar{\eta} = 0.85$ with a 55 Hz beat and $\bar{\eta} = 1.5$ with a 42 Hz beat. Both runs have carrier $f_c = 300$ Hz and amplitude $A_f = 35$ per tone. We label the conditions by their field-free state and separate the beat-locked component from other gamma activity. The spectra and rate folds do not by themselves establish phase capture (§F).

We also run both conditions at $A_f = 10$ per tone with the same measurement settings. For $\bar{\eta} = 0.85$, separate checks double the population size, double the measurement window, or halve the integration step; further runs raise V_{peak} to 200 and 400 at both time steps. An equal-RMS mean-field control replaces the two tones by one 300 Hz carrier with peak amplitude $\sqrt{2}A_f$, using the same duration: both inputs have mean-square amplitude A_f^2 over these windows. The carrier comparison starts from the field-free equilibrium and uses 800 ms settling and 800 ms measurement, with a 3200 ms window to check spectral leakage at the larger amplitude.

For two nearby carriers, the fast-carrier approximation gives a constant shift of the excitatory drive, $\delta\eta_E \simeq A_f^2/(\omega_c\tau_E)^2$, from the quadratic voltage term. We refine this estimate using the full PING linear carrier responses and their second-order DC source, then solve for the carrier-averaged equilibrium and its stability, including the source's dependence on that equilibrium. This approximation isolates the mean shift; direct two-tone integrations retain the beat forcing and provide a separate check.

The network is integrated with Euler steps of 0.0025 ms, settled for 800 ms (over four field-free relaxation times at $\bar{\eta} = 0.85$, where the mean-field relaxation time is 176 ms) and measured over an integer number of beat cycles, 44 at 55 Hz and 34 at 42 Hz (800 and 810 ms), removing the phase-coverage bias from incomplete beat cycles. Envelope-locked timing is quantified by the quadrature lock-in A_Ω of $r_E(t)$ at Δf, reported as the modulation depth $A_\Omega/\langle r_E\rangle$ (a stable measure; the off→on lock-in ratio would divide by the field-free floor), and per neuron by the pairwise phase consistency of each neuron's spike phases at Δf (PPC; [36]), which is unbiased in the spike count, over neurons with at least ten spikes in the window.

At $A_f = 10$ and $\bar{\eta} = 0.85$, the finite-network beat depth is 0.093 for the published cutoff, versus the mean-field value 0.128. Raising the spike cutoff from $V_{\text{peak}} = 100$ to 200 and 400 gives depths 0.127 and 0.139, while the mean-rate increase stays at 2.8–2.9%. At the original cutoff, doubling the population gives 0.083 and halving the time step gives 0.093. The response is therefore sensitive to the finite spike cutoff. Halving the step at cutoffs 200 and 400 gives depths 0.121 and 0.141, respectively: cutoff dependence persists, and quantitative convergence remains unestablished at this population size. At the plotted cutoff, the pooled spike-phase vector strength is 0.046; median per-neuron phase consistency remains negative in field-off and field-on windows at all three cutoffs. In the $A_f = 35$ convergence checks, halving the time step changes the lock-in and the pooled vector strength by under 1%; doubling the spike-detection threshold changes the lock-in by about 1% and the mean rate by 2%, but the pooled vector strength at $\bar{\eta} = 0.85$ by about 45%, so phase concentration, unlike rate modulation, is sensitive to how spike times are defined.

3.7 Coupling sweeps, timing, and the tACS control (Jansen–Rit)

The coupling sweeps of Figs. 9 and S11, and the transcranial alternating-current stimulation (tACS) control of Fig. S3, use the single JR column with the field-free operating point v^* pinned: for each global connectivity C we solve the field-free fixed-point relation analytically for the external drive $p(C)$ that holds v^* (hence $\sigma''(v^*)$) fixed, vary C toward the alpha Hopf, and read γ, ω_0 from the 6×6 Jacobian. The field is the AM surrogate of Eq. (23) for Fig. 9, genuine two tones for the timing comparison (Fig. S11), or a direct in-band sinusoid $s(t) = \varepsilon \cos \Omega t$ ($\varepsilon = 0.1$ mV) for the tACS control (Fig. S3), each read out by the lock-in of v at Δf, except in the timing comparison, which reads the modulation and mean of the same pyramidal rate $r_P = \sigma(v + s)$. That comparison uses 18 s settling and a 20 s window for each waveform. The Figure 9–Figure S3 response-ratio comparison uses $v^* = 8.30$ mV, TI surrogate amplitude 0.3 mV with $m = 1$ and $f_c = 100$ Hz, and tACS amplitude 0.1 mV, driven at each field-free modal frequency. The original TI amplitudes are interpolated logarithmically in C onto the tACS grid. For the waveform comparison, both the surrogate and two-tone TI are rerun on that grid with 12 s settling and a 6 s window. Pinning fixes the background curvature; it does not cancel the stimulation-induced mean shift. Additional controls at $C = 110$, 133.9091, and 136.3 use a tACS amplitude of 0.0143039 mV, matched to the leading TI beat source. They record mean voltage, mean rate, and lock-in with 12 s settling and a 6 s window, repeated with 60 s settling and a 20 s window; the latter settings also test genuine two tones.

3.8 Vocabulary: forced response, entrainment, and gating

Forced response denotes the component driven at the beat Δf, quantified by the lock-in amplitude (Eq. (24)). A purely forced regime requires a stable operating state under stimulation; being below Hopf with the field off is insufficient. *Entrainment* is reserved for its dynamical-systems meaning, frequency capture of a *self-sustained* oscillator [37]; in the maps we screen for it with the dominance criterion $|f_{\text{out}} - \Delta f| < 0.3$ Hz on the dominant output frequency. This identifies frequency dominance, not phase capture. *Gating* is amplitude modulation of a persisting rhythm without frequency capture [38, 39]. Capture and gating are dynamically different, and the same word would otherwise cover both. The QIF rate fold measures beat-locked firing, which does not by itself establish gating of gamma amplitude. Appendix F gives the metrics and the frequency-dominance protocol.

The coupling sweeps approach the Hopf from field-free stable foci ($\gamma > 0$), so the $1/\gamma$ law concerns forced susceptibility. The frequency-dominance maps on the oscillatory side describe a different observable: their bands broaden with drive, but an Arnold tongue describes phase capture of the autonomous limit cycle and requires phase tracking (§F).

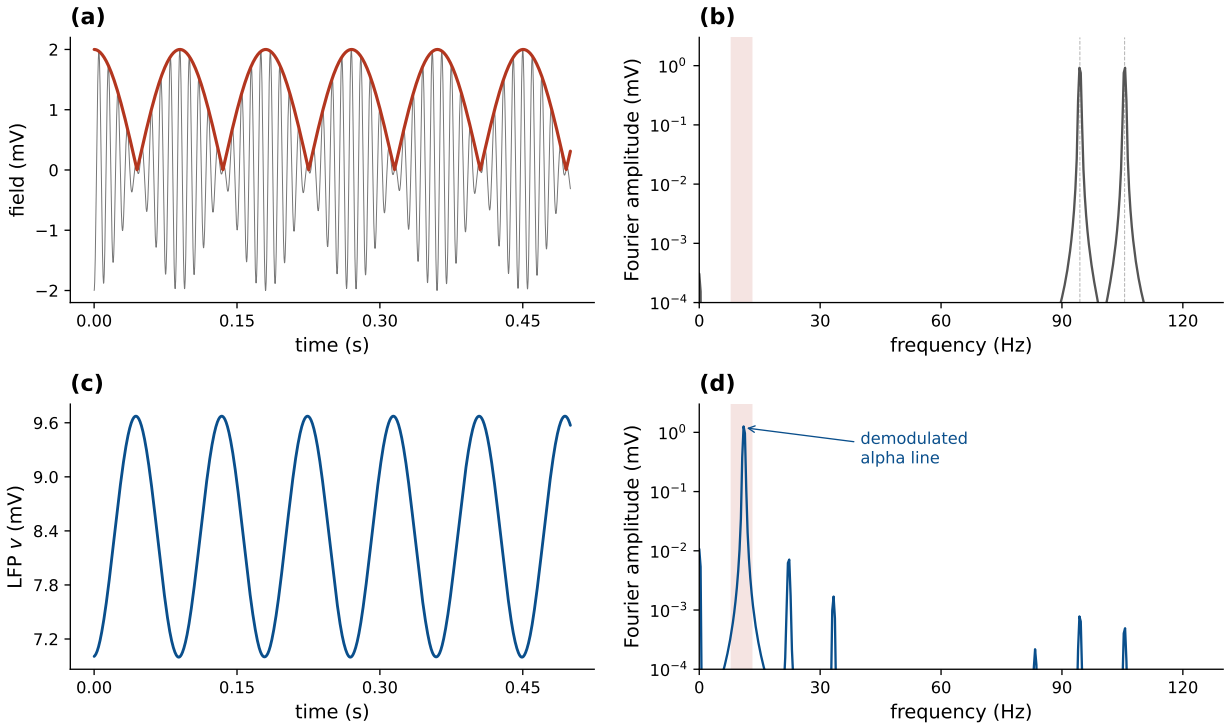


Figure 4: An alpha rhythm is synthesized from a two-tone TI input (Jansen–Rit below Hopf). The field is the physical TI waveform, two equal tones at $f_{1,2} = f_c \mp \Delta f/2$, not the amplitude-modulated surrogate. *(a)* The field $s(t)$ and its envelope $\mathcal{A}(t) = 2\varepsilon|\cos(\Omega t/2)|$—a rectified cosine, not a sinusoid; it is $\mathcal{A}^2$ that is sinusoidal at Ω (§2.5). *(b)* The input amplitude spectrum has lines only at f_1 and f_2 (94.45 and 105.55 Hz, $\Delta f = 11.1$ Hz) and no third line at the carrier; in the alpha band (shaded) it is 1.6×10^{-8} of the tone amplitude, finite-window leakage rather than physical power. *(c)* The output $v = y_1 - y_2$ oscillates at the envelope frequency. *(d)* The output spectrum has a strong peak at the beat, 11.1 Hz, synthesized by the sigmoid and absent from the input.

4 Results

The Jansen–Rit column and the exact next-generation mean field (NMM2) both generate a difference-frequency component and amplify it near a Hopf bifurcation. The former uses a memoryless sigmoid; the latter derives the nonlinearity from QIF dynamics. Their detector coefficients differ, but both separate beat generation from recurrent gain. Coupling controls that gain at fixed generated drive in the JR column (§4.6), and resonance amplifies beat-locked modulation more strongly than the mean rate (§4.7). The TI/tACS comparison then isolates their shared amplifier (§4.8), before the NMM2 and QIF results connect dynamic mixing and gain to spikes and field-induced gamma. The laminar two-band column extends the analysis to carriers of 25–80 Hz and drives up to 3 mV (App. E).

4.1 The Jansen–Rit sigmoid demodulates: an alpha line from a carrier-only input

An input containing only the two tones $f_c \mp \Delta f/2$ produces an output oscillation at their 11.1 Hz beat, near the column's alpha resonance (Fig. 3). The alpha peak is absent from the input spectrum (Fig. 4).

4.2 Near the Hopf, the demodulated beat drives a sharp resonance

In the stable-focus regime ($p > p_H$), the response is approximately Lorentzian and its peak grows from 0.23 to 0.43 to 0.70 mV toward the Hopf (Fig. 5), as expected from the $1/\gamma$ susceptibility. Without a drive the focus is silent at Ω; the nonlinearity generates that component and recurrence

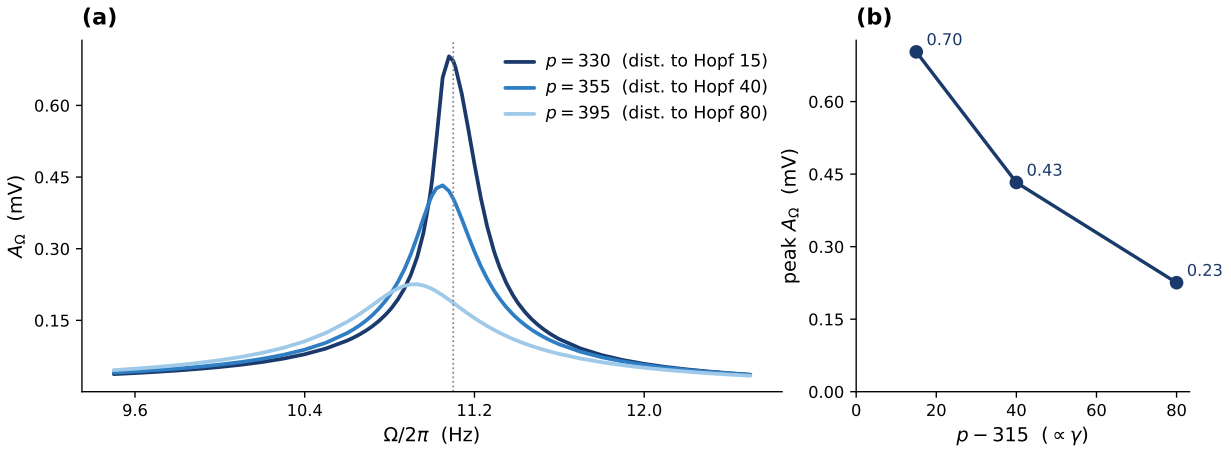


Figure 5: The demodulated beat drives a resonance that sharpens toward the Hopf (Jansen–Rit). Fixed-point regime ($p > p_H$, stable focus): lock-in response at Ω vs. envelope frequency ($\varepsilon = 0.3$ mV). *(a)* The demodulated drive forces an approximately Lorentzian resonance near $f_0 \approx 11.2$ Hz. The measured finite-amplitude peak shifts from 11.08 to 10.93 Hz across the curves as the operating state changes; Eq. (19) describes its near-Hopf scaling, not its exact location. The response carries no power at Ω in the absence of drive, so this is forced gain. *(b)* The peak height grows as the Hopf is approached ($p \to p_H$ from above). Three points cannot establish a power law; the $1/\gamma$ scaling is quantified over a decade, together with its saturation, in Fig. 9(c). The above-Hopf regime, with autonomous alpha activity, is characterized by output frequency in Fig. S4.

amplifies it. On the alpha branch below p_H, the column free-runs at f_0, so the lock-in can contain both driven and autonomous activity. The dominant output frequency f_{out} then identifies a frequency-dominance region (Fig. S4), without establishing phase capture.

4.3 Carrier independence and the kHz roll-off

At fixed post-coupling polarization the demodulated response is flat across the carrier band, for both the open-loop detector and the closed-loop column near the Hopf (Fig. 6). As a function of the *applied* field, by contrast, the membrane low-pass makes the response roll off as $1/f_c^2$ above the corner in the point-membrane model (Fig. S5). Its 16 ms response gives beat attenuation of about 10^{-4}–10^{-6} at 1–10 kHz; the cable-end case in App. B.1, Eq. (29), gives about 10^{-2}–10^{-3}. The assumed 0.2 ms point-membrane response retains appreciable carrier access.

We also drive the full recurrent column with a kHz field, passing it through an explicit membrane low-pass (an extra first-order state, time constant τ) for each modeled compartment before its polarization reaches the sigmoid. The column demodulates and resonates at the recovered alpha in the fast-access case ($\tau = 0.2$ ms), as Eq. (21) predicts (Fig. S9a). With two genuine tones centered at 2 kHz and beating at 10.914 Hz, the output contains the beat absent from the input (Fig. S6); the analytic access factor is $|H_m|^2 = 0.137$ for $\tau = 0.2$ ms. This quantifies the fast-access hypothesis under the specified response time and coupling.

4.4 The nonlinearity is the detector: the σ'' curvature law and its controls

The signed open-loop response tracks $\frac{1}{2}\sigma''(v^*)\varepsilon^2 m$ across the operating range, vanishing and reversing sign at the inflection v_0 (Fig. 7)—demodulation is the sigmoid-curvature term of Eq. (10), and the closed-loop operating points sit where σ'' is large and negative.

In the recurrent column, the response scales quadratically at small drive (log–log slope 1.99, measured as in §3.2), and linearizing the field-receiving sigmoid reduces it from 1.34 to 0.0021 mV (Fig. 7b,c). The open-loop surrogate comparison in panel (d) supports its use for leading-order beat sweeps, with the waveform and near-Hopf limitations specified in §3.1.

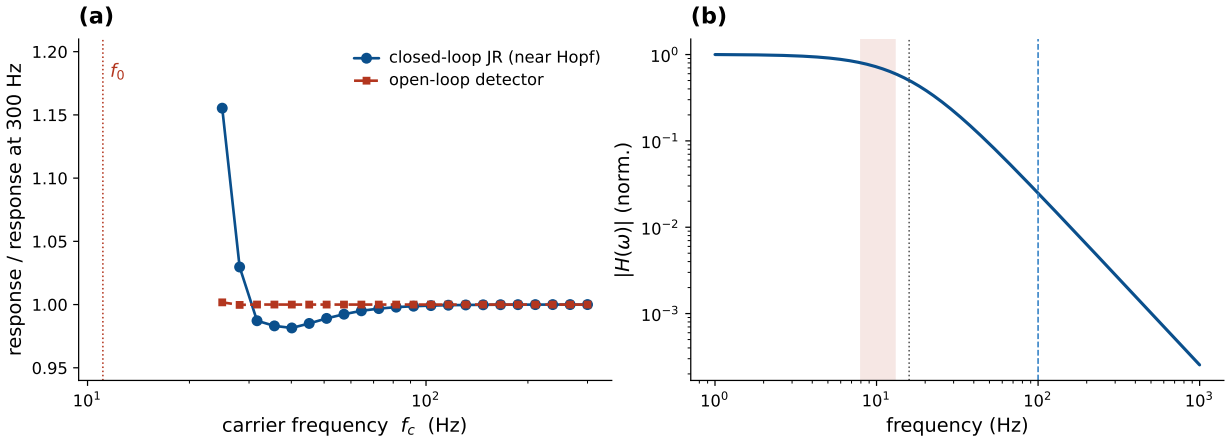


Figure 6: The demodulated response is carrier-independent at fixed polarization (Jansen–Rit). *(a)* The demodulated response is nearly flat across carrier frequency $f_c = 25$–300 Hz for the open-loop detector and for the closed-loop JR near the Hopf, with deviations as f_c approaches the natural band. Each curve is normalized by its own response at 300 Hz: 0.00670 s^{-1} open loop and 0.512 mV closed loop. Their ratio is a rate-to-voltage transfer of 76.4 mV s. The open-loop carrier independence follows to leading order from Eq. (10). *(b)* The second-order-synapse low-pass $|H_s(\omega)|/|H_s(0)|$ passes the envelope ($\sim$0.7) and suppresses the 100 Hz carrier ($\sim$2.5%). Dotted line: synaptic corner $a/2\pi \approx 16$ Hz; shaded band: envelope (8–13 Hz); dashed line: 100 Hz carrier.

4.5 Realistic-head comparison of envelope and quadratic maps

[PLACEHOLDER: Figure 8 will compare the envelope excursion $2\min(|\varepsilon_1|, |\varepsilon_2|)$, quadratic excursion $2|\varepsilon_1\varepsilon_2|$, and quadratic mean $(\varepsilon_1^2 + \varepsilon_2^2)/2$ on the Violante montage in the Ernie head model. R. Salvador will report the maps for 1:1 and 1:3 pair-current ratios and a ratio sweep, together with target-to-cortex ratios and focus displacement in mm relative to 1:1. All maps will use the same local polarizations and a projection direction held fixed at each location across ratios; an envelope-maximizing direction, if used, will be chosen at the reference ratio and then held fixed. An isotropic orientation-averaged quadratic beat map will be shown separately. No FEM results are available in this draft.]

4.6 Coupling sets the gain at fixed detection

The resonance sweeps above drove the column toward the Hopf with the external input p, but p also shifts the operating point, entangling detection (σ'') with amplification. To isolate amplification, we vary the JR global connectivity C and solve analytically for the drive $p(C)$ that *pins* the field-free operating point v^*, so the detection gain $\sigma''(v^*)$ and the open-loop detector amplitude $A_{\text{open}} \simeq \frac{1}{2}|\sigma''(v^*)|\varepsilon^2 m$ are held constant. As $C \to C^*$ (the Hopf, $C^* \approx 137$) the damping $\gamma \to 0$, the demodulated response grows $\sim$30$\times$ and the envelope resonance sharpens (Fig. 9a,b), a network effect since the local detector curvature is fixed while the recurrent transfer changes. Its modal frequency and input–output projections vary with C as well as its damping. The rate-to-voltage gain A_Ω/A_{open} (mV s) tracks $1/\gamma$ before saturating near criticality (Fig. 9c); driving the same column to the Hopf through the input p rather than the coupling C gives a similar leading gain–γ trend. Both paths approach a weakly damped mode; their finite-distance gains need not coincide because the modal projections can differ.

4.7 The resonance amplifies the envelope-locked modulation more than the mean rate

Pinning v^* to hold the local detector curvature fixed, as in Fig. 9, and driving the column toward the Hopf through the coupling, we read both quantities from the same observable, the pyramidal rate $r_P = \sigma(v + s)$ with the field in its argument. With genuine two tones, its beat-locked modulation at $\Delta f = f_0$ grows 13.2$\times$ (26 to 339 mHz), tracking $1/\gamma$ before saturating; its mean shift grows

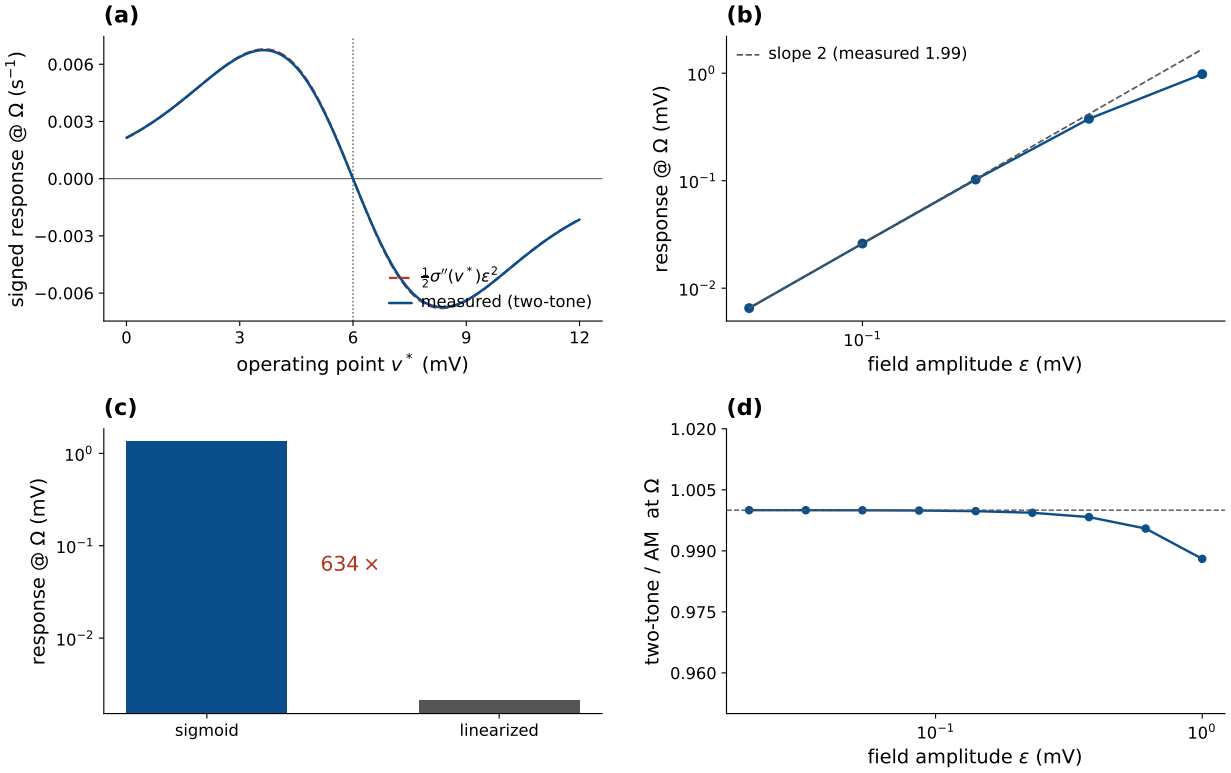


Figure 7: The curvature law, the square law, and the surrogate control (Jansen–Rit, genuine two tones). *(a)* The signed open-loop response tracks $\frac{1}{2}\sigma''(v^*)\varepsilon^2$ across the operating range (maximum deviation 0.9%), vanishing at the inflection v_0 and reversing sign across it. The mechanism is sign-agnostic: σ'' sets sign and phase while $|\sigma''|$ sets gain, so the resonance picture is unchanged up to an overall sign in the $\sigma'' > 0$ lobe, which this sweep spans. The sign flip is itself a prediction (§5.1). *(b)* The closed-loop response scales as ε^2, measured slope 1.99. *(c)* Replacing the field-receiving sigmoid by its tangent collapses the response 634×. *(d)* Surrogate control: the two-tone/AM ratio at Ω approaches 1 as $\varepsilon \to 0$ (1.0000 at 0.02 mV, 0.988 at 1 mV) for the open-loop detector at $v^* = 8$ mV. This checks the leading local source; it does not validate the recurrent AM-surrogate sweeps of Fig. 9 near the Hopf.

4.4× (−1.8 to −7.7 mHz), but stays below 0.2% of the 3.9 Hz baseline (Fig. S11). The ratio of modulation to mean-shift magnitude rises from 14.5 far from the Hopf to 58 near $\gamma = 1$ s^{-1}, then falls to 44 closest to the Hopf as rectification of the amplified oscillation accelerates the mean shift. The surrogate, whose direct DC source is 3/4 of the two-tone value, gives ratios of 19, 66, and 45. A small mean-rate change can therefore accompany a much larger beat response in this weakly driven regime, consistent with primate observations [20]; both effects are compared in the same rate units.

The demodulator feeds the network a constant term and a line at the beat Ω (Eq. (9)), and the transfer $G(\Omega)$ of Eq. (19) treats them differently: $|G(\omega_0)| \propto 1/(2\gamma\omega_0)$ diverges as the Hopf is approached, while $|G(0)| \propto 1/(\omega_0^2 + \gamma^2)$ stays finite. This comparison describes the response to the detector's DC and beat sources. The growing beat response itself rectifies and contributes another mean shift, quadratic in its amplitude. Before saturation that contribution can grow as $1/\gamma^2$, so bounded $G(0)$ does not imply a bounded mean shift throughout the approach to the Hopf.

4.8 TI and tACS share the linear amplifier

TI and direct low-frequency stimulation share the same linear amplifier. Matching their generated in-band drives therefore matches their linear outputs; resonance alone gives TI no efficiency advantage. For the AM surrogate with amplitude $\varepsilon_{\mathrm{TI}}$ and modulation depth m, and a tACS input

FEM: envelope vs quadratic maps on the Violante montage, Ernie head model (R. Salvador)

Figure 8: [PLACEHOLDER: Planned FEM comparison; maps and results to be supplied by R. Salvador. No simulation results are shown.]

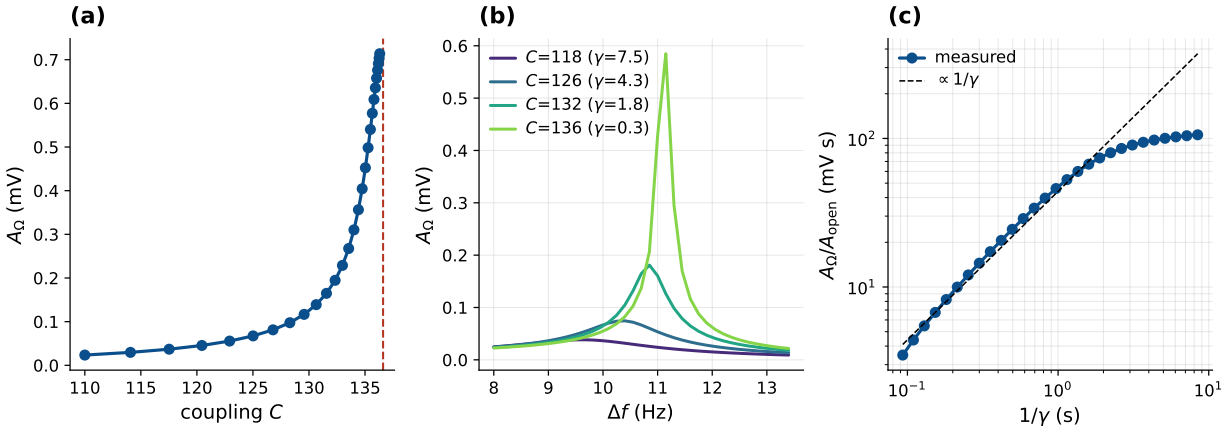


Figure 9: Coupling controls the amplification at fixed detection (Jansen–Rit). The input is the AM surrogate of Eq. (23). The field-free operating point v^* is pinned by co-solving $p(C)$, so $\sigma''(v^*) = -0.151\ \text{s}^{-1}\text{mV}^{-2}$ and A_{open} are held constant throughout. *(a)* The demodulated A_Ω grows as the coupling C approaches the Hopf C^* from the stable-focus side ($\gamma > 0$). *(b)* The envelope resonance sharpens and grows as $C \to C^*$. *(c)* The network gain A_Ω/A_{open}, in mV s, follows $1/\gamma$ (dashed) and saturates near the bifurcation.

of amplitude $\varepsilon_{\text{tACS}}$, the ratio of voltage lock-in amplitudes in linear response is

$$\mathcal{R}_{\text{lin}} = \frac{|\sigma''(v^*)|\,\varepsilon_{\text{TI}}^2 m}{2\sigma'(v^*)\,\varepsilon_{\text{tACS}}}.$$

The common network transfer cancels, so the ratio has no dependence on γ when both responses are linear about the same state. At the amplitudes used in Figs. 9 and S3, $\mathcal{R}_{\text{lin}} = 0.143$. The surrogate sweeps give approximately 0.14 far from the Hopf, rising to 0.24 at $\gamma = 1.07\ \text{s}^{-1}$ and 0.47 at $0.12\ \text{s}^{-1}$. Genuine two tones give 0.14, 0.24, and 0.46, respectively, a change of at most 2.2% across the grid. These are response ratios for the stated unequal input amplitudes, not an equal-power comparison. In controls at three couplings, matching the tACS input to TI's leading beat source gives TI/tACS output ratios of 0.99, 0.94, and 0.92 for the surrogate, and 0.99, 0.93, and 0.90 for two tones. Increasing that direct input by a factor of 6.99 increases its response by 6.97, 3.95, and 1.96, respectively. The larger response saturates earlier, with stimulation-induced mean shifts that field-free pinning does not cancel; this accounts for the finite-amplitude departure from the linear ratio near criticality.

4.9 Exact mean-field confirmation: the NMM2 PING gamma generator

The exact PING mean field generates and amplifies the beat through its derived v_E^2 nonlinearity. With a 300 Hz two-tone field entering the excitatory current, the lock-in of r_E shows a growing gamma resonance below the Hopf and a response superposed on autonomous gamma above it

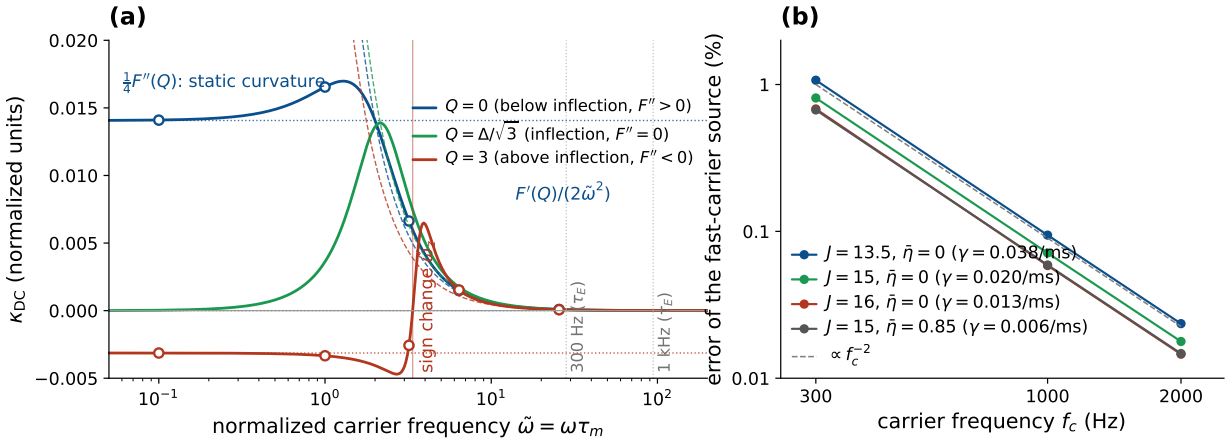


Figure 10: Static curvature at slow carriers, slope at fast ones. *(a)* Second-order DC rate shift of an uncoupled MPR population ($\Delta = 1$, dimensionless membrane-time variables) under a current carrier, Eq. (11), for operating points below, at and above the inflection of $F(Q)$. Dotted: the static limit $\frac{1}{4}F''$; dashed: the fast-carrier limit $F'/(2\tilde{\omega}^2)$; circles: RK4 integrations at $I_{ac} = 0.05$ averaged over whole carrier periods (relative error below 10^{-3}). Above the inflection the sign changes at $\tilde{\omega}_z$. The horizontal coordinate is $\tilde{\omega} = \omega\tau_m$; the carrier markers use $\tau_m = \tau_E = 15$ ms. *(b)* PING of Eq. (25): relative error of the fast-carrier difference-frequency source against the exact second-order response at four stable operating points (γ the damping of the gamma mode), two tones centered at 300, 1000 and 2000 Hz.

(Figs. 11, S8). The resonance ridge intensifies through the Hopf; its appreciable frequency shift with operating point makes it diagonal, unlike the JR sweep shown here [31].

This derived detector lies on the fast side of its crossover at 300 Hz: carrier voltage excursions mix through v_E^2 before the rate reads the result. For the full eight-state PING (Eq. (25)), each high-frequency current tone of amplitude I_j produces a voltage phasor $I_j/(i\omega_j\tau_E)$. The v_E^2 term therefore supplies a difference-frequency source of magnitude $I_1 I_2/(\tau_E^2\omega_1\omega_2)$ inside the equation for $\tau_E\dot{v}_E$. After division by τ_E, this source is propagated through the network susceptibility at Ω. At four stable operating points, the resulting response agrees with the full second-order calculation to within 1.1% at 300 Hz, 0.1% at 1 kHz, and 0.03% at 2 kHz (Fig. 10b).

In NMM2 PING, J is the mean inter-neuron QIF synaptic weight. Sweeping J at fixed background drive toward the gamma Hopf reveals two competing modes (Fig. S10). A second mode near 55 Hz carries the linear-response peak over $14.6 \lesssim J \lesssim 16.2$; the critical mode carries it at lower couplings and again near the Hopf, where its frequency is about 50 Hz. In that near-Hopf interval, $0.0014 \lesssim \gamma \lesssim 0.0081$ ms^{-1}, the linear gain scales as $1/\gamma$ with a fitted exponent of 1.02 over a 5.8-fold damping range. The full-sweep exponent is 0.71, so a single-mode law does not describe the whole curve. This refines the coupling-controlled sensitivity expected in QIF networks [31]: both coupling and rectifier are derived, but the dominant mode can change.

At $A_f = 8$, the simulated response exceeds the normalized linear reference by up to 48% in the amplitude check, then saturates. At a quarter of that amplitude ($A_f = 2$, one sixteenth of the power), the departures stay within 11% at the nine tested couplings. The normalization and endpoint-stability checks are given in §3.5; γ always describes the field-free critical mode, not the driven state. The alpha JR and gamma NMM2 circuits share the $1/\gamma$ gain scaling of their critical mode despite their different mixers, with amplification adjustable through coupling.

4.10 QIF responses distinguish beat modulation from field-induced gamma

Below the field-induced Hopf, the QIF network shows beat-locked modulation with a small mean-rate change; above it, the field induces gamma and adds a beat component. The 8000-neuron populations test this distinction at the spike level [29, 26, 31] (Figs. 12, 13).

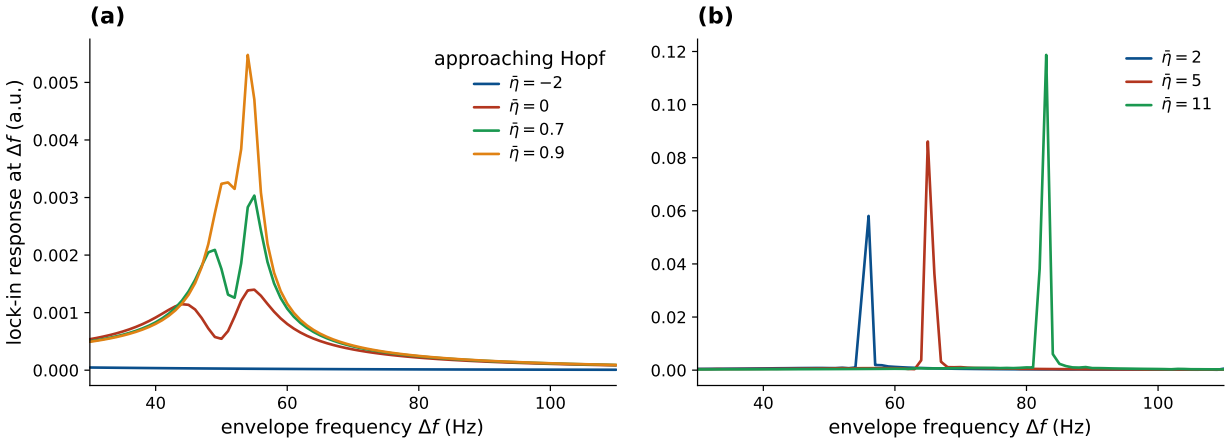


Figure 11: NMM2 PING gamma resonance (exact mean field, genuine two tones). Lock-in response of the excitatory rate r_E at the envelope frequency Δf under a two-tone TI field (carrier 300 Hz). *(a)* (stable focus, $\bar{\eta} < \bar{\eta}_H = 1.110$) forced resonance at the gamma frequency ($f_0 \approx 54$ Hz), the peak growing $0.0014 \to 0.0030 \to 0.0055$ ms^{-1} as the Hopf is approached ($1/\gamma$ gain). *(b)* (limit cycle, $\bar{\eta} > \bar{\eta}_H$) response in the autonomous-gamma regime, the peak shifting upward with $\bar{\eta}$ ($56 \to 65 \to 83$ Hz). The input carries no power at Δf; the response is synthesized by the exact quadratic v^2 nonlinearity, with no sigmoid anywhere in the model. Matched AM and two-tone drives agree at Ω to 0.07% well below the Hopf and to 4% at $\bar{\eta} = 0.9$, consistent with the JR surrogate control (Fig. 7d).

The equal-RMS unmodulated carrier provides a control for this distinction in the mean field (Fig. 13c,d). It produces a rectified E-drive shift within 3% of TI's and a similar mean-rate increase. At $A_f = 35$, both waveforms induce gamma near 51 Hz, whereas TI also produces the 55 Hz beat component. At $A_f = 10$, neither induces gamma, and TI alone produces a resolved beat response. The control separates induction of an oscillation from its beat-frequency response; it has not been run in the spiking network.

The $A_f = 35$ runs are finite-amplitude illustrations: the fast-carrier estimate gives a voltage excursion $A_f/(\tau_E \omega_c) \approx 1.2$ per tone in the model's voltage units. Its rectified excitatory-drive shift is about 1.5, compared with 0.12 at $A_f = 10$. At $\bar{\eta} = 0.85$, the Hopf threshold for a drive shift applied only to the excitatory population is $\delta\eta_E^* \approx 0.286$. The larger field is therefore expected to cross this threshold, whereas the smaller one remains below it.

At $\bar{\eta} = 0.85$ and tone amplitude $A_f = 10$, the spiking network has a beat depth of 0.093 at 55 Hz and a mean-rate increase of 2.8%: modulation exceeds the fractional mean-rate change by a factor of 3.4. The mean field gives a larger depth, 0.128. The response depends on the finite spike cutoff, and quantitative convergence remains unestablished at this population size (§3.6). At $\bar{\eta} = 1.5$, the corresponding 42 Hz depth is smaller, 0.023, against a 1.6% mean-rate increase, and the existing gamma dominates the raster.

At the larger amplitude $A_f = 35$ and $\bar{\eta} = 0.85$, stimulation produces a dominant line near 52 Hz, with modulation depth about 0.70, and a smaller component at the 55 Hz beat, with depth 0.29. The second-order carrier-averaged system predicts an excitatory drive shift $\delta\eta_E \approx 1.65$, beyond the E-only Hopf threshold $\delta\eta_E^* \approx 0.286$, with a leading eigenvalue whose real part is $+0.032$ ms^{-1}. Direct mean-field integration reproduces the off-beat line, supporting the interpretation of panel (b) as field-induced gamma with a smaller forced component.

At $\bar{\eta} = 1.5$, gamma activity is already present without stimulation. With the field on, the rhythm near 53–54 Hz remains about four times larger than the 42 Hz beat-locked component. Gamma therefore dominates the raster in panel (d); the coexistence of the rhythms produces slower variations in burst height. Folding the rate on the beat phase suppresses the non-beat-locked gamma and exposes the smaller component. The inset shows that phase average, not the full rate variation.

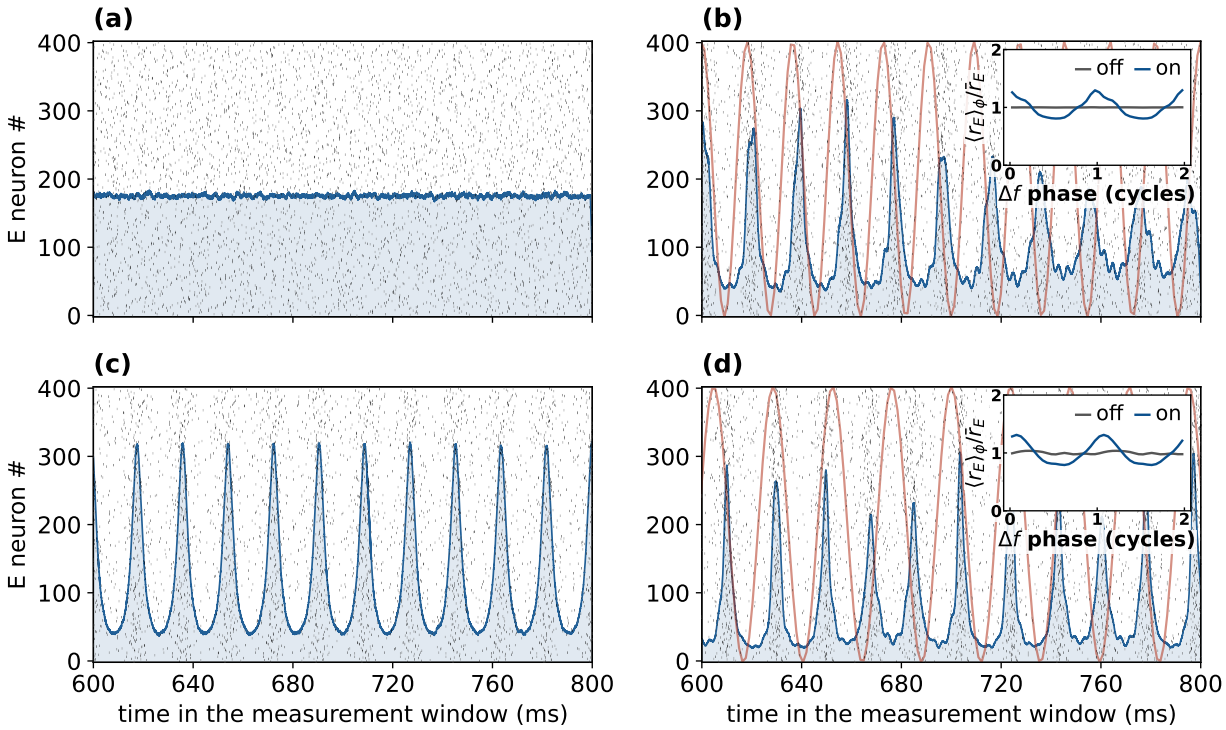


Figure 12: Beat-locked and gamma activity coexist in the QIF network. $N = 8000$ excitatory and inhibitory quadratic integrate-and-fire neurons whose exact mean field is the NMM2 PING circuit (Eq. (25)). These are finite-amplitude examples ($A_f = 35$ per tone, carrier $f_c = 300$ Hz). Black ticks are E spikes (400 of 8000), blue is the smoothed population rate on a separate scale, and red is the TI envelope in arbitrary units. *(a,b)* Field-free stable state ($\bar{\eta} = 0.85$), TI off then on at $\Delta f = 55$ Hz. The field-on response is dominated by field-induced gamma near 52 Hz (depth 0.70), with a smaller beat component (depth 0.29). *(c,d)* Field-free oscillatory state ($\bar{\eta} = 1.5$), TI off then on at $\Delta f = 42$ Hz. Gamma near 53–54 Hz dominates the raster, with depth about four times the beat component's 0.23; their coexistence gives slow variations in burst height. Depth is line amplitude divided by mean rate. The final 200 ms of the common measurement interval are shown. *Insets* in *(b,d)* fold the rate on beat phase over 44 and 34 cycles (off gray, on blue), normalized to each condition's mean. This averaging suppresses non-beat-locked gamma and displays the smaller beat component on a common 0–2 scale. The fold alone does not establish gamma-amplitude gating or phase capture.

The spectrum has sidebands near 95 and 11 Hz (Fig. S12b), establishing nonlinear mixing without distinguishing gamma-amplitude gating from phase modulation; field-free gamma frequencies agree between the spiking network and mean field (panel a).

At $A_f = 35$, the mean rate rises by about 8–11% across the two conditions, while the beat modulation depth, $A_\Omega/\langle r_E \rangle$, rises from below 0.003 to 0.29 ($\bar{\eta} = 0.85$) and 0.23 ($\bar{\eta} = 1.5$) (Fig. S12c). Modulation is about three times the relative mean-rate change, but per-neuron locking is weak: the pairwise phase consistency of single-neuron spike phases at Δf rises from its field-free control (median -0.02) to a median of 0.003–0.005, and the pooled vector strength from below 0.02 to 0.12–0.13. The population's beat-locked component is built from many weakly biased cells; these finite-amplitude runs do not establish its size under weak physiological stimulation.

5 Discussion

Access sets the local polarization, detection generates the beat, and the circuit sets its amplification. Esmaeilpour et al. [6] already related network TI sensitivity to short, axon-like membrane times and distinguished sensitivity from selectivity mediated by network adaptation. Here the exact QIF mean field connects static and dynamic mixing, the weak-input product law determines spatial

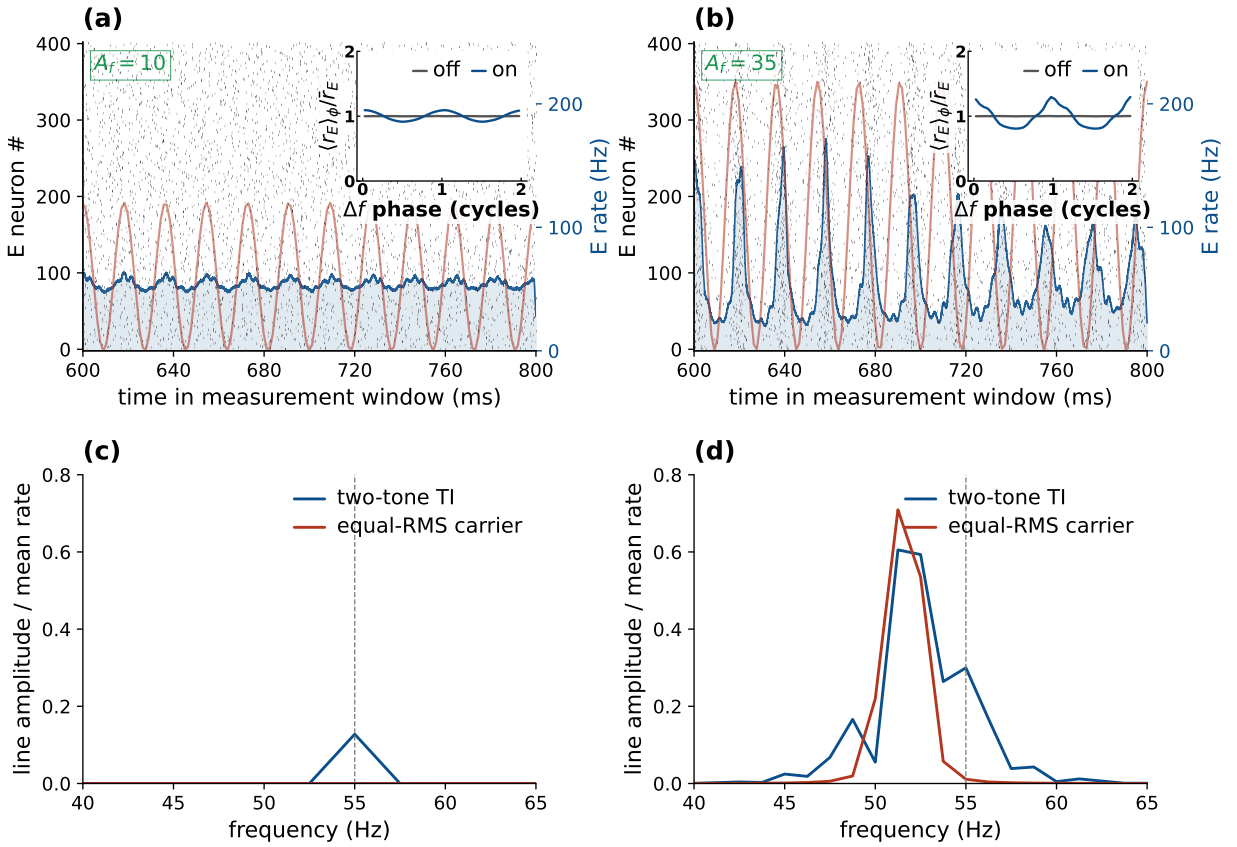


Figure 13: Beat modulation below and across the induced-gamma transition. All panels use $\bar{\eta} = 0.85$, carrier 300 Hz, and TI beat 55 Hz. *(a,b)* Spiking-network responses at $A_f = 10$ and 35 per tone, respectively: black ticks are spikes from 400 of 8000 E neurons; blue is the smoothed population rate on the common right-axis scale, and red is the envelope in arbitrary units. Insets show phase-folded rate divided by its mean (off gray, on blue), on the same scale. The beat depths are 0.093 and 0.290, and the mean-rate increases are 2.8% and 10.5%. At the larger amplitude, non-beat-locked gamma dominates the raster and is suppressed by the fold. *(c,d)* Corresponding mean-field spectra under TI (blue) and an equal-RMS single carrier (red), whose peak amplitude is $\sqrt{2}A_f$. Line amplitude is normalized by each trace's mean; the dashed line marks 55 Hz. Spectra use a Hann window over 800 ms after 800 ms settling. Both waveforms induce gamma at the larger amplitude, while TI produces the additional beat response. Increasing the measurement window from 0.8 to 3.2 s reduces the carrier's apparent 55 Hz depth from 0.011 to 9.2×10^{-5}, consistent with spectral leakage, while TI's beat depth remains 0.30–0.31. The carrier comparison is a mean-field result. The spiking panels retain $V_{\text{peak}} = 100$; at cutoffs 200–400, the $A_f = 10$ depth ranges from 0.121 to 0.141 across the two tested steps (§3.6).

weighting, and matching the generated drive exposes the linear amplifier shared by TI and tACS.

At extracellular fields of order 1 V/m, voltage-gated channels respond through membrane polarization: the direct protein effects reviewed by Cifra et al. [40] occur at 10 kV/m to GV/m, with protocol- and molecule-dependent thresholds; that review excludes fields below 0.1 kV/m, where it expects direct effects to be negligible against thermal noise. Presynaptic terminals can polarize more strongly than somata [41, 42, 43], but small size alone does not imply fast charging: specific membrane resistance times capacitance is area-independent, while conductance, geometry, and stimulation mode determine the response.

Table 3 summarizes the measurements and models that motivate shorter access times; their transfer under TI remains to be calibrated. The 1 and 0.4 ms network sensitivity cases of [6] precede the present effective-time hypothesis. Luff et al.'s pulse-width-modulated TI (PWM-TI) model uses a 1 ms passive response within a 1–100 ms parameter sweep [44]. Separately, Semenov et al. [23] measured field-induced membrane charging near 0.7 μs in isolated neurons under strong,

microsecond field pulses. This is a different response mode from intracellular current charging or periaxonal conduction. Access time and field coupling remain preparation-dependent. A 10–100-fold reduction in a QIF membrane time is therefore a sensitivity hypothesis. Its population-level consequence can be studied through the existing slow-synapse limit, with each physical filter included once; a new periaxonal circuit is not needed for that limiting argument.

At weak input, smooth cellular contributions with a nonzero second-order term combine into a quadratic mixing coefficient. QIF derives one realization without requiring identification of each channel. It connects cellular mixing [2, 10] with the network dependence seen in slices and simulations [16, 17]. Cellular mixing and circuit amplification are therefore not competing explanations.

Weak amplitude alone does not make that coefficient static. Fast population relaxation relative to synapses gives the NMM2 slow-synapse limit; relaxation must also be fast relative to the carrier for curvature to describe its mixing. Outside that limit the coefficient is dynamic. Its magnitude, phase, and frequency dependence remain model-specific, while the static slope converts slow input into rate and enters recurrent gain (§2.1).

A spatial TI dose map depends on this physiology. The usual envelope-modulation map assumes a response determined by envelope excursion; the square-law map instead weights it by the larger local polarization (Eq. (17)). Its accompanying DC source follows the summed carrier intensities under the conditions of §2.6, providing an operating-point shift that the equal-RMS carrier control isolates and that can cross the population Hopf (§4.10). Both idealized mean maps obey the boundary-maximum restriction of §2.6; the beat map does not. Orientation, access, operating point, and network susceptibility further shape the response. A sharp rectifier can approximate envelope following over a finite amplitude range; smoothing or heterogeneity can restore quadratic behavior at smaller inputs. The amplitude and harmonic tests in §3.2 distinguish these regimes.

Current-ratio experiments separate envelope geometry from the neural response map. Violante et al. [45] compared $2 + 2$ mA (1:1) with $1 + 3$ mA (1:3) through the same electrode pairs. At fixed neural state, the quadratic beat would be 3/4 as large everywhere in the 1:3 condition, whereas the mean-square polarization changes by $\mathcal{I}_{1:3}/\mathcal{I}_{1:1} = (\mathcal{P}_1^2 + 9\mathcal{P}_2^2)/[4(\mathcal{P}_1^2 + \mathcal{P}_2^2)]$: a 25% increase only where $|\mathcal{P}_1| = |\mathcal{P}_2|$, with decreases possible elsewhere. Equal summed currents therefore do not match local RMS polarization. Their encoding-stage blood-oxygen-level-dependent (BOLD) response differed directly between 1:1 and 1:3 ($P = 0.015$), with no stimulation-by-region interaction ($P = 0.76$). Envelope steering was supported by field models and cadaver measurements. The BOLD contrast and reported functional-connectivity changes are physiological effects, but neither measures the demodulated neural beat map. They therefore do not identify envelope-following detection or a DC-mediated state change; a spatial beat measurement at controlled state is needed to test the current-ratio prediction.

At higher intensities, TI and unmodulated kHz fields can have similar excitation thresholds, with modulation patterning firing rather than lowering the threshold [21, 23]; some peripheral responses do not require envelope extraction [22]. The weak-input calculation instead describes modulation of ongoing activity [20, 46], excluding direct carrier-evoked spiking and conduction block. The finite-amplitude QIF examples show a related circuit transition: the mean shift crosses the Hopf, inducing gamma alongside the beat response. Its boundary depends on both field amplitude and the initial distance from the bifurcation. These examples and the laminar extension go beyond the weak-input expansion without establishing physiological thresholds.

The recurrent amplifier is shared with direct low-frequency stimulation. Our coupling sweep fixes the JR field-free operating point and its local curvature while changing recurrent gain. A direct in-band drive shows the same $1/\gamma$ growth and resonance sharpening (Fig. S3), consistent with the known resonant susceptibility of recurrent excitatory–inhibitory networks [15, 31]. Near the Hopf, this is temporal critical slowing in a mean-field model, not evidence of a diverging spatial

correlation length. Related models already reproduce tACS entrainment and AM-driven phase locking [47, 48, 49]. When TI and tACS are matched for effective in-band input, observable, and operating state, they share the linear amplifier. Within linear response, resonance alone therefore gives TI no efficiency advantage. At finite amplitude the response ratio can change near the Hopf, as the coupling sweep demonstrates (§4.8); its value then depends on drive amplitude and the driven state as well as on field-free damping.

Absolute response estimates remain sensitive to access and transduction. Measured DC field-to-voltage couplings are 0.12–0.18 mV per V/m in hippocampus (0.21 at 10 Hz AC) [50, 51] and reach about 0.5 mV per V/m in cortical L5/6 pyramidal cells [52]; human cortical fields near 0.8 V/m have been reported at 2 mA [53, 54]. These static couplings do not fix the coupling at kHz. For equal TI carrier polarizations ε, the JR beat drive is $\sigma''\varepsilon^2/2$, whereas a direct drive of the same peak polarization gives $2\sigma'\varepsilon$. Their leading amplitude ratio is $\mathcal{R}_{\mathrm{det}} \simeq |\sigma''|\varepsilon/(4\sigma')$: the relative efficiency decreases as the input is weakened in this perturbative regime. A larger recurrent gain amplifies both drives.

For scale, a reverberation time $\tau_{\mathrm{rev}} = 1/\gamma$ gives a near-Hopf quality factor $\mathcal{Q} = \pi f_0 \tau_{\mathrm{rev}}$ and power bandwidth approximately $1/(\pi\tau_{\mathrm{rev}})$. Population relaxation over a few hundred milliseconds [55] would give a quality factor of order ten at 10 Hz and a bandwidth of order 1 Hz. This is an order-of-magnitude comparison: the measured relaxation is not specific to the alpha mode. Narrow amplification also makes detuning consequential.

Primate measurements illustrate the limits of an efficiency comparison. Vieira et al. [20] reported two distinct experiments. Their two-pair TI comparison gave a phase-locking effect ratio of 0.34 against tACS (95% confidence interval 0.04–0.65, 65 of 154 neurons), without correcting for TI currents up to ±2.5 mA per pair versus ±1 mA for tACS. A separate single-pair AM-tACS control compensated for frequency-dependent shunting to match extracellular modulation depth. Of twenty cells, ten responded to either modality and seven to both; in the latter group, median phase-locking value (PLV) was 0.10 for AM-tACS and 0.20 for tACS, against 0.043 at baseline. The reported TI modulation depths were about 0.5–0.62 V/m. These weaker TI and AM effects are compatible with a weaker generated beat drive, but neither experiment matched polarization at the mixer, and PLV depends on baseline and state. They therefore do not calibrate this paper's detector coefficient; that requires the same timing readout across a local-polarization amplitude sweep.

For an illustrative fast-access budget, take a per-tone field $E_j = 0.5$ V/m, $\lambda_0 = 0.5$ mV per V/m, $f_c = 2$ kHz, and the assumed $\tau_m = 0.2$ ms. Then $\varepsilon = \lambda_0 E_j |H_m| \approx 0.092$ mV, rounded to 0.1 mV for scale; this is an assumed coupling budget, not an inferred polarization in the recorded cells. At $v^* = 8.30$ mV the JR detector gives $\mathcal{R}_{\mathrm{det}} \approx 0.8\%$ for 0.1 mV, for the generated drive relative to a matched-peak direct input. The smooth JR detector is therefore weak under this access budget, even though recurrence can amplify its output. A measured PLV effect cannot be compared directly with this drive ratio; a polarization-calibrated amplitude sweep with the same readout would test the estimate.

For comparison, the carrier-averaged, matched-peak, open-loop drive ratio has a numerically estimated supremum of 0.348 over bounded nondecreasing memoryless transfers (App. D). The positive-mixture-of-steps argument extends the logistic result to this class. Approaching it requires an active transition sharp relative to the input; for the logistic family at the illustrative polarizations, this means microvolt widths. The limiting detector is step-like and has a second-harmonic ratio near 0.15, distinct from both weak square-law detection and linear envelope following. This bound does not cover the dynamic QIF detector or all cellular mechanisms. A larger common matched polarization does not exceed the class bound; unequal actual polarizations can instead invalidate the matching. The unequal-current TI ratio and the matched-depth AM-tACS control do not measure this matched-peak, open-loop ratio. Thus approaching the ceiling would require leaving the smooth weak-input regime used here; within that regime, local curvature determines

the generated drive.

Access and mixing require calibration; their values are not fixed by the quadratic law, and cascading ordinary synaptic filters cannot improve access because they attenuate the carrier before a subsequent detector receives it. The response also depends on the neuron model: Hodgkin–Huxley and Frankenhaeuser–Huxley models reproduce stimulus-evoked firing missed by the tested leaky, exponential, and adaptive-exponential integrate-and-fire models [56], without invalidating the weak-input expansion. Noise, heterogeneity beyond the assumed excitability distribution, and intercolumn interactions can broaden or shift the deterministic resonances. Human evidence is mixed, including peripheral effects without central effects [57] and null occipito-parietal alpha-power modulation [58]. Testing this mechanism therefore requires access, generated beat, and network tuning measured in the same preparation.

5.1 Falsifiable predictions and tests

Table 4 separates tests of access, detection, and amplification from observations already consistent with the model. Quantitative reanalysis of the timing and synaptic-blockade data requires the amplitude and harmonic controls of §3.2, with detector and network changes measured separately.

Table 4: Predictions, existing evidence, and tests. Published observations provide qualitative comparisons; their quantitative reanalysis remains to be done.

Prediction (model basis)	Existing evidence	Proposed test
Carrier dependence. At fixed local polarization, the leading beat is carrier-independent in the static limit and fast-carrier QIF asymptote, provided no other circuit mode is excited. Access restores dependence at fixed applied field; detector dynamics can add it near the crossover.	Carrier-frequency comparisons show changes in network sensitivity [6] and subthreshold single-cell mixing [10], without holding measured local carrier polarizations fixed. Thresholds depend on f_c [21, 22], and bare kHz fields have limited effects on hippocampal oscillations [59].	Measure each local polarization while sweeping f_c at fixed beat and state; normalize the weak beat by their product. Hold network gain fixed or measure it independently to separate access from residual detector dependence. Measure any residual cutoff rather than assigning it to a compartment.
Independent carrier amplitudes. At fixed detector and network gains, quadratic modulation excursion follows $2\lvert\varepsilon_1\varepsilon_2\rvert$; an ideal envelope follower tracks $2\min(\lvert\varepsilon_1\rvert, \lvert\varepsilon_2\rvert)$ (Eq. (17), Table 2).	The unequal-amplitude spatial example separates these maps; a biological test with independent local-polarization calibration is not supplied here.	Hold the weaker polarization fixed and vary the stronger, then swap tones. Keep both inputs weak, frequencies fixed, and the operating state controlled. Reconstruct the slow-response excursion after correcting network filtering; a beat lock-in alone does not measure the envelope's full excursion.
Current-ratio steering. With fixed electrode pairs, frequencies, access, and neural state, the quadratic beat map scales with $I_1^{\mathrm{pair}} I_2^{\mathrm{pair}}$; its normalized pattern does not move. An envelope follower can instead shift its maximum.	Cassarà et al. identify the product-law restriction [34]. The realistic-montage and physiological beat-map comparisons remain proposed tests.	Vary the current ratio at fixed electrodes and compare normalized beat maps and target-to-cortex ratios. Keep the projection direction fixed at each site, including any direction chosen to maximize the envelope at a reference ratio. Measure the DC shift and repeat at lower amplitude to check state dependence.

Continued on next page

Table 4 continued

Prediction (model basis)	Existing evidence	Proposed test
State and carrier dependence. The static sigmoid follows σ'' and reverses sign at its inflection (PEIX= 0). Fast-carrier QIF mixes in voltage and reads the source through rate and network susceptibility; its DC term follows F' without the same sign rule (§2.3).	Cell-type-specific responses (PV versus pyramidal) are reported [16]; the detector coefficient remains model-dependent.	Vary tonic drive and carrier frequency at fixed beat; measure beat amplitude and phase. Compare with the predicted coefficient after accounting for network susceptibility. Amplitude changes alone do not isolate detection.
Transduction class. At a matched site, weak smooth detection with nonzero curvature gives $Y_\Omega \propto \varepsilon^2$ and a harmonic ratio vanishing as $\varepsilon \to 0$. An ideal envelope follower gives $Y_\Omega \propto \varepsilon$ and ratio 1/5; a threshold has onset $2\varepsilon = \delta$ and a variable ratio.	Untested with local-polarization calibration; existing comparisons match extracellular field rather than ε.	Sweep amplitude off resonance, reading both the log–log slope and $\lvert Y_{2\Omega}/Y_\Omega\rvert$. Near resonance, suppression by approximately $3\mathcal{Q}$ requires correction with an independently measured $G(2\Omega)/G(\Omega)$ (§3.2).
Frequency selectivity. The beat response peaks at the region's resonant rhythm and grows as $1/\gamma$ near its Hopf; state changes can alter both the generated drive and the recurrent gain [24].	The quantitative gain–bandwidth relation is not tested here in biological data.	Sweep Δf through the intrinsic band across brain states and track the peak frequency, height, and width.
Timing versus rate. Beat modulation can exceed the mean shift; their ratio peaks and then falls as the amplified oscillation rectifies (§4.7–4.10).	Qualitatively consistent with TI altering spike timing more than mean rate in primates [20].	Compare beat lock-in with mean-rate change in commensurate effect measures, retaining the finite-amplitude qualification.
Network readout. Population nonlinearity and synaptic recurrence contribute to the measured response.	Most pyramidal TI responses vanish under synaptic blockade [16], supporting network involvement without excluding cellular mixing.	Test whether synaptic blockade reduces recurrent amplification while preserving a cellular detector.
Equal-power carrier control. At second order, equal local RMS polarization gives the same steady source when the carriers see the same DC coefficient. TI also supplies a beat; either waveform can induce an oscillation if the mean shift crosses a bifurcation.	Demonstrated in the PING mean field (Fig. 13c,d). The corresponding spiking-network and in vivo controls are not provided here.	Compare two tones with one carrier of matched RMS polarization and duration, checking the DC coefficient across the carrier interval. Measure mean activity, intrinsic oscillations, and beat lock-in separately to distinguish the steady shift from the beat response.

6 Conclusion

For weak perturbations of ongoing activity, a nonzero second-order response makes the TI beat proportional to the product of the local carrier polarizations, rather than the envelope minimum. Its steady source follows their summed squares; the magnitude of this source and the ideal envelope mean have no strict interior maximum in a compartment uniform in conductivity, access, and detection. Fast access through nodes or the AIS is represented by a short effective membrane

time, with periaxonal circuitry motivating distinct axonal and somatic responses. Its TI transfer and the absolute response at human field strengths require calibration.

TI and direct low-frequency stimulation share the circuit amplifier when the generated input, observable, and operating state are matched and both responses are linear. Resonance alone then gives TI no efficiency advantage; finite-amplitude responses near the Hopf can depart from that ratio. Fast population relaxation recovers a static rate map with dynamic synapses, but static carrier mixing requires relaxation faster than the carrier as well. Fast access and slow network resonance can coexist, with each filter counted once; a large response alone identifies neither an efficient detector nor its microscopic mechanism.

In the pinned JR sweep, beat-locked rate modulation grows more than the mean-rate shift toward the Hopf. Their ratio peaks and then falls as the amplified response itself rectifies, so timing can dominate without the mean shift vanishing.

At larger fields, the rectified shift can carry the QIF circuit across its Hopf and induce gamma. An equal-power unmodulated carrier produces the same transition in the mean-field control, while TI adds the beat response. Separately measuring local polarization, the generated beat, and circuit gain distinguishes these mechanisms and calibrates the three stages.

Code and data availability

Simulation code, cached results, and figure-generation scripts are provided at the paper's GitHub repository; the public archive is linked through Zenodo (doi:10.5281/zenodo.21009618). The repository `README` maps figures to their scripts and distinguishes recomputation from replotting cached data. A reconstructed producer with explicit run settings reproduces every archived spectral bin of the two-tone kHz illustration (Fig. S6) exactly. The LaNMM setup is a drawn schematic. The LaNMM carrier comparison has both measurement-window caches and a reproducible summary script. The code is released under CC-BY-4.0.

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Declaration of generative AI and AI-assisted technologies in the manuscript preparation process

During the preparation of this work the authors used Anthropic Claude and OpenAI ChatGPT to streamline the narrative and to assist with code and figure generation from data the authors produced. The authors reviewed and edited all resulting content and take full responsibility for the content of the published article.

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A Notation and units

Table 5 groups the symbols by their role in the calculation. JR and LaNMM voltages are in mV and rates in s^{-1}. QIF voltages and current-like drives are dimensionless model variables; QIF rates are physical rates, integrated in ms^{-1} and converted to Hz where indicated. A tilde marks the dimensionless membrane-time variables of the uncoupled MPR calculation. All frequencies and time constants in a formula must use the same time unit. A star marks a fixed point or, on a bifurcation parameter, its critical value. Subscripts E and I identify excitatory and inhibitory populations; they are not field or current variables.

Table 5: Notation and units. "Normalized" means dimensionless in the stated model scaling; output units depend on the named observable. Numbered references identify main-text definitions; lettered locations identify appendices (in the supplement for the JNE edition).

Symbol	Meaning	Units	Defined in
Field and access			
$E(t), E_0, \mathbf{E}_j$	Applied field, its amplitude, and vector field of tone $j = 1, 2$	V/m	Eq. (7)
$s(t), \varepsilon_j, \varepsilon$	Local polarization; tone amplitudes; common amplitude ($\varepsilon_{\mathrm{TI}}$ and $\varepsilon_{\mathrm{tACS}}$ label the waveform)	mV	Eqs. (1), (8)
$I_j^{\mathrm{pair}}, \mathcal{P}_j$	Peak electrode-pair current; signed local polarization per unit current	mA; mV/mA	§2.5
$\mathcal{A}(t), \overline{\mathcal{A}}$	Nonnegative polarization envelope and its beat-period mean	mV	Eq. (16); Table 2
f_1, f_2, f_c	Tone frequencies and their center	Hz	Eq. (1)
ω_j, ω_c	Angular frequencies $2\pi f_j, 2\pi f_c$	rad/s	Eqs. (1), (8)
$\Delta f, \Omega$	Beat frequency $f_2 - f_1$; $\Omega = 2\pi\Delta f$	Hz; rad/s	Eq. (1)
m	AM-surrogate modulation depth	dimensionless	Eq. (23)
$\Lambda[E], \lambda_0, \lambda_f$	Field-induced polarization; static and frequency-dependent coupling	mV; mV/(V/m)	Eqs. (3), (8)
$\boldsymbol{\lambda}_0^k, \boldsymbol{\lambda}_f^k$	Coupling vectors for compartment k	mV/(V/m)	Eq. (8)
H, H_k, H_m	Dominant-compartment access transfer, indexed transfer, and point-membrane transfer	dimensionless	Fig. 2; §2.2, §2.8
τ_m, τ	Membrane time; access-filter time in kHz controls	ms	Eqs. (4), (21)
f_{char}	Characteristic frequency $1/(2\pi\tau)$	Hz	Table 3
$\ell(\omega), \ell_0$	Frequency-dependent and static cable space constants	μm	App. B.1, Eq. (29)
$\mathbf{V}, \mathsf{C}_m, \mathsf{G}_m$	Compartment voltages, capacitance and conductance matrices	V; F; S	App. B.1
$\mathbf{I}^0, \mathbf{p}_E$	Endogenous currents; field-to-current vector	A; A/(V/m)	App. B.1
$\mathbf{x}, \phi_j, \mathbf{n}$	Position, field potential, unit cell orientation	m; V; unit vector	§2.5, §2.6
$\mathcal{I}$	Mean-square local polarization $(\varepsilon_1^2 + \varepsilon_2^2)/2$	mV^2	§2.6
Detection			
$\sigma, \sigma', \sigma''$	JR/LaNMM rate curve, slope and curvature	s^{-1}; $s^{-1}mV^{-1}$; $s^{-1}mV^{-2}$	Eq. (2)
e_0, v_0, ρ	Half the rate ceiling, inflection voltage, inverse voltage scale	s^{-1}; mV; mV^{-1}	Eq. (2)
PEIX	Signed sigmoid saturation index	dimensionless	Eq. (22)
$Y_\Omega, Y_{\mathrm{DC}}$	Complex beat amplitude and signed mean shift before recurrence	detector-output units	Eqs. (10), (9)
$\chi^{(2)}$	Dynamic coefficient mapping a polarization product to a rate beat	$s^{-1}mV^{-2}$	§2.2
g, T, Y_{LF}	Memoryless response, envelope transduction, carrier-averaged output	specified output units	Eq. (14)

Continued on next page

Table 5 continued

Symbol	Meaning	Units	Defined in
c_1, c_2, c_4	Linear, quadratic and quartic envelope coefficients	output/(mV)^{1,2,4}	§2.4
$\mathcal{H}_{\mathrm{det}}, \mathcal{H}_{\mathrm{meas}}$	Second/fundamental harmonic magnitude ratios before and after the network	dimensionless	Eq. (15)
$\mathcal{M}[y]$	Peak-to-peak excursion of the quantity y	units of y	Eq. (17)
$F(Q), F', F''$	MPR steady-rate curve and drive derivatives	normalized	Eq. (5)
Q, q	Mean total drive $\bar{\eta} + I$; single-cell drive $\eta + I$	normalized	Eq. (5); App. B.2
$I_{\mathrm{ac}}, \tilde{\omega}$	Single-tone current amplitude; angular frequency $\omega\tau_m$	normalized	§2.3
$\kappa_{\mathrm{DC}}, \kappa_V$	Mean-rate mixing per squared current or squared voltage excursion	normalized	Eqs. (11), (13)
$d, \nu, \tilde{\omega}_z$	MPR relaxation, ringing and zero-crossing angular frequencies	membrane-time units	§2.3
$\mathsf{J}, \mathbf{h}, H_v$	Reduced MPR Jacobian, unit-current response and voltage transfer	normalized	§2.3; App. B.2
$\mathbf{b}_2, \mathsf{I}_2$	Quadratic DC source per I_{ac}^2; identity matrix	normalized	App. B.2
$\mathcal{R}_{\mathrm{det}}, \mathcal{R}_{\mathrm{lin}}$	TI/direct-drive source ratio; linear TI/tACS output ratio	dimensionless	App. D; §4.8
δ, ζ	Threshold offset; sigmoid rate divided by $2e_0$	mV; dimensionless	§2.4; App. D
$u, \xi, \beta, k_{\mathrm{ell}}^2$	Reduced amplitude $\rho\varepsilon$, offset $\rho(v^* - v_0)$, threshold ratio, elliptic parameter	dimensionless	App. D
$L, \psi, \mathsf{K}, \mathsf{E}$	Unit logistic, normalized waveform, complete elliptic integrals	dimensionless	App. D
Network			
r_X, v_X	Population firing rate and mean potential, indexed by X	s^{-1}; mV in JR/LaNMM, normalized in QIF	§2.1
$\tilde{t}, \tilde{r}, \tilde{f}$	Membrane-time coordinate, population rate and single-cell rate	normalized	Eq. (4); App. B.2
$r_{\mathrm{syn}}, r_E^{\mathrm{syn}}, r_I^{\mathrm{syn}}$	Synaptically filtered firing rates	same rate units as input	Eqs. (6), (25)
$u_{\mathrm{PSP}}, u_{X\leftarrow Y}, \hat{L}$	Postsynaptic potential and inverse synaptic operator	mV; maps mV to s^{-1}	Eq. (3)
A, B, a, b	JR excitatory/inhibitory PSP gains and inverse synaptic times	mV; s^{-1}	§2.1; App. B
h_e, h_i	JR excitatory and inhibitory synaptic impulse responses	mV	Fig. 2
$C, C_{1\ldots4}, C_{X\leftarrow Y}$	JR connectivity scale and pathway weights	dimensionless	§2.1; App. B
y_0, y_1, y_2, v	JR PSPs; voltage readout $v = y_1 - y_2$	mV	App. B
p, p_H, C^*	JR external rate and its upper Hopf value; critical connectivity	s^{-1}; dimensionless for C^*	§3.4, §4.6
$\eta_j, \bar{\eta}, \Delta$	QIF excitabilities, Lorentzian center and half-width	normalized	Eq. (4)
$I, I_E, I_j, A_f, \lambda_I$	QIF input, E-population input, tone amplitudes, forcing amplitude and field coupling	normalized; λ_I in (V/m)$^{-1}$	Eqs. (4), (25)
$\mathcal{U}_j$	Total synaptic and field drive to QIF neuron j	normalized	Fig. 2
J, J^*, w_{XY}	QIF coupling, critical coupling and relative pathway weights	dimensionless	Eq. (25)
$\tau_E, \tau_I, \tau_a, \tau_g, \tau_s$	E/I membrane and excitatory/inhibitory/generic synaptic times	ms	Eqs. (6), (25)
$\hat{K}_a, \hat{K}_g, H_s$	QIF synaptic rate filters; JR rate-to-voltage transfer	dimensionless; mV s for H_s	§3.5, §2.7

Continued on next page

Table 5 continued

Symbol	Meaning	Units	Defined in
$\mu_{\pm}, \gamma, \omega_0, f_0$	Modal eigenvalues, damping, angular and ordinary modal frequency	s^{-1} (ms^{-1} where stated); Hz for f_0	Eq. (19)
$\tau_{\mathrm{rel}}, \tau_{\mathrm{rev}}, \mathcal{Q}$	Population relaxation time, $1/\gamma$, and mode quality factor	time; dimensionless for $\mathcal{Q}$	§2.1, §2.7, §5
D, G, R_Ω	Beat-source coefficient, recurrent transfer, complex observed beat response	input/output-dependent	Eq. (20)
$V_j, V_{\mathrm{peak}}, N$	Single-QIF voltage, spike cutoff and neurons per population	normalized; count	§3.6
$\delta\eta_E, \delta\eta_E^*$	Rectified E-drive shift and its Hopf threshold	normalized	§3.6, §4.10
P_1, P_2, r_P, φ_X	Deep/superficial pyramidal populations; JR and LaNMM pyramidal rates	labels; s^{-1} for rates	§2.1; §E.1
$z, \alpha, \mathcal{F}, \varepsilon_{\mathrm{SL}}$	Stuart–Landau mode, growth rate, forcing and forcing amplitude	normalized mode; s^{-1} for the others	App. C
Measurement			
$L_{\cos}, L_{\sin}, A_\Omega$	Signed lock-in quadratures and nonnegative amplitude	measured voltage or rate units	Eq. (24)
A_{open}	Magnitude of the open-loop rate beat	s^{-1}	§4.6
$w_k, t_k, v_k, \bar{v}$	Hann weights, sample times, voltage samples and weighted mean	1; s; mV; mV	Eq. (24)
$A_{\mathrm{test}}, \theta_0$	Amplitude and phase of the lock-in test tone	readout units; rad	§3.2
$\Delta t, N_{\mathrm{grid}}$	Integration step and number of parameter combinations	s or ms; count	§3.4
$A_\Omega/\langle r_E \rangle$	Beat-locked population modulation depth	dimensionless	§3.6
PPC	Pairwise phase consistency of single-neuron spike phases	dimensionless	§3.6
$f_{\mathrm{out}}, S(f_c)$	Dominant output frequency; LaNMM mean off-alpha lock-in	Hz; mV	App. F; §E.1

B Simulated models: equations and parameters

The models are written in the NMM1 transfer-function formalism of Eq. (3) [26]: synaptic operators $\hat{L}$ transduce firing rates into PSPs, the PSPs sum with any direct field term $\Lambda[E]$ in the sigmoid argument, and the sigmoid returns the rate. The Jansen–Rit column is given here; the laminar model is specified in [24, 32] with its field drive in Eq. (34), and the NMM2 PING motif and its QIF network in Eq. (25) and §3.6.

Jansen–Rit column

Writing y_0 for the excitatory PSP driving the interneurons, y_1 and y_2 for the excitatory and inhibitory PSPs onto the pyramidal population, external input p, and the applied-field perturbation $s(t)$ (§2.2) entering the pyramidal sigmoid,

$$\ddot{y}_0 = Aa\,\sigma(y_1 - y_2 + s(t)) - 2a\dot{y}_0 - a^2 y_0, \tag{26}$$

$$\ddot{y}_1 = Aa\,[\,p + C_2\,\sigma(C_1 y_0)\,] - 2a\dot{y}_1 - a^2 y_1, \tag{27}$$

$$\ddot{y}_2 = Bb\,C_4\,\sigma(C_3 y_0) - 2b\dot{y}_2 - b^2 y_2, \tag{28}$$

integrated as six first-order ODEs; the LFP proxy is $v = y_1 - y_2$ [27]. Table 6 gives the reference column parameters. The synaptic rates correspond to excitatory and inhibitory decay times of 10 and 20 ms, while A and B set the postsynaptic-potential gains. The sigmoid parameters fix its voltage scale and rate ceiling; the sweeps vary the external rate p or connectivity C to change the operating state, as specified in Methods.

Table 6: Jansen–Rit parameters [27].

Symbol	Meaning	Value
A, B	excit./inhib. PSP gain	3.25, 22 mV
a, b	synaptic rates	100, 50 s^{-1}
v_0, e_0, ρ	sigmoid inflection, max rate/2, slope	6 mV, 2.5 s^{-1}, 0.56 mV^{-1}
C	global connectivity	135
C_1, C_2, C_3, C_4	couplings	C, $0.8C$, $0.25C$, $0.25C$
p	external input (bifurcation knob)	0–400 Hz

B.1 Compartment access and the passive-cable estimate

The passive compartment equation $\mathsf{C}_m\dot{\mathbf{V}} + \mathsf{G}_m\mathbf{V} = \mathbf{I}^0 - \mathbf{p}_E E$ [30] gives the voltage perturbation $\delta\mathbf{V}(\omega) = -(\mathsf{G}_m + i\omega\mathsf{C}_m)^{-1}\mathbf{p}_E E(\omega)$, where $i^2 = -1$. In SI units, $\mathbf{V}$ contains the compartment membrane potentials (V), C_m and G_m are the capacitance (F) and conductance (S) matrices, $\mathbf{I}^0$ is the endogenous current (A), and $\mathbf{p}_E$ is the field-to-current coupling (A per V/m).

Geometry can also alter the relevant response mode. For a passive cable, the magnitude of the frequency-dependent space constant is

$$\ell(\omega) = \ell_0(1 + \omega^2\tau_m^2)^{-1/4}, \tag{29}$$

where ℓ_0 is its static value. At 1 kHz and $\tau_m = 16$ ms, this length is about one tenth of its static value, so compartments that are strongly coupled at low frequency can respond differently to the carrier. A somatic charging time alone therefore does not determine every extracellular-field response mode. For a sufficiently long passive cable with a sealed end in a uniform axial field, the end polarization is proportional to this space constant. Each carrier then acquires the factor $(1 + \omega^2\tau_m^2)^{-1/4}$, so the quadratic beat is attenuated by $(1 + \omega_c^2\tau_m^2)^{-1/2}$, about 10^{-2} at 1 kHz and 10^{-3} at 10 kHz for 16 ms. These differ from the point-membrane estimates; soma loading and finite cable length further change the transfer. These distinct modes motivate the compartment-specific access hypothesis; their implications for TI are considered in §5.

B.2 Single-cell rate and dynamic MPR mixing

The MPR steady-rate curve F of §2.1, Eq. (5), averages the single-neuron rate $\tilde{f}(q) = \sqrt{q}/\pi$ for $q > 0$, and $\tilde{f}(q) = 0$ otherwise, over the excitability distribution. Here η is the neuron's excitability and $q = \eta + I$ its constant total drive.

The coefficient in Eq. (11) follows by expanding about the fixed point $(\tilde{r}^*, v^*)$, with $v^* = -d/2$, in membrane-time units. The Jacobian and unit-current phasor are

$$\mathsf{J} = \begin{pmatrix} 2v^* & 2\tilde{r}^* \\ -2\pi^2\tilde{r}^* & 2v^* \end{pmatrix}, \qquad \mathbf{h} = (i\tilde{\omega}\mathsf{I}_2 - \mathsf{J})^{-1}\begin{pmatrix} 0 \\ 1 \end{pmatrix},$$

where I_2 is the identity matrix and the first-order response is $I_{\mathrm{ac}}\,\mathrm{Re}(\mathbf{h}e^{i\tilde{\omega}\tilde{t}})$. Writing h_r, h_v for its rate and voltage components, with an overbar denoting complex conjugation and Re the real part, the carrier-averaged quadratic source per I_{ac}^2 is

$$\mathbf{b}_2 = \begin{pmatrix} \mathrm{Re}(h_r\overline{h_v}) \\ (|h_v|^2 - \pi^2|h_r|^2)/2 \end{pmatrix}.$$

The mean second-order correction is $-I_{\mathrm{ac}}^2\mathsf{J}^{-1}\mathbf{b}_2$; its rate component gives Eq. (11).

C The cubic Hopf normal form lacks a quadratic mixer

The Stuart–Landau equation [37]

$$\dot{z} = (\alpha + i\omega_0)z - |z|^2 z + \mathcal{F}(t), \qquad \gamma = -\alpha > 0, \tag{30}$$

uses seconds for time and a normalized complex mode z, with the cubic coefficient set to 1 s^{-1}. Its linear growth rate is $\alpha = -\gamma$; γ has units s^{-1}. The mode has damping γ and natural angular frequency ω_0, driven by the applied input $\mathcal{F}$ (normalized mode units per second). For a weak input $\mathcal{F} = \varepsilon_{\mathrm{SL}}\psi_{\mathrm{SL}}(t)$ with dimensionless waveform ψ_{SL} on the stable side, the perturbative response has the form $z = \varepsilon_{\mathrm{SL}} z_1 + \varepsilon_{\mathrm{SL}}^3 z_3 + \cdots$. There is no second-order source: the first-order response contains only the applied frequencies, and the cubic first contributes at order $\varepsilon_{\mathrm{SL}}^3$. Thus the normal form has a resonant linear susceptibility but lacks the quadratic difference-frequency generation of Eq. (10). This statement concerns the weak-input expansion; it is not an exclusion of every higher-order intermodulation or strong-drive response.

In the numerical control ($\alpha = -0.5$ s^{-1}, $f_0 = 10$ Hz, $f_c = 100$ Hz, $\varepsilon_{\mathrm{SL}} = 0.5$ s^{-1}), a square-law detector gives a beat-frequency lock-in amplitude of 2.5×10^{-1}, while $\mathrm{Re}\, z$ gives approximately 2×10^{-8}, at the numerical floor. Driving the same mode directly in band recovers the forced $1/\gamma$ growth. The control separates resonant amplification from the nonlinear source required to drive it at the beat.

D Efficiency of a memoryless transfer against a direct in-band drive

For the logistic family of memoryless transfers, compare balanced TI tones of polarization amplitude ε each with a direct in-band drive of amplitude 2ε, matching peak polarization. Their leading drive amplitudes are $|\sigma''|\varepsilon^2/2$ and $2\sigma'\varepsilon$, so $\mathcal{R}_{\mathrm{det}} \simeq |\sigma''|\varepsilon/(4\sigma')$. The weak-input formula concerns the logistic family. The step-mixture argument below extends the exact carrier-averaged bound to bounded nondecreasing memoryless transfers, with the same operating point, matched peak polarization, and open-loop readout. It does not cover the dynamic detector of §2.3.

Writing $\zeta = \sigma/(2e_0) \in (0,1)$ gives $\sigma' = 2e_0\rho\zeta(1-\zeta)$ and $\sigma'' = 2e_0\rho^2\zeta(1-\zeta)(1-2\zeta)$. Since $|\mathrm{PEIX}| = 1 - 4\zeta(1-\zeta) = (1-2\zeta)^2$, the leading ratio satisfies

$$\mathcal{R}_{\mathrm{det}} \simeq \frac{\rho\,\varepsilon}{4}\sqrt{|\mathrm{PEIX}|} \;\le\; \frac{\rho\,\varepsilon}{4}. \tag{31}$$

It vanishes at the inflection, where the quadratic coefficient is zero, and approaches its bound in the saturated tails. This maximizes a ratio rather than an absolute response: both drives vanish in those tails. For the JR slope $\rho = 0.56\ \mathrm{mV}^{-1}$, the perturbative bound is 1.4% at $\varepsilon = 0.1$ mV and 0.28% at $\varepsilon = 0.02$ mV.

The slope is itself a parameter, so the question is what the whole sigmoid family can do. The logistic transfer depends on voltage only through $\rho(v - v_0)$, so writing

$$u = \rho\,\varepsilon, \qquad \xi = \rho\,(v^* - v_0), \tag{32}$$

we have $\sigma(v^* + \varepsilon\psi(t)) = 2e_0\,L(\xi + u\,\psi(t))$ for any normalized waveform ψ, with $L(\xi) = (1+e^{-\xi})^{-1}$. Every Fourier amplitude, and hence their ratio, is a function of (u,ξ) alone; the factor $2e_0$ cancels. Maximizing over v^* and ρ at fixed ε is therefore the same as maximizing over (u,ξ), and the family supremum is independent of field strength. Evaluating the exact cycle response rather than its quadratic truncation and optimizing ξ at each u, the ratio rises monotonically over the range explored and converges to the hard-threshold limit

$$\sup_{\rho,\,v^*} \mathcal{R}_{\mathrm{det}} \approx 0.3479, \tag{33}$$

approached as $\rho \to \infty$ at a threshold offset δ (the distance from the operating point to the inflection) with $\delta/2\varepsilon = 0.523$. There is no finite optimal transfer width: narrower is always better, and reaching 95% of the ceiling requires $u \gtrsim 6$, that is $1/\rho \lesssim \varepsilon/6$.

Such a detector is not weak. At the optimum, and at the illustrative fast-access polarization $\varepsilon \simeq 0.1$ mV of §5, its open-loop beat drive exceeds the physiological-slope sigmoid's by some three orders of magnitude for the same e_0 and waveform, because the field excursion is about twice the threshold offset and the transfer switches across its full range instead of responding linearly. The disparity grows as the field weakens, the smooth sigmoid's response falling as ε^2 while a threshold repositioned with the field keeps its excursion.

The obstacle is the width. At $\varepsilon = 0.1$ mV the ceiling is approached only for $1/\rho \lesssim 17\ \mu$V; at $\varepsilon = 0.02$ mV the corresponding width is about 3 μV. Both follow from $1/\rho \lesssim \varepsilon/6$, with the threshold offset held to the same order as the applied polarization. A population sigmoid averages the spread of thresholds and noise; the JR voltage scale is $1/\rho \approx 1.8$ mV [27]. A microvolt width lies far below that and reads as an idealized microscopic threshold or rectifier rather than as a neural-mass sigmoid; real thresholds are themselves noisy and state-dependent, so it is not a measured single-cell property either. The regime in which the family approaches its ceiling is thus one in which the "population sigmoid" has ceased to describe a population.

The limit is a step detector, not an envelope follower. For a unit step at offset δ the carrier-averaged transduction is $\pi^{-1}\arccos(\delta/\mathcal{A})$ for $\mathcal{A} > \delta$ and zero below; with $\beta = \delta/2\varepsilon$ its tACS fundamental is $(2/\pi)\sqrt{1-\beta^2}$ and its TI coefficient reduces by parts to $\mathcal{R}_{\mathrm{det}} = 2\beta\,[\mathsf{K}(k_{\mathrm{ell}}^2) - \mathsf{E}(k_{\mathrm{ell}}^2)]/(\pi\sqrt{1-\beta^2})$

with elliptic parameter $k_{\mathrm{ell}}^2 = 1 - \beta^2$ and K, E the complete elliptic integrals, giving 0.3479 at $\beta = 0.523$ by direct quadrature and by the elliptic form alike (`threshold_bound_check.py`). At that optimum the step's second-to-first harmonic magnitude ratio is 0.151, not the 1/5 of a linear envelope follower. A bounded nondecreasing transfer is, up to a constant, a positive mixture of shifted steps. Both signed Fourier coefficients are linear in the transfer, and each step's direct-drive coefficient is nonnegative. The triangle inequality therefore bounds the mixture's amplitude ratio by the largest step ratio, whenever the denominator is nonzero. This extends the result beyond the logistic family; the maximum itself is a numerical evaluation, not a certified bound.

E Extension: the laminar column at low carriers

The two-band laminar column (LaNMM, §2.1) adds a resonant intermediary between the field and the slow generator. These sweeps use 25–80 Hz carriers and polarizations up to 3 mV on P_2, exceeding the sigmoid scale $1/\rho \approx 1.8$ mV. They describe nonlinear frequency selection below TI's kHz range. The weak-field square law is tested separately in JR at 0.05–0.2 mV, one to two orders of magnitude below that scale (Fig. 7b).

E.1 Model and measurements

We complement the single-column analysis with simulations of the laminar neural mass model (LaNMM) of §2.1. We integrate the full 28-variable column [24, 32], with the field entering as in the single JR column, as a membrane polarization added inside the sigmoid argument of the target population. Its output rate φ_X (s^{-1}) is

$$\varphi_X(t) = \sigma\big(v_X(t) + s(t)\big), \qquad X \in \{P_1, P_2\}, \tag{34}$$

with $s(t)$ the AM or two-tone field of §2.2 (amplitude ε in mV, beat $\Omega = 2\pi\Delta f$, carrier $\omega_c = 2\pi f_c$) and all three external drives held flat at their baselines (Fig. S2). A perturbation of an external input *rate* would require clipping at zero once its excursion exceeds the baseline, and a hard clip is a half-wave rectifier—a diode detector placed upstream of the sigmoid, which would inject a line at Δf into the drive before the population nonlinearity received it. A signed membrane polarization carries no such constraint and none is applied. Because the LaNMM and JR sigmoids share the voltage scale $1/\rho \approx 1.8$ mV, ε is directly comparable between the two models.

Integration is a vectorized fixed-step RK4 ($\Delta t = 10^{-4}$ s) advancing the whole parameter grid simultaneously, as in the JR sweeps. The maps report the alpha-band (8–12 Hz) power of the P_1 and P_2 membrane potentials as the mean squared magnitude of the Hann-windowed fast Fourier transform (FFT) over the band, in arbitrary units, over a post-transient window. This measure includes autonomous and driven activity and does not isolate a phase-coherent response to stimulation.

Two sweeps probe the column: an amplitude–beat sweep over $(\varepsilon, \Delta f)$ at fixed carrier, and a carrier–beat sweep over $(f_c, \Delta f)$ at fixed ε, built on the LaNMM module of [24]. The maps (Figs. S1, S7) show the *signed* stimulation-induced change, alpha power minus the unstimulated ($\varepsilon = 0$) baseline, on a zero-centered scale; over most of the P_1-driven grids the change is negative. For the alpha resonance we instead drive the deep P_1 loop directly and sweep its input against Δf, reading the lock-in (Eq. (24)) of v_{P_1} at Δf.

The additional carrier comparison below uses the lock-in of v_{P_1}, averaged at each carrier over 17 beats: 7–9 and 12.25–14 Hz in 0.25 Hz steps. These lie more than 1.5 Hz from the field-free alpha peak near 10.6 Hz. We denote this arithmetic mean by $S(f_c)$. The carrier grid is 25–80 Hz in 1 Hz steps, with equal tone amplitudes $\varepsilon = 1.5$ mV for P_2 drive and 0.5 mV for P_1 drive. After 2 s of settling, we compare 3 and 10 s measurement windows. Field-free controls give mean background amplitudes of 0.0048 and 0.0012 mV over the same beats. This background includes a persistent component near 8 Hz, so it is not solely finite-window leakage. The statistic compares carrier profiles within each drive condition; the unequal amplitudes do not support a direct sensitivity comparison between targets.

E.2 Frequency selection and carrier dependence

Driving either population with the two-tone field of Eq. (34) and reading alpha-band power in the deep (P_1, alpha) and superficial (P_2, gamma) pyramidal potentials recovers the beat resonance (§E.1, Fig. S2). Direct P_1 drive reproduces the JR alpha-band resonance on both stable-focus and limit-cycle sides; that sweep and its code are in the repository. The additional result is carrier selectivity through the coupled gamma circuit.

Table 7: LaNMM carrier profiles measured away from alpha. $S(f_c)$ is the mean lock-in amplitude of v_{P_1} over the 17 beats specified in §E.1. Percentages are normalized to each row's own carrier maximum; the range and median use carriers from 30 to 80 Hz.

Drive	Window	Peak S (mV)	Peak f_c (Hz)	Range (%)	Median (%)
P_2, 1.5 mV	3 s	0.450	39	23–100	42
P_2, 1.5 mV	10 s	0.450	39	23–100	42
P_1, 0.5 mV	3 s	0.092	25	42–68	53
P_1, 0.5 mV	10 s	0.091	25	42–67	52

Sweeping the field amplitude ε and beat frequency Δf at a fixed carrier produces a region of enhanced alpha-band power: the response in P_1 is largest when Δf matches the deep alpha (∼10 Hz) and grows with ε (Figs. S1a,b and S7a,b). The dominant-frequency contours identify where the output is close to the beat, without establishing phase locking of the autonomous rhythm. Away from the enhancement region the drive *reduces* alpha-band power: with the field on P_1, 95% of the amplitude–beat grid and 97% of the carrier–beat grid lie below the field-free baseline (Fig. S7), the drive pulling the autonomous alpha out of the 8–12 Hz band or suppressing it; with the field on P_2 the fractions are 44% and 31% (Fig. S1).

The carrier dependence illustrates the two coupling limits of §2.2–§2.8 within this model's 25–80 Hz carrier range. When the field is delivered to the superficial loop (P_2), alpha-band power enhancement in P_1 is largest in the gamma carrier band with Δf near the P_1 alpha (Fig. S1c,d). At $\Delta f = 10$ Hz, the carrier maximum is 44 Hz. This selectivity is consistent with a double resonance: the fast loop acts as a tuned radio-frequency (RF) front end whose dynamics affect the carrier dependence of the deep response. With direct P_1 drive, a ridge near the column's own alpha persists across the carrier range (Fig. S7c). That ridge contains autonomous activity and is not a measurement of the demodulated component alone.

The lock-in also contains the autonomous rhythm when the beat is close to alpha; its maximum over beats cannot isolate the driven response. We therefore compare the off-alpha statistic $S(f_c)$ defined in §E.1 (Table 7). With P_2 drive it peaks near 39 Hz and falls to about 16–17% of that peak at a 25 Hz carrier. With P_1 drive it peaks at 25 Hz and spans about 42–68% of that peak over 30–80 Hz. These are properties of the specified amplitudes and beat average, not universal carrier-rejection factors. Single-beat profiles have deeper minima, including a dip near a 45 Hz carrier under direct P_1 drive: the gamma circuit can affect the response in either stimulation condition.

The carrier peaks and aggregate ranges persist with the longer window, although individual normalized values change by up to 3.1 percentage points for P_2 drive and 9.6 for P_1 drive. The smallest S exceeds its mean field-free background by factors of about 16 and 8, respectively, with the 3 s window, and 62 and 32 with 10 s. Some individual beat–carrier points remain near or below background; the comparison concerns the mean over beats, not each grid point. TI's kHz carriers lie outside this model's range. Within it, the carrier can excite a network mode and affect the detected response, qualifying the inert-carrier limit of §2.7 and linking it to frequency-tagging and intermodulation paradigms [60].

Within the 25–80 Hz carrier range and at the finite polarizations used here, the LaNMM shows alpha-band power changes concentrated near the intrinsic alpha, amplitude-dependent widening of the frequency-dominance region, and enhanced responses when superficial drive passes through the gamma circuit. The power maps include autonomous and driven activity; they do not isolate TI efficacy. The gamma-carrier preference, around 40 Hz rather than kHz, remains a separate prediction to test. Esmaeilpour et al. [6] swept 0.1–2 kHz carriers at a fixed 5 Hz beat against carbachol-induced gamma, finding decreasing sensitivity with carrier frequency. Those carriers did not sample the gamma band. Violante et al. [45] also used a fixed 5 Hz beat. Neither study tests

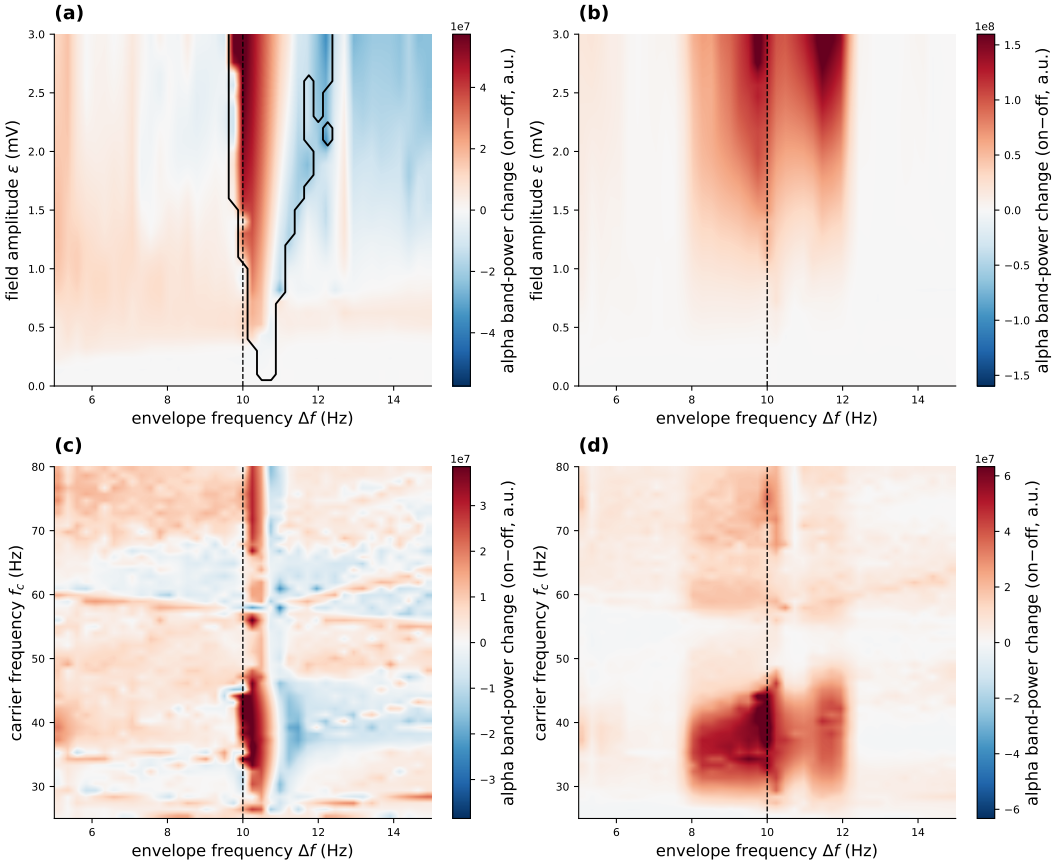


Figure S1: LaNMM frequency selection: two-tone TI field on the superficial P_2 (gamma) loop. The field enters the P_2 sigmoid argument as a membrane polarization ε (mV) with all external drives flat. Color shows the signed change of alpha-band (8–12 Hz) power from the unstimulated $\varepsilon = 0$ baseline, on a zero-centered scale (arbitrary units). *(a,b)* P_1 and P_2 enhancement vs. ε and Δf (carrier 40 Hz), peaking at the P_1 alpha (10.0 Hz, dashed). The black contour in *(a)* is the frequency-dominance set $|f_{\text{out}} - \Delta f| < 0.3$ Hz (Appendix F), drawn because band power alone cannot separate a driven from an autonomous rhythm; it is a dominance screen, not a phase-capture test. The $\varepsilon = 0$ row is excluded, since with no drive the autonomous 10.67 Hz alpha already lies within the tolerance of two grid points (a resolution floor of 0.5 Hz); the set widens to 2.75 Hz at 3 mV. *(c,d)* Enhancement vs. carrier and Δf at $\varepsilon = 1.5$ mV: P_1 alpha-band enhancement is largest in the gamma carrier band with Δf near the P_1 alpha. At $\Delta f = 10$ Hz, the carrier maximum is 44 Hz. The field-free P_2 gamma peak is near 39.7 Hz; the finite-drive maximum need not coincide with it.

this low-carrier resonance prediction.

F Vocabulary and metrics

Forced response. Below the Hopf the column does not oscillate on its own; we quantify its response by the lock-in amplitude at the beat Δf (Eq. (24)). There is no autonomous rhythm to entrain in the stable-focus J-curve, timing, and tACS sweeps.

Frequency dominance and entrainment. Above the Hopf the column free-runs at f_0. A 1:1 phase-capture test would follow the unwrapped phase difference from the drive and require absence of secular drift. Our maps instead report $|f_{\text{out}} - \Delta f| < 0.3$ Hz, where f_{out} is the largest non-DC FFT peak. This is a frequency-dominance screen: a forced component can outgrow a persisting autonomous one without capturing it. When the components coexist, instantaneous-phase estimates also require their separation [61]. The maps therefore identify a dominance region, not a measured Arnold tongue.

Beat-locked rate and gating. Gating means that the amplitude of a persisting rhythm is modulated by the beat without frequency capture [38, 39]. The QIF statistic used here is the lock-in of the population rate r_E at Δf, complemented by the rate folded on beat phase over whole cycles. It measures beat-locked firing. A raw rate fold does not extract the gamma amplitude, and sidebands can arise from amplitude or phase modulation. The above-Hopf QIF panels therefore establish coexistence and mixing of the beat and gamma rhythms; a gamma-amplitude estimate would be needed to identify gating specifically.

The protocol for Fig. S4 places the column on the limit-cycle side (input p on the stable alpha-cycle branch below its upper Hopf), drives it with $s(t) = \varepsilon \cos \Omega t$, and records the dominant frequency. Grid widths and the clipping check are specified in the code. As the Hopf is approached, the autonomous cycle shrinks and the frequency-dominance region broadens in these simulations. Its width and the stable-focus susceptibility describe different responses; their increase near onset does not make them the same quantity.

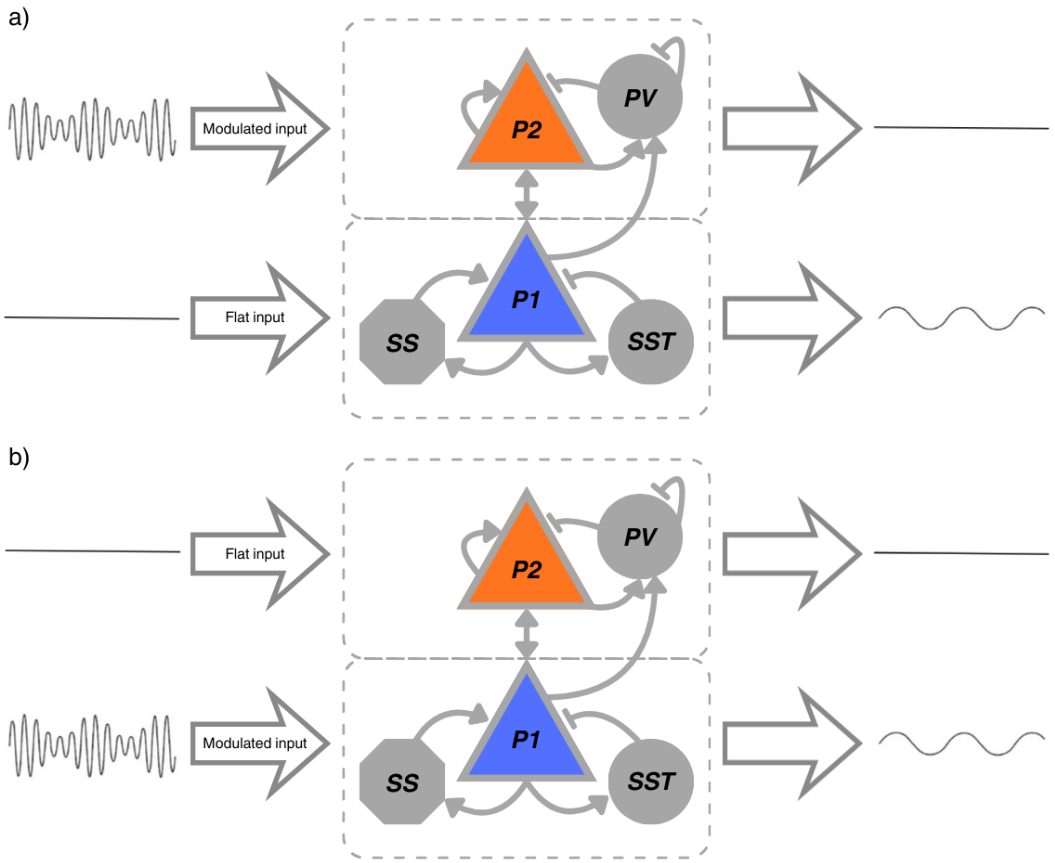


Figure S2: Stimulation setup in a LaNMM column. The column couples a superficial PING subcircuit (pyramidal P_2 + PV; gamma) and a deep JR subcircuit (pyramidal P_1 + SS + SST; alpha). *(a)* the TI field drives P_2 while P_1 receives a flat drive; *(b)* the TI field drives P_1 while P_2 is flat. Through the sigmoid nonlinearities and P_1–P_2 coupling, the generated beat-frequency component is transferred to the deep loop: P_2 carries the modulated fast carrier, while P_1 exposes the recovered low-frequency component (right traces).

G Supplementary figures

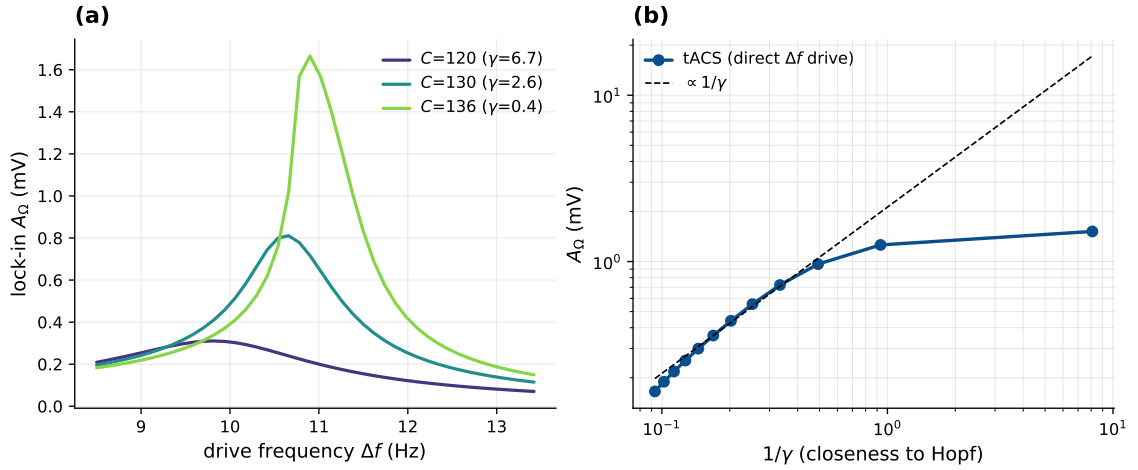


Figure S3: tACS shares the network amplifier (Jansen–Rit). A direct low-frequency (tACS) drive at Δf enters the column without a carrier, so it needs no demodulation, but feeds the same near-Hopf resonator. With the field-free operating point pinned, sweeping the coupling C toward the alpha Hopf: *(a)* the lock-in resonance at Δf sharpens and grows as $C \to C^*$; *(b)* the response grows as $1/\gamma$ (dashed) and saturates near criticality—the same network amplification as the demodulated TI drive (Fig. 9). The leading tACS response is linear in the field; the TI beat is quadratic. Their response ratio is independent of damping in linear response and changes at the finite amplitudes nearest the Hopf (§4.6). Here $\gamma > 0$ describes the field-free state.

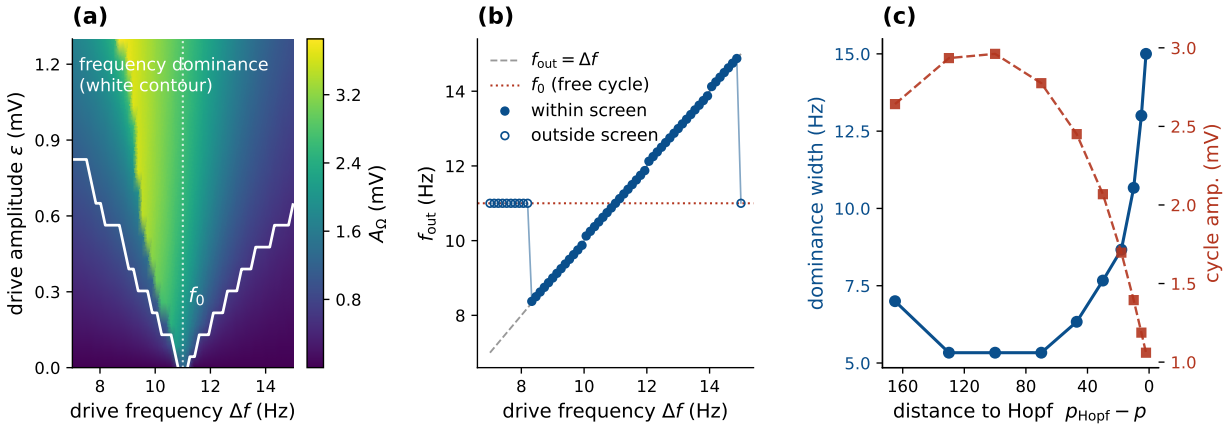


Figure S4: Frequency dominance in the driven autonomous Jansen–Rit column. The column is set in its autonomous alpha limit cycle ($p = 250$, $f_0 \approx 11$ Hz) and driven by a direct in-band sinusoid. *(a)* The set $|f_{out} - \Delta f| < 0.3$ Hz forms a wedge near f_0 that widens with drive. It screens for phase capture but does not establish it. *(b)* Inside this region the dominant frequency follows Δf; outside, it remains near f_0. *(c)* Toward the Hopf at fixed drive the dominance width grows as the autonomous cycle amplitude vanishes (blue, left axis; red dashed, right axis). Above the Hopf this width describes frequency selection in a driven autonomous oscillator; it is distinct from the linear susceptibility of the stable-focus side (Fig. 9). Both diagnostics increase toward criticality in these sweeps.

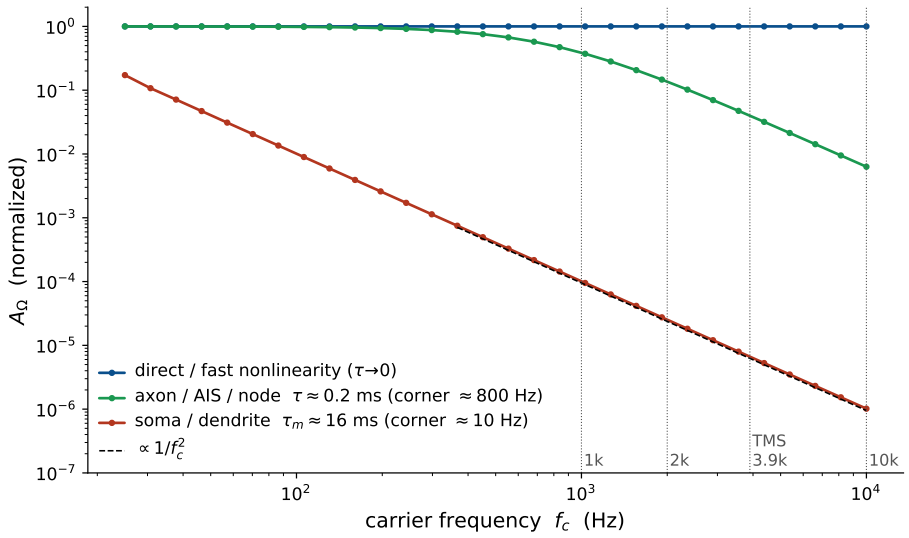


Figure S5: Carrier attenuation depends on the assumed access time (Jansen–Rit, open loop). Open-loop demodulated response (normalized to the $\tau \to 0$ value) vs. carrier frequency up to 10 kHz. With direct coupling ($\tau \to 0$) the response is flat—carrier-independent. A slow somatic membrane ($\tau_m \approx 16$ ms) rolls off as $1/f_c^2$ (dashed guide); the assumed fast response ($\tau = 0.2$ ms) retains about 0.14 of the direct response at 2 kHz and 0.04 at 3.9 kHz. These are sensitivity cases, not measurements of anatomical compartments.

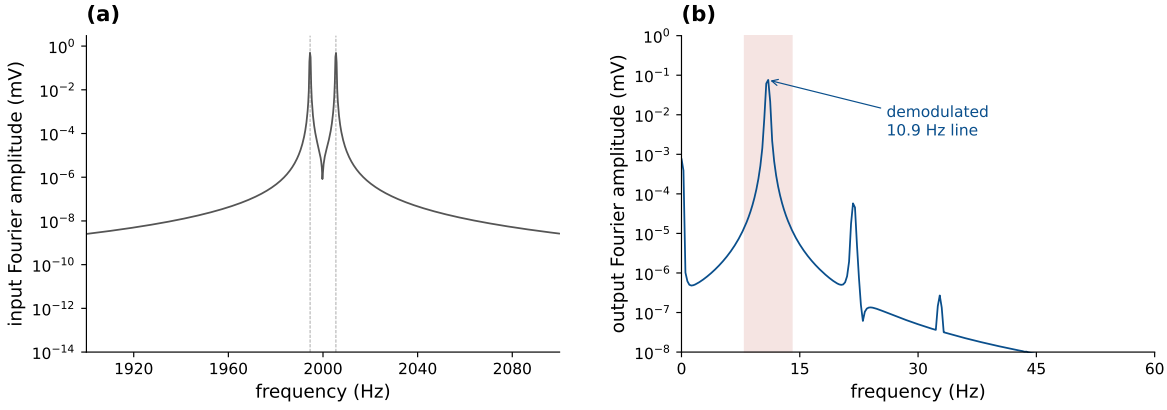


Figure S6: Two-tone TI at a kHz carrier (Jansen–Rit, assumed fast access). Two equal tones at $f_1 = 1994.543$ and $f_2 = 2005.457$ Hz, beating at 10.914 Hz, pass through the assumed low-pass ($\tau = 0.2$ ms) into the recurrent column. *(a)* The input amplitude spectrum has lines only at f_1 and f_2; in the 8–14 Hz band its maximum is 2.2×10^{-13} mV. *(b)* The output carries a demodulated line at the beat, 10.9 Hz.

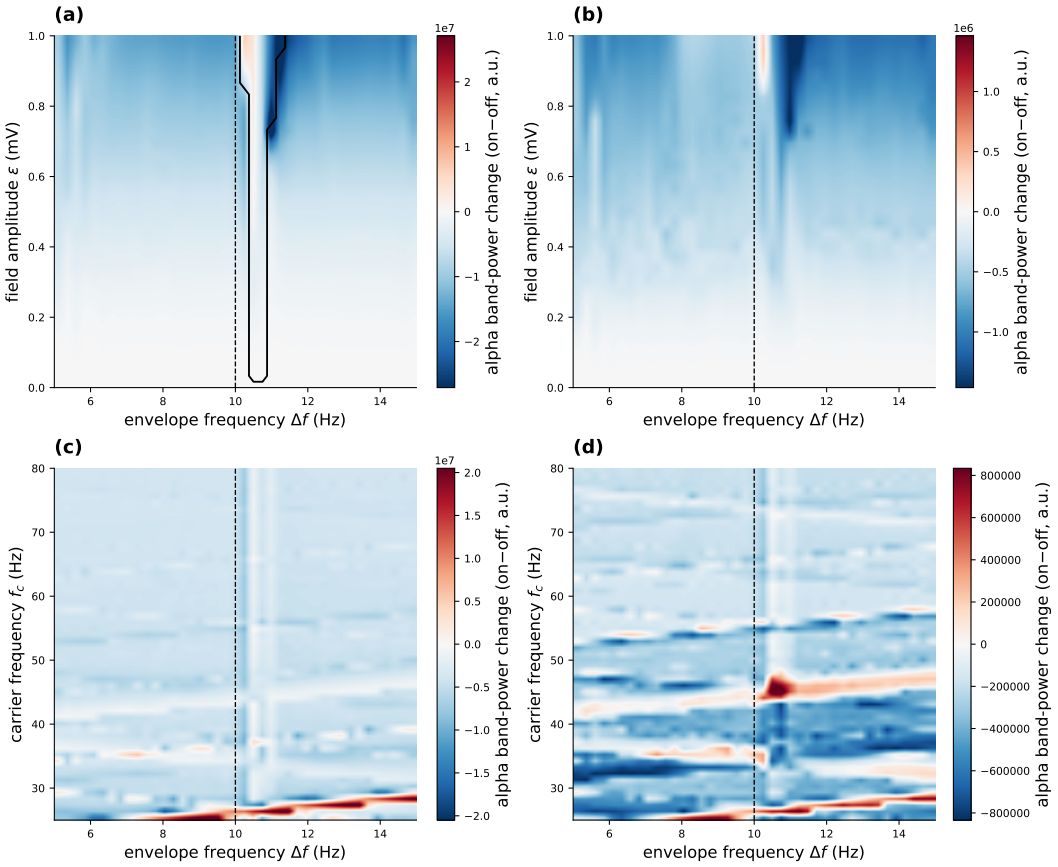


Figure S7: LaNMM frequency selection: two-tone TI field delivered directly to the deep P_1 (alpha) loop. As Fig. S1 but with the field on P_1. The deep loop shows frequency dominance at smaller fields, so the amplitude range is $\varepsilon \leq 1$ mV here against 3 mV there. These finite-amplitude maps extend beyond the perturbative regime of the theory. Color: signed change of alpha-band power from the $\varepsilon = 0$ baseline, zero-centered; most of the grid is suppression. *(a,b)* P_1 and P_2 enhancement vs. ε and Δf; the black contour in *(a)* outlines the frequency-dominance set $|f_{\text{out}} - \Delta f| < 0.3$ Hz (Appendix F), computed from the dominant output frequency because band power alone cannot separate a driven from an autonomous rhythm; the $\varepsilon = 0$ row is excluded (resolution floor 0.5 Hz). The set widens to 1.25 Hz at $\varepsilon = 1$ mV. *(c,d)* Enhancement vs. carrier frequency and Δf at $\varepsilon = 0.5$ mV. The ridge near alpha persists across the carrier band and includes the autonomous rhythm. A separate lock-in comparison away from alpha, including its window and background controls, is given in Table 7; these panels show band-power changes.

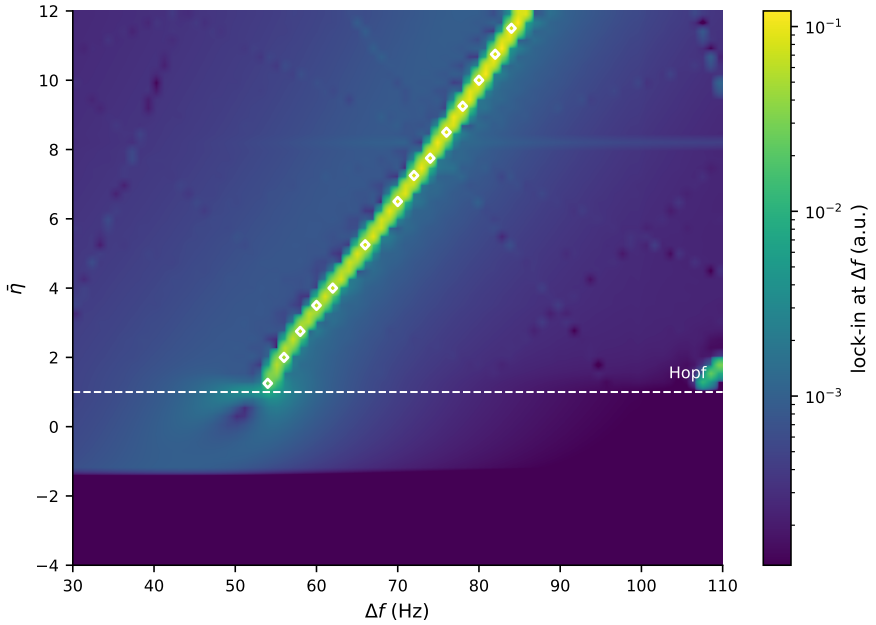


Figure S8: NMM2 PING resonance map (exact mean field). Demodulated response over the (Δf, background drive $\bar{\eta}$) plane, log color scale. The ridge follows the gamma natural frequency, with f_0 rising with $\bar{\eta}$ for these parameters. White markers outline the frequency-dominance set (Appendix F), drawn only above the Hopf (dashed line) where there is an autonomous rhythm to capture; below it the same color field is a forced response. The markers do not establish phase capture. Lock-in amplitude cannot separate driven and autonomous contributions, since both can place power at Δf.

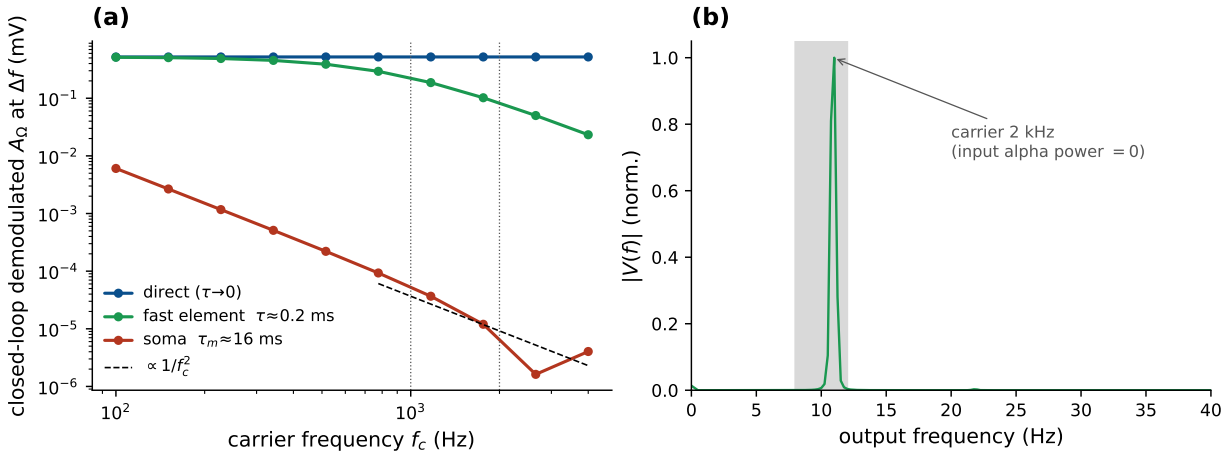


Figure S9: Demodulation at a kHz carrier (Jansen–Rit, closed loop). The applied field passes through an explicit membrane filter before the sigmoid. *(a)* Closed-loop demodulated A_Ω at $\Delta f = f_0$ vs. carrier f_c for three access models: direct ($\tau \to 0$, carrier-independent), fast ($\tau = 0.2$ ms), and somatic ($\tau_m = 16$ ms; $1/f_c^2$ roll-off). The fast time is assumed rather than assigned to a measured compartment. *(b)* Output spectrum for a 2 kHz carrier delivered through the fast element: an alpha line at f_0, synthesized by the column although the input carries no alpha power.

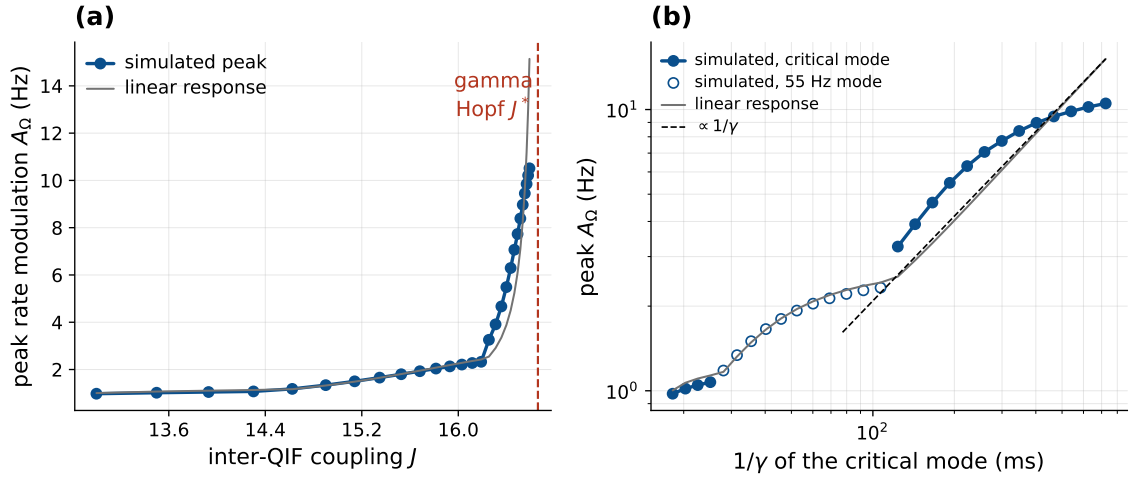


Figure S10: Coupling controls the amplification in the exact mean field (NMM2 PING, gamma). J is the inter-QIF synaptic weight; the sweep is unpinned at $\bar{\eta} = 0$ and uses the AM surrogate with $A_f = 8$. *(a)* Simulated peak of r_E (blue) and the linear reference (gray), scaled to the median measured gain over $14.5 < J < 16$. The reference includes the second-order carrier source; its nearby-carrier approximation changes the AM peak gain by less than 0.1%. The red dashed line marks the field-free Hopf. *(b)* The same responses against inverse damping of the critical mode, tracked continuously from the Hopf. Symbols are filled where that mode carries the linear peak and open where the second mode near 55 Hz does ($14.6 \lesssim J \lesssim 16.2$). The dashed $1/\gamma$ guide is anchored at the last linear-response point. The critical-mode gain follows it near the Hopf; the simulated response first exceeds and then falls below it at this amplitude. At a 50.5 Hz beat, the endpoint is attracting for both waveforms: the AM multiplier is 0.034 over 2 s, and two-tone perturbations decay at -0.0014 ms^{-1}. Both coupling and rectifier are derived from the QIF network.

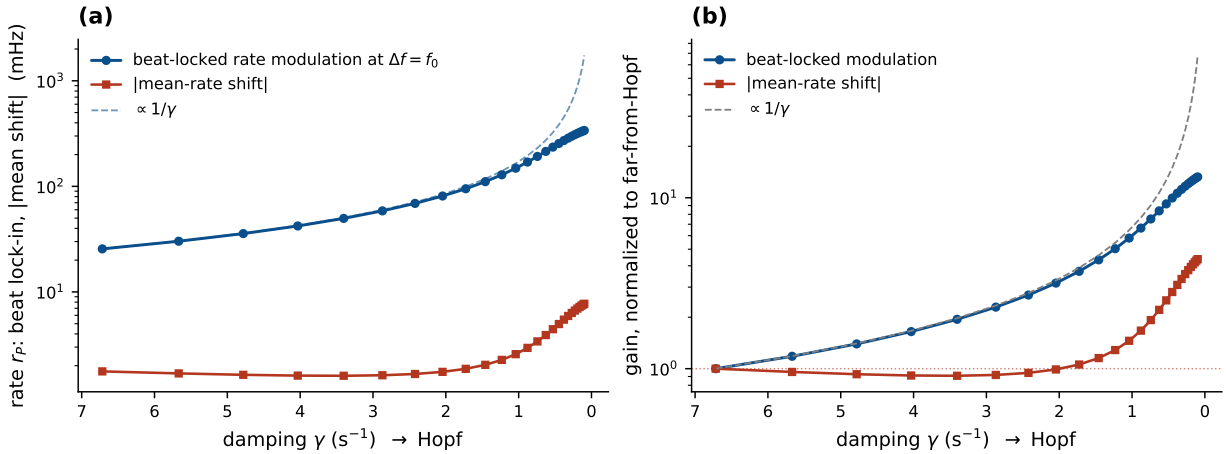


Figure S11: Envelope-locked modulation against mean-rate shift (Jansen–Rit, detection pinned). As the column is driven toward the Hopf (from the stable side, $\gamma > 0$) through the coupling at fixed $\sigma''(v^*)$, both quantities are read from the pyramidal rate $r_P = \sigma(v + s)$, in mHz. *(a)* The beat-locked modulation at $\Delta f = f_0$ (blue) is resonantly amplified and tracks $1/\gamma$ (dashed) before saturating; the magnitude of the mean-rate shift (red) stays at a few mHz and rises near the Hopf. *(b)* Both normalized to their far-from-Hopf values (log scale): the modulation grows 13.2× and the mean-shift magnitude 4.4× across the sweep. The input has two genuine tones. Modulation exceeds the mean shift by 14.5× far from the Hopf; the ratio peaks at 58× near $\gamma = 1$ s^{-1} and falls to 44× at the nearest point as the amplified oscillation rectifies. The AM surrogate gives 19, 66, and 45×, respectively.

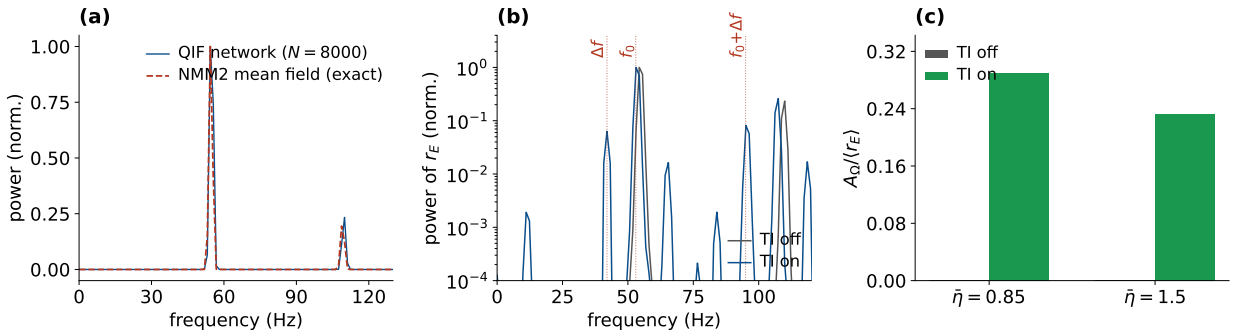


Figure S12: Beat-locked modulation and mean-rate change in the QIF network. *(a)* Field-free power spectrum of $r_E(t)$, normalized: the spiking network ($N = 8000$) matches the exact NMM2 mean field in gamma frequency (∼55 Hz); a normalized spectrum does not test the mean rate. *(b)* Intermodulation above the Hopf (TI off vs. on, log power): the nonlinearity mixes the imposed $\Delta f = 42$ Hz beat with the persisting gamma near 53–54 Hz, raising the direct Δf line and the sum sideband near 95 Hz, both absent with TI off. These sidebands establish nonlinear mixing; they do not uniquely identify gamma-amplitude gating. *(c)* The Δf modulation depth $A_\Omega/\langle r_E \rangle$, off vs. on: below 0.003 rising to 0.29 ($\bar{\eta} = 0.85$) and 0.23 ($\bar{\eta} = 1.5$), while the mean rate rises by about 8–11%. The labels identify field-free states; both field-on responses contain gamma activity beyond the beat component. Spectra use the same post-settling windows as the rate measurements and are normalized to each spectrum's maximum. Modulation depth is reported rather than the off→on lock-in ratio, whose denominator is the field-free floor.

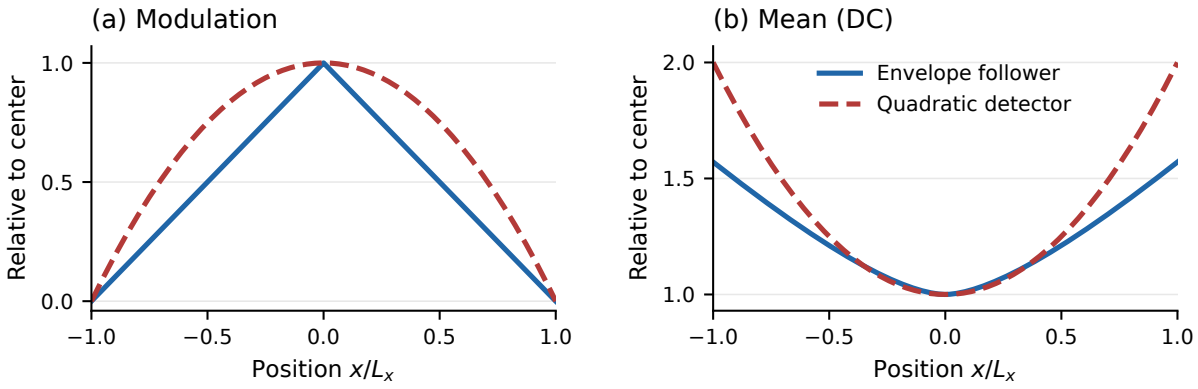


Figure S13: Envelope and quadratic spatial maps. Illustrative line profile: $\varepsilon_1(x) = \varepsilon_0(1 + x/L_x)$ and $\varepsilon_2(x) = \varepsilon_0(1 - x/L_x)$ on $-L_x \le x \le L_x$, with polarization scale $\varepsilon_0 > 0$ (mV) and length $L_x > 0$ (m). Each curve is divided by its own value at $x = 0$. *(a)* Modulation is $1 - |x/L_x|$ for envelope following and $1 - (x/L_x)^2$ for quadratic detection: both peak centrally, but the quadratic profile is broader here. *(b)* Both means increase toward the edges. This is a line profile, not a head model or a demonstration of three-dimensional focusing.